

The Satanic Verses



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF SALMAN RUSHDIE

Salman Rushdie was born into a liberal Muslim family in Bombay (present-day Mumbai). He received his education in England at Rugby School and later at King's College, Cambridge. In England, he developed a deep love for English literature while also facing a fair degree of racial prejudice. After graduating, Rushdie worked as an advertising copywriter in London while pursuing his passion for writing. His first novel, *Grimus* (1975), garnered little attention, but his second, [Midnight's Children](#) (1981), won the Booker Prize and established him as a leading voice in postcolonial literature. In 1988, Rushdie published *The Satanic Verses*, a novel that ignited a global controversy due to its portrayal of Islam. The book, perceived as blasphemous by some in the Muslim world, sparked widespread protests. In 1989, Iran's Ayatollah Khomeini issued a fatwa calling for Rushdie's death, forcing him into hiding under police protection for several years. Despite the threats, Rushdie continued writing, producing works such as *The Moor's Last Sigh* (1995) and *Shalimar the Clown* (2005). Over time, the political climate shifted, and in 1998, the Iranian government distanced itself from the fatwa. However, on August 12, 2022, Salman Rushdie was attacked and stabbed multiple times, resulting in the loss of an eye and nearly the loss of his life as the result of the fatwa. Ultimately, Rushdie recovered and continued writing. His most recent work, *Knife* (2024), is a work of nonfiction in which he discusses the stabbing and the events that led to it.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

British colonialism plays a crucial role in the novel's thematic landscape. At its height, the British Empire controlled vast territories across Asia, Africa, and the Americas, including India, where Rushdie was born. The effects of colonial rule on the colonized peoples, particularly the cultural and religious impositions, are central to the novel. The story reflects the struggles of postcolonial societies as they grapple with their identities in the aftermath of colonial domination. The immigrant experience in Britain, depicted through characters like Saladin Chamcha, illustrates the ongoing tensions between former colonizers and the colonized. These characters navigate the complexities of identity and cultural assimilation in a postcolonial world, echoing the broader historical context of decolonization and the waves of migration that followed the collapse of the British Empire. Another pivotal historical event directly related to *The Satanic Verses* is the fatwa issued against Salman Rushdie by Iran's Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Khomeini,

on February 14, 1989. This religious edict accused Rushdie of blasphemy against Islam due to the novel's content and called for his death. The fatwa had immediate consequences, leading to violent protests, book burnings, and several assassination attempts on those associated with the book's publication. The international reaction to the fatwa highlighted the cultural and political divides between the West and the Islamic world. The incident became a symbol of the broader conflict over freedom of expression, religious sensitivity, and the rights of artists and writers to challenge religious dogma.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The Satanic Verses is deeply rooted in literary and religious traditions, drawing comparisons to a range of significant texts. At the heart of the novel is its controversial engagement with the Qur'an, the holy book of Islam. Rushdie's novel takes inspiration from the story of the so-called "satanic verses," a disputed episode in Islamic tradition where the Prophet Muhammad is said to have momentarily accepted verses that acknowledged pagan goddesses before retracting them, declaring them to have been inspired by Satan. This narrative, though not found in the Qur'an itself, appears in some early Islamic sources and has been a point of contention among scholars and believers. Rushdie's fictional exploration of this theme, coupled with his portrayal of a prophet-like character, led to accusations of blasphemy and fueled the intense backlash against the novel. Additionally, *The Satanic Verses* stands alongside other works of postcolonial literature that grapple with issues of identity, migration, and cultural hybridity. Salman Rushdie's own [Midnight's Children](#) (1981) explores the legacy of British colonialism in India through a blend of historical fiction and magical realism, a style that also permeates *The Satanic Verses*. The novel's exploration of the immigrant experience in the West connects it to works such as V. S. Naipaul's *The Mimic Men* and Zadie Smith's [White Teeth](#), both of which delve into the complexities of cultural assimilation.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Satanic Verses
- **When Written:** 1984–1988
- **Where Written:** Primarily in England
- **When Published:** September 26, 1988
- **Literary Period:** Postmodernism
- **Genre:** Novel, Magical Realism, Postcolonial Literature
- **Setting:** Primarily in London, with significant events in India and the Arabian Peninsula

- **Climax:** Gibreel Farishta, in a delusional state, kills Allie Cone and then takes his own life.
- **Point of View:** Third-Person Omniscient

EXTRA CREDIT

What's in a Name The title *The Satanic Verses* refers to a disputed Islamic tradition in which the Prophet Muhammad supposedly spoke verses that acknowledged pagan goddesses, later retracting them as having been inspired by Satan.

Knighthood Despite the controversy surrounding *The Satanic Verses*, Rushdie has continued to receive numerous literary accolades, including a knighthood in 2007 for his services to literature.



PLOT SUMMARY

Two men, Gibreel Farishta and Saladin Chamcha, fall through the sky following the explosion of Flight 420. Both men are actors: Gibreel is a movie star in India known for portraying gods, while Saladin is a television star in England known for his controversial depictions of immigrants. Their flight was destroyed after a group of terrorists hijacked it and detonated explosives. Even though everyone else on the flight dies, Gibreel and Saladin manage to survive, seemingly through divine intervention. Upon washing up on a beach in England, the men begin to undergo different but equally strange transformations. Gibreel's transformation is purely mental. He begins having dreams in which he is the archangel Gibreel delivering messages to important figures in the Islamic tradition. The most significant of these visions sees Gibreel delivering the "satanic verses" to Mahound (Rushdie's fictional equivalent of the Prophet Mohammad). These satanic verses cause both Mahound and Gibreel to question whether Gibreel is acting as a mouthpiece of God or Shaitan (Satan). Ultimately, Mahound dismisses the satanic verses, thinking them the work of the devil.

Meanwhile, Saladin undergoes a grotesque physical transformation, becoming a devil-like figure with horns and goat's hooves. Saladin's transformation gets underway just as the police take him into custody, believing he is an illegal immigrant. Too distracted by his own problems to care, Gibreel allows the police to take Saladin without saying a word. The police brutally mock and beat Saladin, humiliating him. Eventually, they realize he is a British citizen and abandon him.

Saladin wakes up in a hospital where he sees other people like him who are turning into a variety of mythological creatures. One of the creatures informs him that his transformation is a result of how others—particularly the English, who are hostile toward immigrants—see him. Saladin breaks out of the hospital with these other creatures and then attempts to get his life

back in order.

However, Saladin quickly discovers that his wife, Pamela, has begun seeing his childhood friend, Jumpy, because both thought he died in Flight 420. Because he cannot return to Pamela, Saladin lives with the Sufyans who run a café and boarding house. Mr. Sufyan is happy to care for Saladin despite his transformation. However, his wife, Hind Sufyan, wants Saladin to go away because she thinks he is a corrupting influence.

Meanwhile, Gibreel resumes his relationship with a woman named Alleluia (Allie) Cone. Alleluia is an accomplished English mountaineer, who has reached the summit of Mount Everest. Allie is surprised that Gibreel is alive and is eager to rekindle her relationship with him, although her mother, Alicja, disapproves. Although Allie and Gibreel's relationship goes well at first, it starts to deteriorate when Gibreel becomes jealous of other men's attraction to Allie. Gibreel's jealousy drives them to fight and temporarily split up. During this time, Gibreel also has another vision relating to Mahound. In this vision, Mahound has become a tyrant in Jahilia (the novel's stand-in for Mecca). The only one willing to stand up to Mahound is a poet, Baal, who makes it his life's mission to satirize and mock Mahound. Mahound ultimately puts Baal to death for what he writes.

Back at the Sufyan household, Saladin completes his grotesque transformation, which is too much for Hind Sufyan to stomach. Saladin leaves and ends up at an empty club where he reaches his physical and spiritual low point. After a great internal struggle, Saladin decides that he will take back control of his life, at which point he transforms back into a man. Then, he goes back to Pamela and tells her that he intends to live with her and Jumpy for the time being. Around this time, Saladin also learns about Dr. Uhuru Simba, a local Black activist who is being framed for the "Granny Ripper" murders that are plaguing London.

Gibreel returns to London, where his visions become increasingly extreme. He often has a difficult time distinguishing between fantasy and reality. In London, Gibreel sees Saladin at a party. Although Gibreel does not know it, Saladin still hates him because Gibreel abandoned him when the police came for him. All Gibreel can talk about is his relationship with Allie, which drives Saladin mad. In an angry outburst, he reveals that Pamela and Jumpy are going to have a child together. After hearing this news, Gibreel assaults Jumpy and runs away.

Because Allie thinks Saladin is a friend, she asks him if he will help her take care of Gibreel, whose actions are becoming increasingly erratic. Saladin agrees to do so, but instead of fulfilling his promise, he deliberately drives a wedge between Allie and Gibreel as a form of revenge. Saladin's meddling ultimately leads to the destruction of Allie and Gibreel's relationship.

Just after this, the public discovers that Dr. Uhuru Simba died under mysterious circumstances while in police custody. Many minorities in England believe that the police murdered Simba, thinking his death was racially and politically motivated. This leads to a great deal of civil unrest.

During this period of unrest, Gibreel succumbs to his madness. In a state of full delusion, Gibreel walks into a music store and purchases a **trumpet**, which he names Azraeel. Then, he walks out into the streets to issue divine judgment. While wandering around London, he discovers that Saladin is in danger and rushes into a **fire** to save him. Gibreel exits a burning building carrying Saladin in his arms.

Eighteen months later, Saladin flies to India because his father, Changez, is ill and about to die. For much of his life, Saladin has run away from India and his Indian identity. However, at this point, he begins to reembrace it. Saladin makes up with Changez, with whom he has long had a contentious relationship, on his deathbed. After Changez dies, Saladin decides to stay in India and rekindle a relationship with Zeeny Vakil, a leftist writer with whom he once had an affair. During this period, Gibreel also returns to India, but his life goes downhill fast. He loses what is left of his career and fortune, which only increases his sense of rage.

Then, one day, Allie comes to visit him in India to try to repair their relationship. This visit ends in a physical fight where Gibreel throws Allie off the roof of his building, killing her. Panicked, Gibreel runs away from the scene and the crime and travels to Saladin's apartment. After confessing what he did to Saladin, Gibreel shoots himself in the head before the police can capture him.

judgment. In the end, unable to reconcile his fractured identity and the weight of his delusions, Gibreel kills both Allie and himself.

Saladin Chamcha – Saladin Chamcha is an Indian expatriate and voice actor who rejects his cultural heritage in favor of assimilating into British society. Born Salahuddin Chamchawala, Saladin has a troubled relationship with his father, Changez, and grows up feeling overshadowed by his father's authority and traditional values. This conflict drives Saladin to adopt a new identity in England, where he changes his name, accent, and demeanor to fit into his ideal of Britishness, distancing himself from his roots. Saladin's defining characteristics include his deep-seated insecurity, resentment, and desire for acceptance. These traits become more prominent after he miraculously survives the plane explosion which begins the novel—only to find himself transformed into a devil-like creature with horns and hooves. This metamorphosis symbolizes his inner conflict and feelings of alienation, both from his adopted country, which treats him as an outsider, and from his native culture, which he has rejected. His transformation leads to a series of humiliations, such as being detained as an illegal immigrant and enduring racial abuse. As the novel progresses, Saladin grapples with his identity and sense of belonging. Eventually, he reconciles with his father and accepts his heritage, allowing him to return to human form.

Alleluia Cone – Alleluia "Allie" Cone is an English mountaineer known for her fearless spirit and strength. She becomes romantically involved with Gibreel Farishta after his arrival in London, serving as both his lover and a grounding force amid his psychological turmoil. Allie is depicted as a strong, independent woman who has faced her own struggles, including a difficult relationship with her father, Otto, which drives her to conquer Mount Everest. Despite her resilience, Allie becomes entangled in Gibreel's deteriorating mental state, bearing the brunt of his jealousy and paranoia. She attempts to support him, but eventually he grows too delusional. Allie's relationship with Gibreel ultimately ends in tragedy when his madness consumes him, and he kills her.

Rekha Merchant – Rekha Merchant is the wife of a wealthy businessman who becomes Gibreel's lover after he moves into her building. When Gibreel abruptly ends their relationship and abandons her, Rekha kills herself by leaping to her death from her apartment with her children. This act casts a long shadow over Gibreel's life and contributes to his unraveling mental state. Throughout the novel, Rekha returns as a spectral figure who torments Gibreel, appearing in his hallucinations and dreams to mock him and remind him of his betrayals and moral failures.

Changez Chamchawala – Changez is Saladin's father and a prominent member of India's nationalist movement. The public loves Changez, but Saladin has a difficult relationship with his father, who he feels withholds affection. From a young age,



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Gibreel Farishta – Gibreel Farishta is a renowned Bollywood actor famous for portraying deities. Born Ismail Najmuddin, Gibreel had a tumultuous childhood, as both of his parents died before his 21st birthday. As an adult, he reinvents himself as Gibreel Farishta, adopting a new persona filled with charisma and charm. After a near-death experience on a hijacked plane, Gibreel's grip on reality begins to unravel. He experiences vivid dreams where he embodies the archangel Gibreel. Over time, these dreams begin to blend with his waking life, manifesting as prophetic visions. In one such episode, Gibreel has an encounter with the Prophet Mahound in which Gibreel delivers the "satanic verses." Gibreel's jealousy and paranoia, particularly in his relationship with his lover, Allie Cone, fuel his descent into madness. He becomes convinced that Allie is unfaithful, and this causes him to become increasingly delusional and erratic. His paranoia reaches its peak when he believes himself to be a divine figure wielding the power of

Changez makes Saladin be self-reliant, which strains their relationship. When Saladin does not live his life the way Changez wants him to, Changez grows increasingly hostile. For much of his life, Saladin does not talk to his father, though they do make up just before Changez dies.

Pamela Lovelace – Pamela is Saladin's wife. Their relationship is strained from the start, as Pamela refuses to open up to Saladin. Pamela has a tragic past, which she does not want to discuss, which puts strain on their relationship. She also resents Saladin for his inability to have children. When she thinks Saladin is dead, she immediately begins an affair with Jumpy, hoping to conceive a child. She also has no desire to return to Saladin when she discovers he is alive.

Zeeny Vakil – Zeeny Vakil is a political writer and activist with whom Saladin carries out an affair when he returns to India to perform a play. Zeeny makes Saladin question his relationship to India and desire to be perceived as English. Although Saladin does not see her for a long time, the two rekindle their relationship when Saladin returns to India at the end of the novel.

Karim Abu Simbel – Abu Simbel is a wealthy and powerful leader in the city of Jahilia, a fictionalized version of pre-Islamic Mecca. He is depicted as the head of the ruling Quraysh tribe and is a key opponent of the prophet Mahound. Abu Simbel's role is central to the "satanic verses" episode, where he pressures Mahound to compromise his monotheistic message by allowing the worship of three local goddesses—Al-Lat, Manat, and Uzza—in order to maintain social and economic stability in Jahilia.

Baal – Baal is a subversive poet living in the city of Jahilia. He is known for his satirical and blasphemous poems that openly mock Mahound and his followers. His works challenge the power and legitimacy of Mahound's message, making him a target for persecution. Eventually, Baal is captured and executed because of what he writes.

Ayesha of Dash – Ayesha of Dash is a young, devout woman who claims to receive divine visions from the Archangel Gibreel, leading her to convince the villagers of the town of Titlipur to undertake a pilgrimage to Mecca on foot. She becomes a messianic figure and insists that the Arabian **Sea** will part for them as a miracle from God.

Mahound – Mahound is the novel's stand-in for the prophet Mohammed. He is the central figure of one of Gibreel's visions, which reimagines the founding of Islam. In this vision, Mahound as a businessman who becomes a prophet in the desert city of Jahilia. As Mahound's influence and power grows, a powerful man named Abu Simbel approaches him and offers to grant Mahound official recognition in Jahilia and a seat on the city's governing council—if Mahound agrees to incorporate three local goddesses into his monotheistic faith. Mahound struggles with this choice, which would grant his followers protection but

ultimately undermine a core tenet of his faith. He consults Gibreel for guidance and has a vision in which Gibreel (perhaps acting as a mouthpiece for Shaitan rather than for Allah) recites the "satanic verses" to Mahound, encouraging him to accept the goddesses. Mahound ultimately rejects this advice, however, recognizing that the verses came from Shaitan rather than from Allah.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Nasreen Chamchawala – Nasreen is Saladin's mother. Although Saladin gets along with her much better than he does Changez, Nasreen hates the idea of him going to England for his education. Nasreen dies during an air raid while attempting to show others that there is nothing to be afraid of.

Mirza Saeed Akhtar – Mirza Saeed Akhtar is a wealthy, rational landowner who becomes a key figure in the story of Ayesha of Dash. Skeptical of Ayesha's divine visions and the pilgrimage she leads, Mirza Saeed tries to dissuade the villagers, especially his wife, Mishal, from following her.

Mishal – Mishal Akhtar is the wife of Mirza Saeed Akhtar. She becomes one of the most devoted followers of Ayesha of Dash. Suffering from a terminal illness, Mishal places her hope in Ayesha's promise of a miraculous cure if she completes the pilgrimage to Mecca.

Nasreen Chamchawala (Stepmother) – After the death of Saladin's mother, Changez marries another woman named Nasreen. This Nasreen does not have a relationship with Saladin because Saladin refuses to even meet her for much of his life.

Eugene Dumsday – Eugene Dumsday is an American southerner who is on Flight 420 with Saladin and Gibreel. Eugene is a staunch Christian who initially traveled to India because he wanted to warn people of the evils of Darwinism.

Rosa Diamond – Rosa is an elderly woman who discovers Gibreel and Saladin after they wash up on the beach near her home. She takes the two men in and briefly forms a relationship with Gibreel before dying.

Jumpy Joshi – Jumpy is Saladin's childhood friend who almost immediately begins an affair with Pamela after he hears that Saladin died. Jumpy becomes morally conflicted once he realizes Saladin is still alive, though he continues seeing Pamela anyway.

Hanif Johnson – Hanif is a local lawyer who boards with the Sufyan's. Mishal Sufyan enters into a relationship with him, which drives a wedge between Mishal and her mother, Hind Sufyan.

Uhuru Simba – Uhuru Simba is a doctor and Black activist whom the police attempt to frame for the "Granny Ripper" murders. Though the police ultimately fail to link Simba to the murders, he suspiciously dies while in their custody.

Otto Cone – Otto Cone is Alleluia's father. Allie has a complicated relationship with him as a child, which only grows more strained after he dies by suicide when she is still a child.

Alicja Cone – Alicja is Alleluia's mother. She tries her best to provide a simple and fulfilling life for Allie, and she does not like it when Allie begins seeing Gibreel.

Jack Brunel – Jack is a friend of Otto Cone, who becomes romantically interested in Alleluia. Although Allie does not have any interest in Jack, Jack's interest in Allie makes Gibreel jealous.

Hagar – Hagar (Hājar) is the wife of the Prophet Ibrahim and the mother of Ismail, known for her unwavering faith, especially during her search for **water** in the desert, leading to the miraculous spring of Zamzam.

Ibrahim – Ibrahim (Abraham) is considered a major prophet in Islam and a patriarch of monotheism. He demonstrated absolute devotion to God, including his willingness to sacrifice his son Ismail as an act of faith.

The Imam – The Imam is a fanatical religious leader who appears in Gibreel's visions. He is exiled in London and hopes to return to his homeland to establish a strict theocratic regime.

Mr. Sufyan – Mr. Sufyan is the owner of the Shaandaar Café, which doubles as a boarding house. He takes pity of Saladin as Saladin is going through his transformation.

Ismail – Ismail (Ishmael), the son of Ibrahim and Hagar, is also regarded as a prophet and an ancestor of the Prophet Muhammad (or Mahound, in the case of the novel).

Salman – Salman is one of Mahound's closest followers and confidants. He abandons Mahound after he realizes that Mahound does not seem consistent in his beliefs.

Tavleen – Tavleen is a female terrorist who acts as the ringleader for the terrorists who board and eventually destroy Flight 420.

Kasturba – Kasturba is Vallabhbbhai's wife. She carries on an affair with Changez following Nasreen's death.

Hind of Jahilia – Hind is the scheming wife of Karim Abu Simbel who regularly takes on new lovers.

Martin de la Cruz – Martin is a man from Rosa's past with whom she may or may not have had an affair.

Hyacinth Philips – Hyacinth is a nurse who treats Saladin when he ends up in the hospital following his abuse at the hands of the police.

Hind Sufyan – Hind is Mr. Sufyan's wife. She despises Saladin's presence and wants him out of her home.

Pinkwalla – Pinkwalla is a local DJ who drives Saladin to Club Hot Wax when he needs a place to stay.

Orphia Philips – Orphia is Hyacinth's sister. Gibreel tries and fails to perform a miracle for her.

S. S. Sisodia – S. S. Sisodia is a film producer who helps get Gibreel back into the film industry after Gibreel returns to London.

Ayesha of Jahilia – Ayesha of Jahilia is one of Mahound's wives. Mahound dies in her arms.

Billy Battuta – Billy is a famous actor who is notorious for the film industry for his mistreatment of women. Still, he always manages to book new jobs.

Mimi Mamouljian – Mimi is Saladin's television co-star. She starts a relationship with Billy Battuta, despite her knowledge of his terrible reputation.

Khadija – Khadija is a member of the voyage to the Arabian **Sea**. She is married to Muhammad Din and dies on the journey.

Srinivas – Srinivas is a toymaker who joins Ayesha of Dash's voyage to the Arabian Sea.

Muhammad Din – Muhammad Din is a member of the voyage to the Arabian **Sea**. He is married to Khadija.

Inspector Lime – Inspector Lime is the chief officer in Saladin's arrest when Saladin is staying with Rosa.

Mishal Sufyan – Mishal is one of Mr. Sufyan's daughters. She is rebellious and finds herself drawn to Saladin.

Pimple Billimoria – Pimple is Gibreel's female co-star in a film he is shooting on the day he disappears.

Najmuddin Senior – Najmuddin Senior is Gibreel's father. He dies from a stroke when Gibreel is a young man.

Naima Najmuddin – Naima is Gibreel's mother. She is hit by a bus and dies when Gibreel is still a child.

Babasaheb Mhatre – Babasaheb is a man who takes Gibreel in and cares for him after the deaths of Gibreel's parents. Babasaheb introduces Gibreel to the film industry.

Mrs. Mhatre – Mrs. Mhatre is Babasaheb's wife.

Shaitan – Shaitan is the Arabic word for Satan. Gibreel encounters Shaitan in his prophetic visions.

Al-Lat/Lat – Al-Lat/Lat is one of Shaitan's daughters.

Manat – Manat is one of Shaitan's daughters.

Uzza – Uzza is one of Shaitan's daughters.

Muttalib – Muttalib is the grandfather of Mahound.

Vallabhbbhai – Vallabhbbhai is Saladin's housekeeper.

Khalid – Khalid is one of Mahound's closest followers.

Bilal – Bilal is one of Mahound's closest followers.

Hamza – Hamza is Mahound's uncle.

Mrs. Srinivas – Mrs. Srinivas is Srinivas's wife.

Enrique – Enrique is Rosa's long-deceased husband.

Stein – Stein is one of the policemen who brutalizes and threatens Saladin.

John Maslama – Maslama is a religious man whom Gibreel meets on his way to London.

Bilal X – Bilal X is one of the Imam's ardent followers.

Anahita Sufyan – Anahita is one of Mr. Sufyan's daughters.

Antoinette Roberts – Antoinette is Uhuru Simba's mother.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



THE FALLIBILITY OF PROPHETS

In *The Satanic Verses*, Salman Rushdie explores the fallibility of prophets through a provocative reimagining of religious history. The novel

challenges the notion of prophets as infallible figures, suggesting instead that they, like all humans, are susceptible to doubt, error, and manipulation. This idea is most evident in the portrayal of the character Mahound, a fictionalized version of the Prophet Muhammad. Rushdie presents Mahound as a man who grapples with the authenticity of his divine revelations. In one of the novel's most controversial episodes, Mahound receives verses that sanction the worship of three goddesses, only to later retract them, claiming that they were inspired by the devil, not by God. This incident, often referred to as the "Satanic Verses," illustrates the uncertainty inherent in the prophetic experience. Mahound's moment of doubt and subsequent reversal casts doubt over the supposed divine origin of his messages, raising questions about the true source of religious authority.

Similarly, Gibreel, an actor who portrays gods in Bollywood films, begins to believe he is the archangel Gabriel after surviving a plane crash. His hallucinations and visions of himself as a divine messenger mirror Mahound's experiences, blurring the lines between prophecy and madness. Gibreel's inability to distinguish between reality and his visions highlights the fragility of the prophetic mind. His descent into madness suggests that the weight of carrying divine messages—or believing oneself to—is too great for any human to bear without cracking under the pressure. By intertwining Gibreel's and Mahound's stories, Rushdie emphasizes the inherent dangers of deifying prophets. Through this dual narrative, the novel critiques the traditional veneration of prophets, urging a more humanistic approach to understanding religious figures and their roles in shaping belief systems.



IMMIGRATION AND IDENTITY

The Satanic Verses explores the complexities of immigration and identity, as characters navigate the dislocation that comes with leaving one's

homeland. Saladin Chamcha's journey exemplifies these struggles. As an Indian expatriate in England, Saladin goes to great lengths to distance himself from his Indian heritage and fully embrace a British identity. He adopts an English accent, changes his name, and immerses himself in British culture, striving for acceptance. However, his sense of belonging is violently disrupted after a plane crash, when he undergoes a grotesque transformation into a devil-like figure, complete with horns and hooves. This metamorphosis symbolizes the inner conflict he experiences as he battles between rejecting his origins and confronting the inescapable influence of his cultural background. Saladin's physical transformation reflects how British society perceives and marginalizes immigrants, revealing the deep-seated prejudices he encounters despite his efforts to assimilate.

Meanwhile, Gibreel Farishta's story offers a parallel yet distinct perspective. A Bollywood star who relocates to London, Gibreel holds on to his Indian identity even as he attempts to adapt to his new surroundings. Unlike Saladin, Gibreel does not reject his roots, but he nevertheless struggles with the identity crisis that immigration often triggers. His gradual descent into madness, marked by his visions of being the archangel Gabriel, underscores the psychological strain of maintaining multiple identities in an unfamiliar environment. Through these characters, Rushdie illustrates the fragmented nature of immigrant identity. Saladin and Gibreel's stories reveal the psychological toll of migration, showing how it forces individuals into a liminal space where they exist between cultures, belonging fully to neither.



RELIGION AND BLASPHEMY

The Satanic Verses delves into the fraught relationship between religion and blasphemy, challenging orthodox beliefs. Rushdie's narrative

sparked one of the most significant literary controversies of the 20th century, leading to widespread outrage and a fatwa (a ruling on Islamic law) calling for his assassination in 1989. The novel blurs the boundaries between the sacred and the profane, often venturing into what many consider blasphemous territory. Gibreel Farishta, after surviving a plane crash, begins to have visions in which he assumes the role of the archangel Gabriel. These visions lead to a retelling of the life of Mahound (a fictionalized version of the Prophet Muhammad) and the controversial episodes that define his prophetic mission. By reimagining these sacred stories, Rushdie challenges the inviolability of religious texts, suggesting they are open to interpretation and re-interpretation, like any other human creation.

Baal, a satirical poet named after a pre-Islamic pagan god, embodies the tension between artistic freedom and religious orthodoxy. His biting, often blasphemous verses target the emerging religious order led by Mahound in the city of Jahilia, a stand-in for Mecca. Baal's poetry becomes a form of resistance against the growing theocratic power that seeks to control not just spiritual life but also everyday human expression. Ultimately, Baal is executed for speaking out against Mahound, but not before leaving a lasting impact. Baal, despite his noble qualities, remains a flawed character, neither morally superior to Mahound nor a divine figure in his own right. Yet, as a writer and satirist, he plays a crucial role in speaking truth to power—an act that leads to his martyrdom. Through Baal, Rushdie ultimately suggests that the value of fiction and satire lies in their capacity to challenge and blaspheme against established power.



RACIAL PREJUDICE AND XENOPHOBIA

Throughout the novel, Rushdie examines the insidious effects of racial prejudice and xenophobia, revealing how deeply ingrained biases shape the experiences of characters who face discrimination in a society that views them as outsiders. The novel exposes the harsh realities of racism and the dehumanizing impact of xenophobic attitudes on those whom English society perceives as different due to their ethnicity or cultural background. Saladin Chamcha's experiences in England illustrate the destructive power of racial prejudice. Despite his efforts to assimilate into British society, Saladin finds himself subjected to overt and systemic racism. After surviving the plane crash, Saladin is not only transformed into a devil-like figure but also treated as one by the authorities. His transformation into a literal monster serves as a metaphor for how society demonizes immigrants and people of color. The police, embodying institutional racism, brutalize Saladin without hesitation, reinforcing the notion that those who are racially or culturally different from the ruling or mainstream culture are inherently suspect. This dehumanization reflects the broader societal view that non-white individuals are inferior, a view that justifies their mistreatment in the eyes of the police.

Another important moment in the novel that comments on race is the trial of Dr. Uhuru Simba, a Black activist who is framed for the "Granny Ripper" murders. For the minorities in the community, the trial is less about determining the truth and more about reinforcing societal fears and stereotypes about Black men. Simba's African heritage is used against him, as the prosecution and public opinion paint him as an embodiment of the dangerous and uncivilized other. Ultimately, the police are unable to convict Simba because they lack the proper evidence, but he suspiciously dies while under their care. Simba's death results in civil unrest, which the media tries to paint as more insidious than it really is. Together, the media and the police

force conspiracy to victimize minorities in their communities. Then, just to rub salt in the wound, they point the finger at those same people, suggesting they are to blame for their ongoing plight. Although the novel often admires the multicultural atmosphere of London, it simultaneously exposes the ugliness that lies just beneath the surface. Ultimately, the novel calls for a more just and compassionate understanding of those who are too often marginalized because of their race and immigrant status.



METAMORPHOSIS AND IDENTITY

In *The Satanic Verses*, Rushdie uses the concept of metamorphosis to explore the fluidity of identity. Metamorphosis in the novel is both a literal and symbolic process, reflecting the interplay between self-perception and societal expectations. Saladin Chamcha's physical transformation into a devil-like creature is perhaps the most striking example of metamorphosis in the novel. After surviving a plane crash, Saladin finds himself sprouting horns, growing hooves, and developing other monstrous features. This grotesque change symbolizes the deep conflict within him; that is, his desire to assimilate into British society while rejecting his Indian heritage. Saladin's metamorphosis can be seen as a manifestation of how society views him: despite his best efforts to conform, he is perceived as alien and other. The transformation forces Saladin to confront the parts of his identity he has tried to suppress, ultimately leading him to a painful but necessary reconciliation with his roots.

Gibreel Farishta's transformation, while less physically dramatic, is equally significant. After the crash, Gibreel begins to believe he is the archangel Gabriel, experiencing visions that blur the line between reality and fantasy. This psychological metamorphosis represents Gibreel's struggle with his own identity and the weight of his religious upbringing. His descent into madness reflects the overwhelming pressures that come with embodying multiple, often conflicting identities. Gibreel's transformation illustrates how the human mind can distort reality when burdened by unresolved conflicts and guilt.

Metamorphosis in the novel is not limited to physical or mental changes—it also extends to the characters' spiritual and moral transformations. Both Saladin and Gibreel undergo significant shifts in their understanding of themselves and their place in the world. These transformations challenge them to reassess their values, beliefs, and connections to their pasts. Through these changes, Rushdie suggests that identity is not fixed but is constantly evolving in response to life's challenges and the shifting landscapes of culture and belief.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and

Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THE MAGIC LAMP

In *The Satanic Verses*, the magic lamp symbolizes Saladin Chamcha's complicated relationship with his Indian heritage. The lamp, which belongs to his father, Changez Chamchawala, is believed to bring good fortune. For Saladin, the lamp represents the cultural and familial heritage he seeks to distance himself from in his quest to assimilate into British society. This desire to distance himself from India begins, in part, because of how his father treats him, which includes not allowing him to touch the lamp. Over time, the magic lamp evolves into a metaphor for Saladin's struggle with his identity and the realization that he cannot entirely sever ties with his heritage. It reflects his internal conflict between rejecting his roots to become "English" and the deep-seated cultural inheritance that shapes his sense of self. When Saladin essentially cuts himself off from Changez, Changez tells him that he will not inherit the lamp. However, when Saladin returns to India and reconciles with his Changez, he inherits the lamp, after all, which represents the return of his Indian identity and heritage.



THE TRUMPET

In *The Satanic Verses*, the trumpet symbolizes Gibreel's belief that he is a God-like figure who should be responsible for issuing divine judgments. When Gibreel purchases the trumpet, he names it Azraeel, the name for the Angel of Death in Islamic tradition. The trumpet, therefore, becomes not just a symbol of divine judgment but also a harbinger of death. This naming underscores Gibreel's internal struggle with how he perceives his role as a divine instrument. It represents Gibreel's fear of being an agent of destruction and his burden of carrying out what he believes to be God's will. It is this belief that he is responsible for delivering such judgments, which eventually leads to his psychological unraveling.



FIRE AND WATER

In *The Satanic Verses* fire and water are contrasting forces that represent destruction and purification, respectively. They also reflect the novel's broader themes of transformation and identity. When Saladin turns into a demon, fire becomes a symbol of his rage and the obliteration of his former self. The London riots, marked by flames and chaos, further highlight fire's destructive power, tearing apart not just the city but the characters' lives and beliefs. Water, in contrast, symbolizes cleansing and renewal. For Gibreel, water appears at moments of spiritual crisis or rebirth, such as when he emerges from the English Channel after falling from the

exploded plane. The water acts as a baptismal force, suggesting a chance to start anew.



BAD BREATH

In *The Satanic Verses*, bad breath symbolizes inherent moral corruption. Gibreel's bad breath reveals the disparity between his public persona as a beloved actor playing deities and his flawed, human reality. When he portrays gods in Bollywood films, his foul breath signifies a spiritual taint that exists beneath the surface. This contrast exposes the irony of Gibreel's existence—the public sees him as a divine figure, yet he is morally compromised. When he and Saladin survive the fall back to Earth after the plane explodes, his bad breath transfers to Saladin. This transfer represents the spread of inner decay, infecting Saladin with the same moral compromise that plagues Gibreel.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Random House edition of *The Satanic Verses* published in 2008.

Part 1, Chapter 1 Quotes

“Fly,” Chamcha shrieked at Gibreel. “Start flying, now.” And added, without knowing its source, the second command: “And sing.”

How does newness come into the world? How is it born?

Of what fusions, translations, conjoinings is it made?

How does it survive, extreme and dangerous as it is? What compromises, what deals, what betrayals of its secret nature must it make to stave off the wrecking crew, the exterminating angel, the guillotine?

Is birth always a fall?

Do angels have wings? Can men fly?

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha (speaker), Gibreel Farishta

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 8-9

Explanation and Analysis

Following the plane hijacking, Saladin feels a sudden—seemingly divine—feeling come upon him as he falls through the sky. He orders Gibreel to sing and fly, which will allow them to get to safety. Rushdie uses this

moment to delve into the nature of “newness” entering the world. Through a series of rhetorical questions, he explores the tumultuous process of creation and transformation. The inquiries—“How does newness come into the world? How is it born?”—imply that bringing something new into existence is fraught with challenges. These questions mirror the novel’s broader themes, particularly the experiences of migration and the reshaping of identity. Newness, in this sense, is not merely an addition to the old, but rather a product of “fusions, translations, conjoinings.”

The passage culminates in a meditation on the nature of birth and the role of angels. These questions blur the lines between the divine and the human and suggest that the act of creation is inherently tied to loss and transformation. Birth, in this sense, is both a beginning and a fall—a descent from an idealized state into the compromised reality of the world.

☞ These were the first words Gibreel Farishta said when he awoke on the snowbound English beach with the improbability of a starfish by his ear: “Born again, Spoono, you and me. Happy birthday, mister; happy birthday to you.”

Whereupon Saladin Chamcha coughed, spluttered, opened his eyes, and, as befitted a new-born babe, burst into foolish tears.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta (speaker), Saladin Chamcha

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 10

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Gibreel and Saladin have made it back to earth after the explosion of Flight 420. Gibreel’s words serve as a declaration of rebirth for both himself and Saladin. The imagery of being “born again” is laden with religious undertones, echoing themes of resurrection and transformation. Meanwhile, the reference to a birthday reinforces the notion of new beginnings. Gibreel’s words are celebratory, suggesting that this rebirth is an opportunity for both characters to redefine themselves in a new world. However, this rebirth is also full of uncertainty. Gibreel’s use of “Spoon,” a playful nickname for Saladin, carries a tone of familiarity but also a sense of lost identity. Saladin’s response to this declaration is telling. Like a newborn, Saladin is overwhelmed by the enormity of his new reality, unable to fully comprehend what has happened to him. Notably, despite Gibreel’s feelings that the two of

them have been reborn, their past lives will come back to haunt them, meaning this new episode of life will not be the clean break Gibreel hopes it will be. As such, Saladin’s reaction is ultimately the one that proves to be more appropriate.

Part 1, Chapter 2 Quotes

☞ *We are creatures of air, Our roots in dreams And clouds, reborn In flight. Goodbye.* The enigmatic note discovered by the police in Gibreel Farishta’s penthouse, located on the top floor of the Everest Vilas skyscraper on Malabar Hill, the highest home in the highest building on the highest ground in the city, one of those double-vista apartments from which you could look this way across the evening necklace of Marine Drive or that way out to Scandal Point and the sea, permitted the newspaper headlines to prolong their cacophonies.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, Saladin Chamcha

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 13-14

Explanation and Analysis

This passage discusses the note Gibreel leaves in his apartment before disappearing from the public eye. The idea of being “reborn in flight” echoes the novel’s recurrent theme of metamorphosis, hinting at the possibility of escape through a kind of spiritual ascent. Of course, Gibreel is ultimately reborn in flight after the explosion of Flight 420, making the note prophetic and rather literal. The setting of the penthouse from which the note is discovered amplifies the themes within the text. Positioned at the top of the Everest Vilas skyscraper on Malabar Hill, the penthouse represents a divine vantage point from which one can look out over the entire city—including Scandal Point, where Saladin is from. This height reinforces the imagery of air and flight, suggesting a detachment from the mundane world below. It aligns with Gibreel’s desire to transcend the ordinary and ascend to a higher, more purified state of being.

However, the note’s ambiguity and the sensationalism that surrounds its discovery introduce a tension between this ethereal aspiration and the grounded reality of the city’s life. The media’s quotidian speculation on the circumstances of Gibreel’s disappearance strips the note of its poignant, transcendent qualities. The word “cacophonies” hints at the chaotic and superficial nature of public discourse, which contrasts sharply with the reflective tone of the note itself.

The media's response to the note reflects a misunderstanding or perhaps a deliberate distortion of the more profound existential ideas with which Gibreel is grappling.

☞ After he departed the ubiquitous images of his face began to rot. On the gigantic, luridly coloured hoardings from which he had watched over the populace, his lazy eyelids started flaking and crumbling, drooping further and further until his irises looked like two moons sliced by clouds, or by the soft knives of his long lashes. Finally the eyelids fell off, giving a wild, bulging look to his painted eyes. Outside the picture palaces of Bombay, mammoth cardboard effigies of Gibreel were seen to decay and list. Dangling limply on their sustaining scaffolds, they lost arms, withered, snapped at the neck. His portraits on the covers of movie magazines acquired the pallor of death, a nullity about the eye, a hollowness. At last his images simply faded off the printed page, so that the shiny covers of *Celebrity* and *Society* and *Illustrated Weekly* went blank at the bookstalls and their publishers fired the printers and blamed the quality of the ink.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 16

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, the disintegration of Gibreel's public image symbolizes his fall from grace. As Gibreel departs, his image—once omnipresent and revered across Bombay—literally begin to rot. This description paints a picture of Gibreel's decline from a celestial, almost divine presence to something grotesque, his beauty and charisma lost to time. It is perhaps an allusion to Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, which follows a morally corrupt young man who wishes to remain forever youthful while his portrait ages instead. This is one of the first hints in the novel that Gibreel's transformation might not be the positive metamorphosis that he envisions.

The portrayal of the giant effigies of Gibreel outside the picture palaces of Bombay reinforces this sense of a fallen idol. The imagery is almost apocalyptic in nature, suggesting a world where the gods—or in this case, film stars—are not only mortal but subject to a rapid decay. The physical disintegration of these figures is emblematic of Gibreel's loss of his status as a cultural icon. Gibreel's decay is not just a personal downfall—it also affects everyone around him who held him up on a pedestal.

Part 1, Chapter 3 Quotes

☞ Once upon a time—it *was* and it *was not* so, as the old stories used to say, *it happened* and it *never did*—maybe, then, or maybe not, a ten-year-old boy from Scandal Point in Bombay found a wallet lying in the Street outside his home [...] when he saw the black leather billfold lying at his feet, the nausea vanished, and he bent down excitedly and grabbed,—opened,—and found, to his delight, that it was full of cash,—and not merely rupees, but real money, negotiable on black markets and international exchanges, — pounds! Pounds sterling, from Proper London in the fabled country of Vilayet across the black water and far away.

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 35-36

Explanation and Analysis

This passage, which employs a narrative style reminiscent of a fairy tale, is a flashback to Saladin's childhood. The opening line sets a tone of uncertainty, inviting the reader into a world where reality and fiction intermingle. This introduction reflects the novel's overarching commitment to the postmodern style, which is self-referential and tends to call into question the reliability of what is on the page.

For Saladin, the British pounds he finds in the wallet represent more than just financial value—they also link him to "Proper London," a place of dreams. This reference to "Vilayet," an Urdu word for a foreign land (particularly Britain) evokes the colonial history and post-colonial aspirations that permeate the novel. Saladin's fascination with the foreign currency hints at a cultural fixation with the West. The description of the pounds as "real money" underscores his perceived superiority of Western currencies and, by extension, Western civilization. Meanwhile, the phrase "across the black water" conveys the intimidating gap between Saladin's reality in Bombay and the imagined riches of London. This gap is not only geographical but also socioeconomic, highlighting the allure that the "other" world holds for someone like Saladin.

☛☛ The promise of the magic lamp infected Master Salahuddin with the notion that one day his troubles would end and his innermost desires would be gratified, and all he had to do was wait it out; but then there was the incident of the wallet, when the magic of a rainbow had worked for him, not for his father but for him, and Changez Chamchawala had stolen the crock of gold. After that the son became convinced that his father would smother all his hopes unless he got away, and from that moment he became desperate to leave, to escape, to place oceans between the great man and himself.

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha, Changez Chamchawala

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 37

Explanation and Analysis

Saladin—referred to here as Master Salahuddin—grapples with his complicated feelings about his father, Changez, and the magic lamp Changez possesses. The magic lamp represents the cultural and familial heritage Saladin is desperate to escape. Initially, Saladin believes that one day the lamp's magic will resolve his troubles and fulfill his desires, embodying his naïve hope that his wishes could be realized without effort. However, when his father takes the “crock of gold” in the incident of the wallet, Saladin's view shifts. He begins to see his father as an obstacle to his freedom and dreams, much like the lamp becomes a symbol of the cultural baggage he wishes to shed in his quest to assimilate into British society.

Saladin's desire to escape—to place “oceans” between himself and Changez—reflects his deep yearning to sever ties with his heritage. His father's control over the lamp, a symbol of his Indian roots, becomes intolerable, and Saladin becomes desperate to reject everything it represents. His father's refusal to let him touch the lamp mirrors his broader attempts to dictate Saladin's future, fueling Saladin's determination to break away.

Part 2 Quotes

☛☛ Doubt.

The human condition, but what of the angelic? Halfway between Allahgod and homosap, did they ever doubt? They did: challenging God's will one day they hid muttering beneath the Throne, daring to ask forbidden things: antiququestions. Is it right that. Could it not be argued. Freedom, the old antiquest. He calmed them down, naturally, employing management skills à la god. Flattered them: you will be the instruments of my will on earth, of the salvationdamnation of man, all the usual etcetera. And hey presto, end of protest, on with the haloes, back to work. Angels are easily pacified; turn them into instruments and they'll play your harpy tune. Human beings are tougher nuts, can doubt anything, even the evidence of their own eyes. Of behind-their-own eyes. Of what, as they sink heavy-lidded, transpires behind closed peepers. . . angels, they don't have much in the way of a will. To will is to disagree; not to submit; to dissent.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, Mahound

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 94-95

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes from the beginning of Part 2, as Gibreel begins to experience his visions of Mahound. This moment seems to portray an omniscient narrator's reflections, though perhaps some of Gibreel's thoughts are mixed in as well. This passage explores the contrast between divine beings and humans, focusing on the nature of doubt.

The passage begins by emphasizing doubt as an essential aspect of human nature, which allows for constant questioning. This skepticism forms a stark contrast to the implied certainty religious doctrine often attaches to divine beings. The narrator raises the idea of angelic doubt, suggesting that angels, positioned “halfway” between divinity and humanity, occupy a space where doubt could exist. Angels once challenged divine authority with “antiququestions,” moments of rebellion akin to human inquiry. Rushdie's term “antiquest” captures this dual sense of simultaneously denying and seeking alternative truths, presenting a parallel to human intellectual freedom.

God's response to this rebellion is portrayed through bureaucratic manipulation, using flattery to pacify the angels by assigning them as “instruments of my will.” This highlights a divine strategy of control rather than genuine engagement with dissent, implying that religious authority can superficially appease without addressing deeper issues.

The phrase “harpy tune” underscores the idea that once subdued, the angels merely follow orders, lacking critical thought or genuine autonomy. Humans, however, are described as fundamentally different—“tougher nuts”—because they can doubt everything, including their own experiences and internal thoughts. The narration frames this condition as a unique human trait tied to free will, where doubt is necessary for genuine autonomy. The narrator seems to think of this as a positive force, in part because it can resist the influence of God.

☞ Gibreel: the dreamer, whose point of view is sometimes that of the camera and at other moments, spectator. When he’s a camera the pee oh vee is always on the move, he hates static shots, so he’s floating up on a high crane looking down at the foreshortened figures of the actors, or he’s swooping down to stand invisibly between them, turning slowly on his heel to achieve a three-hundred-and-sixty-degree pan, or maybe he’ll try a dolly shot, tracking along beside Baal and Abu Simbel as they walk, or hand-held with the help of a steadicam he’ll probe the secrets of the Grandee’s bedchamber. But mostly he sits up on Mount Cone like a paying customer in the dress circle, and Jahilia is his silver screen.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, Mahound

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 110

Explanation and Analysis

This passage describes Gibreel while he is experiencing his vision of Mahound and Jahilia. Gibreel is both a dreamer and a visionary, whose perspective shifts between that of a filmmaker’s camera and a spectator. Rushdie uses cinematic language to explore Gibreel’s consciousness, blending film techniques with the novel’s narrative structure. As a “dreamer,” Gibreel’s viewpoint is flexible, changing from the objective gaze of a camera to the subjective engagement of a spectator.

When in “camera” mode, Gibreel’s perspective is dynamic, constantly moving and capturing multiple angles. This mode signifies his desire for omniscience—an attribute typically reserved for gods. In this role, Gibreel appears to be more than just a participant in the events; he becomes a creator, shaping how the narrative unfolds and reflecting the godly power to impose order and clarity. However, this mix of human and divine within Gibreel leads to a constant tension, as he can neither fully embrace his divine role nor

completely relinquish his human limitations. His divine gaze is never entirely free from human biases, suggesting that his god-like visions are not purely objective but rather colored by his subjective, human consciousness.

☞ He returns to the city as quickly as he can, to expunge the foul verses that reek of brimstone and sulphur, to strike them from the record for ever and ever, so that they will survive in just one or two unreliable collections of old traditions and orthodox interpreters will try and unwrite their story, but Gibreel, hovering—watching from his highest camera angle, knows one small detail, just one tiny thing that’s a bit of a problem here, namely that *it was me both times, baba, me first and second also me*. From my mouth, both the statement and the repudiation, verses and converses, universes and reverses, the whole thing, and we all know how my mouth got worked.

“First it was the Devil,” Mahound mutters as he rushes to Jahilia. “But this time, the angel, no question. He wrestled me to the ground.”

Related Characters: Mahound (speaker), Gibreel Farishta

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 126

Explanation and Analysis

This passage provides the novel’s title and centers on the controversial concept of the “Satanic verses” in Islamic tradition. Mahound, the fictional version of the Prophet Muhammad, realizes that the verses allowing the worship of goddesses might have come from Satan. Gibreel, hovering above, reveals that he spoke both the original verses and their repudiation, blurring the line between divine and demonic inspiration. Historically, the “Satanic verses” refer to a disputed episode in which the Prophet Muhammad reportedly accepted—then retracted—verses influenced by Satan. Many Islamic scholars reject this account, as it challenges the infallibility of the Quran and the Prophet. Rushdie’s portrayal of this ambiguity, in which divine and satanic messages intermingle, sparked outrage among Muslims, who saw it as blasphemy.

Essentially, Rushdie’s account suggests that prophets are fallible and do not necessarily represent the true word of God. Even worse, they cannot tell the difference between the word of God and the word of the Devil. In making this point, Rushdie is not condemning religion per se, but he is suggesting that prophets, like all people, are prone to error and are therefore undeserving of the status religious

groups place upon them.

Saladin, find themselves caught in the whims of higher powers.

Part 3, Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ One man's breath was sweetened, while another's, by an equal and opposite mystery, was soured. What did they expect? Falling like that out of the sky: did they imagine there would be no sideeffects? Higher Powers had taken an interest, it should have been obvious to them both, and such Powers (I am, of course, speaking of myself) have a mischievous, almost a wanton attitude to tumbling flies. And another thing, let's be clear: great falls change people. You think *they* fell a long way? In the matter of tumbles, I yield pride of place to no personage, whether mortal or im—. From clouds to ashes, down the chimney you might say, from heavenlight to hellfire. . . under the stress of a long plunge, I was saying, mutations are to be expected, not all of them random. Unnatural selections. Not much of a price to pay for survival, for being reborn, for becoming new, and at their age at that.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, Saladin Chamcha

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 137

Explanation and Analysis

This quote reflects on the transformative consequences of Gibreel and Saladin's fall from the hijacked plane. The narrator, who subtly hints at being a supernatural figure, speaks of how the two men undergo significant changes—one's breath sweetens, and the other's turns sour. Throughout the novel, bad breath is a sign of moral and spiritual decay, suggesting Saladin is about to embark on a downward trajectory. The "Higher Powers" that the narrator mentions seem to enjoy meddling in human affairs, and their actions are not random but rather purposeful, with "unnatural selections" influencing the outcomes of the characters. The quote emphasizes that such profound falls, both literal and metaphorical, lead to irreversible changes. These transformations are framed as a "price to pay" for survival, rebirth, or becoming new, suggesting that Gibreel and Saladin's experiences are part of a larger, cosmic scheme. The imagery of falling "from heavenlight to hellfire" underscores the moral and spiritual descent that accompanies their journey. The narrator's almost casual tone about these transformations reflects a sense of amusement at the plight of those who, like Gibreel and

☞ "Gibreel," said Saladin Chamcha, "help."

But Gibreel's eye had been caught by Rosa Diamond. He looked at her, and could not look away. Then he nodded, and went back upstairs. No attempt was made to stop him.

When Chamcha reached the Black Maria, he saw the traitor, Gibreel Farishta, looking down at him from the little balcony outside Rosa's bedroom, and there wasn't any light shining around the bastard's head.

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha (speaker), Gibreel Farishta, Rosa Diamond

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 146

Explanation and Analysis

As the police take Saladin away, Saladin begs Gibreel for help. However, Gibreel does not step in to help him. Gibreel's distraction by Rosa signifies more than just inattentiveness—it also highlights his susceptibility to earthly desires and the fragile nature of his moral compass. By turning away from Saladin's call for help, Gibreel is stepping away from his perceived divine role. Meanwhile, the "traitor" label that Saladin attaches to Gibreel reflects the crumbling of his own faith in others, deepening his sense of alienation. The absence of light around Gibreel's head is an image that dismantles the mythic aura that has surrounded Gibreel, suggesting that whatever divine qualities he momentarily possessed have gone away or have at least dimmed. This moment strips Gibreel of any pretense of sanctity and exposes him as flawed. Rushdie uses this act of betrayal to interrogate the nature of goodness and evil, suggesting that these qualities are not always starkly defined. Although Gibreel becomes an angel at the same moment Saladin becomes the devil, Rushdie is suggesting that the difference between them is not as great as these labels would suggest.

Part 3, Chapter 4 Quotes

☛☛ Chamcha's room struck the sleepless intruder as contrived, and therefore sad: the caricature of an actor's room full of signed photographs of colleagues, handbills, framed programmes, production stills, citations, awards, volumes of movie--star memoirs, a room bought off the peg, by the yard, an imitation of life, a mask's mask. Novelty items on every surface: ashtrays in the shape of pianos, china pierrots peeping out from behind a shelf of books. And everywhere, on the walls, in the movie posters, in the glow of the lamp borne by bronze Eros, in the mirror shaped like a heart, oozing up through the blood-red carpet, dripping from the ceiling, Saladin's need for love. In the theatre everybody gets kissed and everybody is darling. The actor's life offers, on a daily basis, the simulacrum of love; a mask can be satisfied, or at least consoled, by the echo of what it seeks.

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha, Jumpy Joshi

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 180

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Jumpy Joshi is looking around Saladin's room and creating a psychological portrait of his childhood friend. The description of Saladin's room as filled with memorabilia and novelty items suggests a life that is overly curated and constructed, lacking authenticity. Rushdie uses the room as a metaphor for Saladin's own existence—it is a “mask's mask,” an imitation of an imitation rather than a genuine expression of self. The clutter of superficial objects indicates a personality overwhelmed by artifice and a desperate need to conform to an image of an actor's lifestyle.

This description of Saladin's room, therefore, reflects his fragmented identity. Caught between masks, roles, and a desperate desire for validation, Saladin's life is one of performance without substance, where the echoes of love are felt but never truly attained. The “blood-red carpet” and “heart-shaped mirror” evoke a sense of both passion and violence, hinting at the turmoil within Chamcha's psyche. His need for love is not just emotional—it is almost a physical, palpable force that undergirds his every action throughout the narrative.

Part 3, Chapter 5 Quotes

☛☛ The other scrambled to his feet and stood pulling at his fingers, his head bowed. “What I want to know, sir,” he mumbled, “is, which is it to be? Annihilation or salvation? Why have you returned?”

Gibreel thought rapidly. “It is for judging,” he finally answered. “Facts in the case must be sifted, due weight given pro and contra. Here it is the human race that is the undertrial, and it is a defendant with a rotten record: a history-sheeter, a bad egg. Careful evaluations must be made. For the present, verdict is reserved; will be promulgated in due course. In the meantime, my presence must remain a secret, for vital security reasons.” He put his hat back on his head, feeling pleased with himself.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, John Maslama (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 200

Explanation and Analysis

This is a conversation between Gibreel and John Maslama, a religious fundamentalist whom Gibreel meets on a train ride back to London. The exchange presents Gibreel as someone who is both unsure of his own purpose and adept at improvising an authoritative persona, a skill he presumably picked up from his time in acting. Maslama's anxious questioning suggests an existential fear, positioning Gibreel as a figure with the power to determine humanity's fate. This expectation puts Gibreel in a position of authority, which he navigates with a mixture of quick thinking and self-satisfaction.

Gibreel's response, describing his mission as “judging,” carries a dual irony. On one level, it suggests a divine role—one that involves weighing humanity's sins and virtues, with the potential for “annihilation or salvation.” However, his use of legal language—terms like “undertrial,” “defendant,” and “verdict”—paints this judgment as a bureaucratic process, devoid of the moral gravity usually associated with divine intervention. Furthermore, the portrayal of humanity as a “defendant with a rotten record” reveals a cynicism about human nature, reducing complex moral questions to simplistic judgments. In other words, although Gibreel fools Maslama, he is not capable of being the divine arbiter he claims to be.

Part 5, Chapter 1 Quotes

☞☞ Sufyan, taking his cue from his younger daughter, went up to where Chamcha, huddled in his blanket, was drinking enormous quantities of Hind's unrivalled chicken yakhni, squatted down, and placed an arm around the still-shivering unfortunate. "Best place for you is here," he said, speaking as if to a simpleton or small child. "Where else would you go to heal your disfigurements and recover your normal health? Where else but here, with us, among your own people, your own kind?"

Only when Saladin Chamcha was alone in the attic room at the very end of his strength did he answer Sufyan's rhetorical question. "I'm not your kind," he said distinctly into the night. "You're not my people. I've spent half my life trying to get away from you."

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha, Mr. Sufyan (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 261-262

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Saladin has arrived at the Shaandaar Café where Sufyan has decided to take him in. Sufyan's way of comforting Saladin has a paternalistic and perhaps even condescending feel, though Saladin is willing to put up with it given his circumstances. By framing Saladin's healing as something that can only occur among his own people, Sufyan imposes a sense of cultural belonging onto Saladin that feels more restrictive than comforting. Sufyan's words imply that Saladin's disfigurement, both literal and metaphorical, stems from a kind of cultural estrangement and that reintegration with his "own people" is the remedy. Saladin's response to Sufyan, uttered in the solitude of his attic room, starkly rejects this imposed sense of kinship. His response serves as a reassertion of his self-imposed exile from his cultural identity. This rejection is both a denunciation of his cultural heritage and an expression of the identity crisis that defines his character. The isolated attic room where he sits furthers the imagery of dislocation and alienation found in the passage, as Saladin contemplates his Indian identity.

☞☞ I am the incarnation of evil, he thought. He had to face it. However it had happened, it could not be denied. I am *no longer myself*, or not only. I am the embodiment of wrong, of what-we-hate, of sin.

Why? Why me?

What evil had he done -- what vile thing could he, would he do?

For what was he—he couldn't avoid the notion—being punished? And, come to that, by whom? (I held my tongue.)

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 265

Explanation and Analysis

This quote sees Saladin attempting to come to terms with his transformation as he sits alone in the attic of the Shaandaar Café. His declaration, "I am the incarnation of evil," reflects a complete breakdown of his self-concept and a surrender to the idea that he has become something monstrous, both literally and metaphorically. This realization is marked by a sense of inevitability—Saladin doesn't question the transformation itself but rather his own culpability in it, wondering what sin or wrongdoing led to such a fate. Saladin's questioning of his punishment suggests that he is grappling with the idea of divine punishment. He seems to view his transformation as a form of retribution, but he cannot identify any specific crime that warrants such a severe response. This ambiguity intensifies his internal turmoil, as he is left to ponder what unseen forces might be orchestrating his misery. The interjection, "I held my tongue," subtly hints at the presence of a narrator with knowledge or power over Saladin's fate, reinforcing the idea that forces beyond his understanding are at play. The narrator, an omniscient and omnipotent figure—as well as a tongue-in-cheek mouthpiece for Rushdie himself—ultimately has power over Saladin.

Part 5, Chapter 2 Quotes

☛☛ Allie didn't argue with her mother, being by no means certain that she could continue to live with Gibreel, even if he had crossed the earth, even if he had fallen from the sky. The long term was hard to predict; even the medium term looked cloudy. For the moment, she concentrated on trying to get to know this man who had just assumed, right off, that he was the great love of her life, with a lack of doubt that meant he was either right or off his head. There were plenty of difficult moments. She didn't know what he knew, what she could take for granted: she tried, once, referring to Nabokov's doomed chess-player Luzhin, who came to feel that in life as in chess there were certain combinations that would inevitably arise to defeat him, as a way of explaining by analogy her own (in fact somewhat different) sense of impending catastrophe (which had to do not with recurring patterns but with the inescapability of the unforeseeable), but he fixed her with a hurt stare that told her he'd never heard of the writer, let alone *The Defence*.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, Alleluia Cone

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 321

Explanation and Analysis

This quote provides insight into Allie Cone's ambivalence about her relationship with Gibreel Farishta after they reunite in London. Despite the dramatic, almost mythical nature of their meeting—Gibreel literally falls from the sky—Allie remains skeptical about the future of their relationship. The reference to Nabokov's character Luzhin from *The Defense* is particularly telling. In Nabokov's novel, Luzhin is a brilliant but doomed chess player who comes to see his life as a series of inevitable patterns leading to his defeat. Allie uses this reference to articulate her own sense of impending disaster, though her perception is rooted in the "inescapability of the unforeseeable" rather than in predictable patterns. This difference underscores her awareness that chaos, not order, governs life's trajectory. Her attempt to connect with Gibreel through this literary analogy fails, as he is unfamiliar with Nabokov or his works. Gibreel's "hurt stare" signifies not just his ignorance of literature but also his inability to engage with Allie on the intellectual and emotional levels she desires. This disconnect deepens her doubts about him as a life partner.

☛☛ For Blake's Isaiah, God had simply been an immanence, an incorporeal indignation; but Gibreel's vision of the Supreme Being was not abstract in the least. He saw, sitting on the bed, a man of about the same age as himself, of medium height, fairly heavily built, with salt-and-pepper beard cropped close to the line of the jaw. What struck him most was that the apparition was balding, seemed to suffer from dandruff and wore glasses. This was not the Almighty he had expected.

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, Alleluia Cone

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 328-329

Explanation and Analysis

After getting into a fight with Allie, Gibreel sees God in her home, who is far different than he expected. The depiction of God as a middle-aged, balding man with a salt-and-pepper beard and glasses—features that align closely with Rushdie's own appearance—suggests that the author is deliberately inserting himself into the narrative in the guise of the divine. This act of self-insertion blurs the lines between author, narrator, and character, enhancing the novel's metafictional quality. By portraying God with his own physical attributes, Rushdie challenges abstract conceptions of divinity, suggesting that the divine might be more human and fallible than religious doctrine typically imagines it to be.

This representation may also hint at the author's role in the creation of the novel's world. In this passage, Rushdie fashions himself as an omnipotent creator who, despite his power, remains deeply human, with all the flaws and vulnerabilities that entails. Furthermore, this encounter invites readers to question the nature of authority in literature. If God—the ultimate authority figure—can resemble the author, it suggests that the boundaries between fiction and reality are porous, with the creator's presence influencing the narrative directly. Of course, this is something that the reader is always aware of in the back of their mind, but Rushdie brings it to the forefront of his narrative in this passage.

Part 6 Quotes

☞☞ Mahound had no time for scruples, Salman told Baal, no qualms about ends and means. The faithful lived by lawlessness, but in those years Mahound— or should one say the Archangel Gibreel? — should one say Al-Lah? — became obsessed by law. Amid the palm-trees of the oasis Gibreel appeared to the Prophet and found himself spouting rules, rules, rules, until the faithful could scarcely bear the prospect of any more revelation, Salman said, rules about every damn thing, if a man farts let him turn his face to the wind, a rule about which hand to use for the purpose of cleaning one's behind. It was as if no aspect of human existence was to be left unregulated, free.

Related Characters: Baal, Salman, Mahound

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 375-376

Explanation and Analysis

This quote explores the relationship between religion, law, and personal freedom as a lens to critique the increasing legalism in religious doctrine. Salman, a scribe who becomes disillusioned with Mahound, reflects on how the Prophet transforms from a spiritual leader to a figure obsessed with regulations. The reference to Mahound's association with the Archangel Gibreel and even Al-Lah (God) suggests a blurring of identities, which questions who truly speaks through these revelations—the divine, the angel, or the Prophet himself. Salman's description of Gibreel "spouting rules, rules, rules" captures the overwhelming shift from a more spontaneous, morally guided spirituality to one dominated by an endless series of legalistic decrees. The rules range from the profound to the absurd, as shown by the mention of regulations on which direction to face when passing gas and how to clean oneself. These trivial details highlight how religion's expansion into legalism can stifle personal freedom and reduce spirituality to a series of mechanical, prescribed actions. The passage critiques the nature of religious authority and shows how it can become excessively preoccupied with control, ultimately alienating and sometimes exploiting the faithful.

☞☞ 'In the old days you mocked the Recitation,' Mahound said in the hush. 'Then, too, these people enjoyed your mockery. Now you return to dishonour my house, and it seems that once again you succeed in bringing the worst out of the people.'

Baal said, 'I've finished. Do what you want.'

So he was sentenced to be beheaded, within the hour, and as soldiers manhandled him out of the tent towards the killing ground, he shouted over his shoulder: 'Whores and writers, Mahound. We are the people you can't forgive.'

Mahound replied, 'Writers and whores. I see no difference here.'

Related Characters: Baal, Mahound (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 404-405

Explanation and Analysis

This quote presents a confrontation between Mahound and Baal, a poet who has mocked Mahound's revelations and defied his authority. The exchange captures a conflict over freedom of expression and the boundaries of religious authority. Mahound's opening statement reflects his awareness of Baal's history of satirical critique against his teachings, or "the Recitation," which is a thinly veiled reference to the Quran. Mahound accuses Baal of corrupting the people by bringing out the worst in them, implying that satire leads to moral decay. This accusation highlights Mahound's desire to control not only religious adherence but also public discourse, seeing any challenge to his authority as a threat that needs to be swiftly neutralized.

Baal's response is a defiant statement that aligns writers with society's marginalized and condemned, suggesting that both are persecuted for their transgressive roles. His grouping of "whores and writers" together implies that both groups disrupt established orders and challenge societal boundaries. The phrase underscores the idea that both artists and those who are sexually liberated represent a freedom that authoritarian power structures find intolerable. Meanwhile, Mahound's cold retort strips both professions of their subversive power by reducing them to a single category of deviance in his eyes. By equating writers and sex workers, Mahound dismisses the value of both creative and personal freedom, framing them as elements that destabilize his authority. His refusal to see a difference between them suggests that for him, the freedom to speak critically is as dangerous as sexual acts that contravene moral codes.

Part 7, Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ Culture, city, wife; and a fourth and final love, of which he had spoken to nobody: the love of a dream. In the old days the dream had recurred about once a month; a simple dream, set in a city park, along an avenue of mature elms, whose overarching branches turned the avenue into a green tunnel into which the sky and the sunlight were dripping, here and there, through the perfect imperfections in the canopy of leaves. In this sylvan secrecy, Saladin saw himself, accompanied by a small boy of about five, whom he was teaching to ride a bicycle. The boy, wobbling alarmingly at first, made heroic efforts to gain and maintain his balance, with the ferocity of one who wishes his father to be proud of him. The dream-Chamcha ran along behind his imagined son, holding the bike upright by gripping the parcel-rack over the rear wheel.

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 414

Explanation and Analysis

This quote sees Saladin thinking about a life he always wanted but never managed to achieve. The dream of guiding his son through a serene park as he learns to ride a bike demonstrates Saladin's longing for paternal connection, which he has been unable to have due to his broken marriage and his biology. The imagery of the park, with its overarching elms and filtered sunlight, evokes a sense of calm—an escape from the chaos of Saladin's real life. Saladin's dream represents his wish for a nurturing role in which he can provide support and encouragement, something he feels is missing in his actual relationships. Here, Saladin imagines a father-son relationship that he never had himself—one that is built on mutual respect and pride. Saladin never felt like he was able to make his father proud, which is why he wants to display pride to this imaginary child. In a sense, Saladin is also the boy on the bike because the boy on the bike represents what Saladin feels his childhood should have been like.

☞ Chamcha recommended caution. Recalling Mishal Sufyan's loathing for Simba, he said: "The fellow has—has he not?—a record of violence towards women . . ." Jumpy turned his palms outward. "In his personal life," he owned, "the guy's frankly a piece of shit. But that doesn't mean he disembowels senior citizens; you don't have to be an angel to be innocent. Unless, of course, you're black." Chamcha let this pass. "The point is, this isn't personal, it's political," Jumpy emphasized, adding, as he got up to leave, "Um, there's a public meeting about it tomorrow. Pamela and I have to go; please, I mean if you'd like, if you'd be interested, that is, come along if you want."

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha, Jumpy Joshi (speaker), Uhuru Simba, Mishal Sufyan

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 426

Explanation and Analysis

This passage delves into the complexities of personal morality versus political activism, as Saladin and Jumpy discuss the political persecution of Dr. Uhuru Simba, a Black activist with a questionable past. Saladin's hesitation about Simba stems from his history of violence against women, reflecting a concern about the moral implications of supporting someone with such a record. His cautious approach highlights his discomfort with the potential fallout of aligning with a problematic figure.

Jumpy, however, brings a different perspective by pointing out the racial double standards at play. He suggests that while Simba may be flawed, these flaws don't inherently make him guilty of every accusation leveled against him. His statement about how innocence is often denied to Black people critiques the systemic racism that skews society's perception of people of color. This shifts the conversation from Simba's personal failings to a critique of societal biases. Jumpy's perspective is hard for someone like Saladin, who also thinks of himself as an individual first, to see. For Jumpy, Simba represents an ideal—a sort of prophet-like figure. Like all the prophets in the novel, Simba is personally flawed, which people are willing to overlook because he represents a broader cause that they find important.

Part 7, Chapter 2 Quotes

☞ The moment Saladin Chamcha got close enough to Allie Cone to be transfixed, and somewhat chilled, by her eyes, he felt his reborn animosity towards Gibreel extending itself to her, with her degree-zero go-to-hell look, her air of being privy to some great, secret mystery of the universe; also, her quality of what he would afterwards think of as *wilderness*, a hard, sparse thing, antisocial, self-contained, an essence. Why did it annoy him so much? Why, before she'd even opened her mouth, had he characterized her as part of the enemy?

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, Saladin Chamcha, Alleluia Cone

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 442

Explanation and Analysis

This passage describes the first time Saladin meets Allie and Saladin's reunion with Gibreel. Saladin's existing relationship with Gibreel shapes how he sees Allie, as he immediately thinks of her as his adversary. This reaction suggests that Saladin's bitterness and sense of betrayal have started to warp his perceptions, causing him to view anyone associated with Gibreel as a threat. Allie's presence forces Saladin to confront aspects of his own identity, especially his insecurities and feelings of inadequacy, which his experiences and relationship with Gibreel magnify.

Although Gibreel finds Allie threatening, he also manages to be attracted to her. Perhaps his envy and his attraction are one and the same, as he finds her transfixed in part because she seems to have figured out something he has not. In reality, Allie does not feel any surer of herself than Saladin, but it is Saladin's belief, rather than Allie's reality, that matters here. It is this first impression of Allie that drives Saladin's desire for revenge to a new level, which ultimately results in the destruction of Allie's relationship with Gibreel.

☞ "Minnamin, Gut mag alkan, Pern dirstan," Chamcha replied. "It means, 'My darling, God makes hungry, the Devil thirsty.' Nabokov."

"Him again," Gibreel complained. "What bloody language?"

"He made it up. It's what Kinbote's Zemblan nurse tells him as a child. In [Pale Fire](#)."

"Perndirstan," Farishta repeated. "Sounds like a country: Hell, maybe. I give up, anyway. How are you supposed to read a man who writes in a made-up lingo of his own?"

Related Characters: Gibreel Farishta, Saladin Chamcha (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 456

Explanation and Analysis

This quote alludes to Vladimir Nabokov's *Pale Fire* and uses this reference to explore the function of language within the novel. When Saladin says "Minnamin, Gut mag alkan, Pern dirstan," he is referencing a line from *Pale Fire*, a novel where Nabokov creates a fictional language called Zemblan. In Nabokov's novel Zemblan is the language spoken in the fictional land of Zembla. Kinbote, one of *Pale Fire*'s central characters, is an unreliable narrator who constructs a distorted version of reality around himself. Saladin's allusion to Nabokov's invented language highlights a parallel to *The Satanic Verses*, where the boundaries between reality, myth, and narrative are similarly blurred. Just as Nabokov uses Zemblan to emphasize the instability of meaning and the unreliability of narratives, Rushdie employs shifting narratives and magical realism to challenge readers' perceptions of truth.

Gibreel's frustration with Nabokov's "made-up lingo" indicates his discomfort with ambiguity and his preference for clear, straightforward interpretations. His exasperation reflects his struggle to navigate the uncertain terrain of the novel's narrative, where reality and illusion intermingle. This reaction also mirrors his own experiences of losing a stable sense of self and being caught in a narrative he does not fully control or understand.

Part 8 Quotes

☞ "They are going to die," Saeed replied.

It was too late. The villagers, whose heads could be seen bobbing about in the distance, had reached the edge of the underwater shelf. Almost all together, making no visible attempt to save themselves, they dropped beneath the water's surface. In moments, every one of the Ayesha Pilgrims had sunk out of sight.

None of them reappeared. Not a single gasping head or thrashing arm.

Related Characters: Mirza Saeed Akhtar (speaker), Ayesha of Dash

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 517

Explanation and Analysis

This passage describes the tragic end of the Ayesha Pilgrims, who, under the influence of the zealot Ayesha, blindly follow her into the sea, believing it will part for them as a divine miracle. The scene captures a moment of collective faith turned fatal, illustrating the dangers of blind obedience to charismatic leaders. The description of the villagers “making no visible attempt to save themselves” shows their absolute faith in Ayesha’s vision and their resignation to whatever fate awaits them. The lack of struggle to survive suggests that they are entirely convinced of the righteousness of their actions or are too deep into their delusion to recognize the imminent danger they’ve put themselves in. This fatalistic march into the sea becomes a powerful image of devotion crossing the line into self-destructive fanaticism. The line “None of them reappeared” emphasizes the finality of their demise. It points to the chilling reality that belief, when unmoored from reason, can lead to catastrophic ends. Water, which is typically a symbol for cleansing and renewal, here becomes a horrible deathbed for those who are blinded by faith.

Related Characters: Saladin Chamcha, Zeeny Vakil (speaker), Gibreel Farishta

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 561

Explanation and Analysis

This final scene in the novel depicts Saladin standing at the window of his childhood home, as he confronts the tension between his past and his desire to move forward. The sea and moonlight create an image that suggests the allure of hope and fantasy. However, Saladin dismisses these illusions, recognizing them as remnants of a childhood perspective that he no longer finds credible. This realization marks his acceptance that holding onto the past prevents growth. Saladin’s decision to let go of his sentimental attachments and his readiness to embrace change reflects a significant turning point. By acknowledging the need to let the “old” be replaced, he embraces the possibility of starting anew. Unlike the last time he was reborn alongside Gibreel, this is a willing rebirth, as Saladin is eager to start his new life with Zeeny. At this point, Saladin has accepted his Indian heritage and is eager to begin a new life among those he once turned his back on. Unlike Gibreel, whose life ends in tragedy, Saladin—who was a devil-like figure not so long ago—has found a way to move forward.

Part 9 Quotes

☛ He stood at the window of his childhood and looked out at the Arabian Sea. The moon was almost full; moonlight, stretching from the rocks of Scandal Point out to the far horizon, created the illusion of a silver pathway, like a parting in the water’s shining hair, like a road to miraculous lands. He shook his head; could no longer believe in fairy-tales. Childhood was over, and the view from this window was no more than an old and sentimental echo. To the devil with it! Let the bulldozers come. If the old refused to die, the new could not be born.

“Come along,” Zeenat Vakil’s voice said at his shoulder. It seemed that in spite of all his wrong-doing, weakness, guilt—in spite of his humanity—he was getting another chance. There was no accounting for one’s good fortune, that was plain. There it simply was, taking his elbow in its hand. “My place,” Zeeny offered. “Let’s get the hell out of here.”

“I’m coming,” he answered her, and turned away from the view.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

PART 1, CHAPTER 1

Sometime around New Year's Day, on a cold winter morning, two men are freefalling from 29,002 feet in the sky. One of the men, Gibreel Farishta, is singing happily and striking various poses in the air. The other man, Saladin Chamcha, is irritated by Gibreel's levity and tells him to be quiet. A narrator reveals that the men are freefalling because they were on a flight (Flight 420) that exploded. All around them, other people and objects from the flight are also falling. Gibreel continues to sing. The narrator notes that it should not be possible for Saladin to hear Gibreel, and yet, he does hear him.

As Saladin and Gibreel fall through a thick layer of clouds, Gibreel maneuvers through the air and grabs ahold of Saladin. Saladin is falling upside-down, while Gibreel is positioned upright. While Gibreel is holding on to Saladin, Gibreel's deceased lover, Rekha, appears on a flying carpet. To Gibreel's surprise, Saladin cannot see or hear Rekha. Gibreel and Rekha insult each other, clearly not over whatever ended their relationship. Both imply that the other did something wrong, though they do not speak in specifics. Rekha curses Gibreel and warns him that he is headed to hell. Then, she disappears just as Saladin and Gibreel exit through the bottom layer of clouds.

Saladin tells Gibreel that they must fly and sing. He does not understand where his orders come from. He feels a new force within him rise up and give these instructions. It is as if he has undergone some kind of transformation—one that he will later deny—which he does not understand. Both men begin flapping their arms and singing, allowing them to float down safely into the English Channel.

The novel begins in the middle of the action, as two men are falling through the sky without a specific explanation for what happened to their flight. Rushdie is writing in the genre of magic realism which combines realistic narrative techniques with surreal or fantastical elements. In this novel, the narration makes no attempt to explain the plot's fantastical elements—rather, the reader must simply accept them at face value. Additionally, many of the scene in the novel parallel scenes from Islamic texts such as the Quran. Like the Christian Bible, Islam has an account of the Fall of Man. In Islam, this descent to Earth is not seen as a curse or original sin that affects all of humanity. Instead, the fall is a test for Adam, Hawwa (the Islamic equivalent of Eve), and their descendants. Islam sees humans as born without sin and fully capable of choosing between right and wrong, with guidance provided by God through prophets.



The position of the two men falling together through the clouds symbolically suggests an underlying similarity between the two of them. This similarity becomes more obvious as the novel progresses. Meanwhile, Rekha is a figure who will haunt Gibreel throughout the novel and serves as a manifestation of Gibreel's guilt.



The novel regularly examines whether certain actions or orders indeed come from God. In this case, it seems completely out of character for Saladin to suggest that he and Gibreel fly and sing, yet he does it anyway. It is this order that ultimately saves Gibreel and Saladin, who otherwise would have fallen to their deaths, indicating divine intervention.



Some unknown amount of time later, Saladin and Gibreel wash up on a beach—the only two people to survive the disaster. After the incident, Gibreel is convinced that something supernatural—perhaps divine—allowed them to live. Meanwhile, Saladin believes that they were simply lucky. Here, the narrator interrupts to say that they know the truth of what happened because they watched it occur. The narrator does not reveal their identity, though they do describe themselves as an omnipotent and omnipresent force. Back on the beach, Gibreel wishes Saladin a happy birthday and Saladin bursts into tears.

The narrator is an interesting force in the novel because, although the narrative mostly reads as though it is written in third-person, the narrator repeatedly interjects in ways that makes it seem as if the story is actually a first-person retelling of events. Rushdie employs this narrative technique to play with the idea that his third-person omniscient narrator is God, a figure who is also supposed to be all-knowing. As Gibreel and Saladin arrive on the beach, Gibreel embraces the idea that they have been reborn, whereas Saladin appears deeply upset by the turn of events and does not agree with Gibreel's framing of their situation.



PART 1, CHAPTER 2

For 15 years, Gibreel is the most famous actor in India. However, just before his 40th birthday, Gibreel disappears, and no one knows what happened to him. The first people to notice Gibreel's absence are members of his wheelchair team. Because Gibreel was making so many movies at once, he hired a group of people to push him around in a wheelchair from set to set. When the wheelchair team reports Gibreel's absence, the movie executives begin panicking. In recent years, much of their audience has switched over to television, and Gibreel's presence is the only thing that has kept people invested in the movies.

One of Gibreel's co-stars, Miss Pimple Billimoria, is also upset that Gibreel has not arrived on set, as the movie they are working on is supposed to be her big break. When she realizes Gibreel is not coming, she storms off the set, saying she is glad that he did not show up because they were supposed to shoot a love scene, and she did not want to deal with his **horrible breath**. Although Miss Pimple Billimoria is being spiteful, the narrator acknowledges that what she says is true: Gibreel's breath is exceedingly foul.

In Gibreel's apartment—which is in Everest Vilas, the most luxurious complex in Bombay—the police find an enigmatic note that reads, “*We are creatures of air. Our roots in dreams And clouds, reborn In flight. Goodbye.*” Gibreel's disappearance and the note are widely reported on because he is such a prominent figure. Meanwhile, Rekha lives in the apartment below Gibreel with her husband and two children. When she hears about Gibreel's disappearance, she writes a suicide note, and then she throws herself and her two children off the roof of Everest Vilas. Before killing herself, Rekha circles the words from Gibreel's note with a red pen in her copy of the newspaper, leading the public to speculate about the nature of their relationship.

Although the chronology of the novel eventually becomes clear, the narration does not explicitly signal when he is jumping forward and backward in time. Here, the story moves backward in time to explain Gibreel's perspective leading up to the explosion on Flight 420. In India, Gibreel is treated as a sort of god, with people attending to his every need because he is singlehandedly keeping the movie industry afloat.



The novel is packed full of minor characters, often with eccentric names, that are loosely based on real life figures. For instance, there are multiple famous Indian actors with the last name Bilimoria and there is also an actress named Dimple Kapadia. Rushdie has punned on Kapadia's first name and added an 'l' to Bilimoria to create Pimple Billimoria. Additionally, this is the first time the novel introduces Gibreel's bad breath, which suggests that, despite how he might look on the outside, he is somehow rotten on the inside.



Mount Everest is a motif that appears throughout the story. The height from which Gibreel and Saladin fall in the previous chapter (29,002 feet) is the same height as Mount Everest. Here, Gibreel's apartment complex—from which other characters fall—is named Everest Vilas. Other connections will pop up as the story continues. Although falling from this great height symbolizes rebirth in the first chapter, here it becomes a gruesome death. To the extent Rekha is reborn afterward, it is only as a spiteful figure that haunts Gibreel's imagination.



In part, Gibreel's disappearance is so shocking to the public because he is like a god to them. Not only was he India's biggest actor, but he also made a career out of playing various Gods in "theologicals," a popular subgenre of Indian cinema. Despite the godlike status he achieved, Gibreel comes from humble beginnings. His birth name is Ismail Najmuddin, and he was born in the later years of British Imperialism in Mumbai (the Indian name for Bombay).

While on Flight 420, Gibreel talks to Saladin about his childhood. As a child, Gibreel works with his father, Najmuddin Senior, delivering food. It is a difficult job and Gibreel returns home exhausted every day. While Gibreel is still a child, his mother, Naima, is hit and killed by a bus. Later, when Gibreel is a young man, Najmuddin Senior dies from a stroke. After Najmuddin Senior's death, a childless couple, Babasaheb Mhatre and his wife, Mrs. Mhatre, take him in.

Babasaheb Mhatre helps Gibreel secure a job at a movie studio, where he adopts the name Gibreel Farishta, inspired by his mother's nickname for him, "personal angel." Initially, Gibreel plays minor roles, but his career soars when he started portraying deities. The public, especially women, become smitten with Gibreel—he seems godlike. During this period, Gibreel begins his affair with Rekha, whom he meets after moving into Everest Vilas. Rekha's husband is an international businessman who is always gone. Lonely, Rekha immediately takes an interest in Gibreel and has sex with him the first day she meets him. Gibreel enjoys his time with Rekha, but he does not love her. Often, they fight.

One day, while on the set of a movie, Gibreel fails to get up after taking a fake punch in a fight scene. Gibreel is rushed to the hospital where he learns that he has a great deal of internal bleeding, and his doctors cannot figure out the cause. After falling ill, Gibreel prays to Allah for his recovery, but, over time, he loses his faith in the possibility of a divine being. Nonetheless, he miraculously gets better. Upon recovering, Gibreel goes to a hotel buffet and eats pork. At the hotel, he meets Alleluia Cone, a beautiful blonde woman, and falls in love. Immediately after, he ends his relationship with Rekha to focus on Alleluia. However, after seeing Alleluia for only a short time, their relationship starts to go downhill. Before long, Alleluia leaves Gibreel. Days later, Gibreel composes his mysterious note and boards Flight 420 to London.

In the theologicals, Gibreel is acting as a mouthpiece for Gods, making him a sort of prophet. This contrast between Gibreel's humble beginning and the elevated status he has achieved as an actor underscores the public's fascination with him, making his vanishing all the more unsettling and amplifying his mythic presence in both cinema and society.



Here, Rushdie jumps forward in time to when Gibreel is already on Flight 420, only to then go back in time once more. Despite the status in society Gibreel has achieved as an adult, his background is full of tragedy. These childhood events inform the rest of his life, though it is a part of him that he hides from the public.



In Islamic tradition, Gibreel is an archangel, one of the highest-ranking angels. He is considered the messenger of God who delivered divine revelations to the prophets. Gibreel is particularly significant for his role in transmitting the Quran to the Prophet Muhammad, conveying God's words verbatim. However, Gibreel's affair with Rekha shows that despite his angelic name and god-like status on the big screen, Gibreel's behavior in his personal life is far from saintly.



Gibreel praying to Allah suggests that he comes from a Muslim background. Yet, in movies, he portrays Hindu deities. Although he engages in prayer, there is a sense that his belief in a God of any kind was never very deep to begin with. Notably, eating pork is forbidden in Islam, so Gibreel eating it immediately following his recovery is a deliberately blasphemous act. Alleluia—whose name is an alternative spelling of "hallelujah"—also has a divinely inspired name. Yet, despite how special she seems at the time, she is out of Gibreel's life almost as soon as she comes into it.



PART 1, CHAPTER 3

As Flight 420 takes off, Saladin Chamcha crosses his fingers, a superstitious habit of his. He has just completed a trip to his hometown of Bombay, which he regrets. Saladin spent much of his life running away from India and his Indian identity; in particular, he has tried to disguise his accent. However, after returning home only a brief time, his accent starts to come back, which frustrates him.

In a flashback, Saladin (full name Salahuddin Chamchawala) is a child living in Bombay. One day, while riding home on a bus, Saladin finds a wallet full of English currency. Excited, he takes it home, feeling as though providence has smiled upon him. However, Saladin's father, Changez Chamchawala, confiscates the wallet, taking it for himself. Changez is a leader of India's nationalist movement, who much of the public loves. In contrast, Saladin dislikes his father, whose presence he finds suffocating, and wants to escape him. Saladin wants to leave India for London and loves English culture so much that he even roots for England when India plays them in cricket. The one thing Saladin likes about his father is that he owns a **magic lamp**, which Saladin perceives as lucky. Changez refuses to let anyone touch the magic lamp, but Saladin hopes he will inherit it one day.

One day, when Saladin is 13, he is playing alone among some rocks. While exploring, he sees an old man who motions to Saladin to be quiet. Then, the old man beckons Saladin toward him. When Saladin approaches the old man, the man grabs him and forces Saladin to touch his genitals. This incident deeply disturbs Saladin, who never mentions it to anyone. After this moment, Saladin realizes that he must escape Bombay once and for all. Otherwise, he feels he will die.

Saladin's prayers are answered when, seemingly out of nowhere, Changez offers to send him to England for schooling. Saladin's mother, Nasreen, hates the idea of Saladin leaving India and protests. However, Changez insists it is a good idea. In the end, Saladin is allowed to go, but Nasreen refuses to go to the airport to send him off. On the plane to England, Saladin reads science fiction novels about interplanetary travel such as *The Martian Chronicles* and *Foundation*. On the airplane, Saladin thinks about his relationship with Changez. He used to have a great relationship with his father until he started questioning Changez's thoughts and opinions. After that, Changez treated him like a traitor. Even so, Changez traveled with Saladin to London and then, in London, returned the stolen wallet to him with all the money still inside.

Identity, particularly as it relates to immigrants, is a key theme that runs throughout the novel. In Saladin's case, he is attempting to run away from India and being Indian. However, as his returning accent demonstrates, running away from his national and cultural identity is not something he can do forever.



Saladin, like Gibreel, does not use the name he was born with. In Gibreel's case, he changes his name to match the divine characters he is portraying on screen. Meanwhile, Saladin changes his name to make it more palatable to an English audience. When Saladin was a child, India was fighting for its independence—symbolically, then, rooting for the British in a sporting event is a far greater transgression that it may seem. In part, it seems Saladin was eager to support the English because it was a way to rebel against his nationalistic father. Meanwhile, the magic lamp is an important symbol not only because it is lucky but also because Saladin views it as something to inherit. It is a part of his culture and heritage that he would be happy to have, but, at least for the moment, the lamp remains beyond reach.



Because Saladin never processes this incident, it is difficult for him to articulate how it affects him emotionally and psychologically for the rest of his life. Regardless, this is the moment where he feels definitively as though there is something rotten in India; something that wants to pray on him and eventually kill him.



Changez's sudden change of heart is a surprise given how much his identity is wrapped up in his Indian identity and culture. Nasreen's refusal to see her only son off as he departs is another instance of Saladin feeling that his parents do not love him, which increases his sense of alienation from India. The science fiction books Saladin is reading—written by Ray Bradbury and Isaac Asimov, respectively—are stories about traveling to new planets and exploring different cultures and societies. Their themes fit with the journey on which Saladin is currently embarking.



However, after Changez gives Saladin the wallet, Changez stops paying for things. The year is 1961 and Saladin is still a teenage boy. Changez lives with Saladin in London but refuses to help him with anything. However, Saladin does not care—he is too thrilled with the idea of becoming English. At school, other children make fun of his accent and do nothing to help him adjust to life in England. However, he is determined to become an Englishman nevertheless and internally vows revenge. Around this time, Saladin begins referring to himself as Saladin instead of Salahuddin, as that is what his English classmates call him.

After five years of schooling in London, Saladin returns home to Bombay. There, Nasreen makes it a point to tease Saladin for what she perceives as a haughty attitude toward India now that Saladin thinks of himself as English. Although he does not say anything out loud, Saladin does not take the teasing well. Really, though, Saladin is angry with Changez. During a tense moment when all three family members are together, Changez explodes on Saladin because he hates what his son has become. Saladin responds, “Whatever I am, father dear [...], I owe it all to you.” This is the last chat Saladin ever has with his mother and father at the same time.

In September of the same year, India goes to war with Pakistan. In a show of solidarity for her Hindu and Muslim friends, Nasreen throws a dinner party and invites them over. During the party, air raid sirens erupt, and everyone runs and hides except Nasreen, who wants to show that there is no real danger. While everyone else is hiding, Nasreen continues to eat her fish and ends up choking on a bone. Because no one is around to help her, the incident kills Nasreen. One year later, while Saladin is in college in London, Changez marries another woman named Nasreen.

When Changez informs Saladin of his new marriage, Saladin grows irate, and their relationship sours even further. A few years later, Saladin finishes college and informs Changez that he plans to be an actor, which all but dooms his relationship with his father, who thinks the devil has possessed Saladin. Changez tells Saladin that he will never inherit his **magic lamp**.

Although Changez giving Saladin the wallet initially seems like a kind gesture, it is really just Changez’s way of teaching Saladin a lesson. The same might be said about Changez’s decision to allow Saladin to come to an English school. He wants his son to see how the English will treat him and make him understand that he does not belong in England. However, Saladin is willing to fight against negative influences from both Indian and English people to achieve the goal of becoming an Englishman himself.



Saladin’s return to Bombay after being educated in London highlights the tension between his adopted English identity and his Indian roots. Nasreen’s teasing and Changez’s anger reveal the generational and cultural conflict within the family. Saladin’s response to his father suggests a deep-seated resentment, as he feels that his father is responsible for his cultural dislocation. He has situated his identity as necessarily in conflict with his father’s. Changez wants to represent India, so Saladin wants to represent England.



The war mentioned is the India-Pakistan conflict of 1965. The conflict was primarily triggered by territorial disputes over Kashmir, a region both nations claimed. The war lasted from April to September of 1965 and involved large-scale tank battles and air strikes. Nasreen’s refusal to move during the dinner party is a political act that ultimately ends in her demise, albeit in an unlucky and bizarre fashion. Changez’s decision to marry another woman with the same name only a year later suggests that he has not truly moved on and is attempting to recreate the past.



Every decision Saladin makes goes against Changez’s idea of what it means to be an Indian man. This idea that Saladin is demonically possessed is one that will recur throughout the novel. Because of Saladin’s career decisions, Changez cuts him off from the magic lamp, the one object from his childhood that Saladin truly cares about.



In the late 1960s, Saladin meets Pamela Lovelace, a fellow actor, and they get married a few years later. However, Saladin has a hard time getting Pamela to open up to him. Eventually, when it is already too late to save their marriage, Saladin learns that Pamela's parents died by suicide when she was young. Additionally, he learns that he is unable to have children, which puts more strain on their relationship.

While in India for a role, Saladin starts an affair with Zeeny Vakil, a Marxist writer passionate about Indian culture and identity. Zeeny attempts to reconnect him with his roots in Bombay. One night, after a show, Zeeny takes Saladin out drinking with a few of her friends. One of Zeeny's friends begins a passionate political debate, which causes Saladin to feel overwhelmed. He realizes he no longer feels truly connected to India.

Saladin and Zeeny have a conversation about Saladin's work as an actor. The TV show Saladin is most famous for is a sitcom about aliens that receives censure from both conservative and liberal critics. Conservatives think the show is too sexually explicit, while liberals think that the show has racist implications, as the alien characters are played by non-white actors. Zeeny teases and criticizes Saladin for using accents in his roles, which she thinks are offensive. Saladin defends himself, thinking there is nothing wrong with the way he acts. To him, the accents he uses are part of his talent. Zeeny also points out that Saladin only ever appears on television if he is in some sort of costume. He is never allowed to look as he does in everyday life. For that, he has to be part of a theatre troupe that travels all the way to India.

During their conversation, Saladin mentions Changez. Zeeny recognizes the name because of Changez's involvement in politics. When Saladin mentions that is thinking of visiting Changez, Zeeny convinces him to take her along. Together, Saladin and Zeeny travel to Saladin's childhood home. There, Saladin finds that his home looks exactly the same as he left it except that everything is rundown. His housekeeper, Vallabhbhai, answers the door and invites him inside. There, Saladin sees what he thinks is the ghost of Nasreen, though it is really just Kasturba, Vallabhbhai's wife, wearing Saladin's mother's clothes. Saladin learns that Changez has demanded that the entire house be kept as it was following Nasreen's death.

Although some sections of the novel are elongated and examined in detail, others gloss over significant developments in the lives of its characters. Saladin's relationship with Pamela, for instance, is over before it really begins as far as the reader is concerned.



Zeeny and her friends, like Changez, represent a kind of Indian politics and identity that makes Saladin deeply uncomfortable. Because he ran away from India and his Indian identity, he struggles to deal with people who seem to have done the opposite. Although he is not necessarily ashamed of his alternate path through life, he has a hard time explaining himself to someone like Zeeny.



Zeeny wants Saladin to understand that the roles he plays in his television show reinforce negative stereotypes about immigrants. In other words, the British television producers are merely using him to reinforce their xenophobic agenda. However, Saladin sees things differently; he thinks of himself only as an actor—not an Indian actor. Even if one grants Saladin this point, Rushdie uses this argument to underline an obvious contrast between the roles Saladin gets—which are questionable at best—and those Gibreel gets, as he literally portrays Gods.



The unchanged yet rundown state of Saladin's childhood home symbolizes his arrested development and his stagnated connection to his past. The house represents a frozen memory, kept in a state of disrepair as if time has stopped since Nasreen's death. The ghostly vision of Nasreen suggests that Saladin's past haunts him. Of course, that his house remains in disrepair indicates that Changez has not moved on, either. Regardless of whether either would admit it, both father and son are stuck in the past.



Changez comes to see Saladin and Zeeny, but it is not a happy reunion. Although Changez is still married to the other Nasreen, it quickly becomes clear to Saladin that he is also carrying on an affair with Kasturba. Evidently, Vallabhbhai is aware of this arrangement, and Changez pays them extra to allow it to happen. Before long, Saladin and Changez get into a big fight. Changez tells Zeeny that she should listen carefully to both sides of the argument and decide a winner at the end. For his part, Saladin blames Changez for the way his life has unfolded. Meanwhile, Changez reminds him that they have not spoken in a long time and, therefore, he cannot be blamed for how Saladin's life turned out. Changez also tells Saladin that he has no interest in continuing their relationship, making Saladin realize that the **magic lamp** is lost to him forever.

After the argument, Zeeny declares Changez the winner, which makes Saladin furious. Back at Saladin's hotel, he and Zeeny get into a fight about Saladin's identity and his relationship with Changez. Although Saladin thinks Zeeny is only trying to score political points, Zeeny assures him that she initially wanted to help him. However, at this point, Saladin thinks there is nothing left for him in India. He wants to return to England where he can switch back to a version of himself that makes him feel comfortable. As such, he packs up his things and boards Flight 420 to London.

PART 1, CHAPTER 4

While traveling to London on Flight 420, Saladin sees a woman on the plane who he thinks he recognizes from one of his dreams. In the dream, the woman is a suicide bomber with a Canadian accent. The woman on the plane is holding what looks like a child so close to her chest that Saladin cannot tell if it is really a child or a bomb. After seeing the woman, Saladin takes a brief nap. When he opens his eyes again, he sees Gibreel Farishta. Although Gibreel looks different in person than on the movie screen, Saladin recognizes him immediately.

Seated next to Saladin on the plane is a man named Eugene Dumsday, an American with a Southern accent. Eugene tells Saladin that he traveled to India to spread word about the dangers of Darwinism. Eugene is a highly religious man who believes the teachings of Darwin will disrupt the spiritual lives of anyone who comes across them. Saladin asks Eugene how the Indian people received him. Eugene admits that people were not particularly receptive to his message, much to his dismay. Saladin chuckles in response, which makes Eugene angry. Then, Saladin goes back to sleep.

The affair between Changez and Kasturba, with Vallabhbhai's complicity, reveals the moral decay that Changez has allowed to degrade his life. Meanwhile, Saladin's attempt to blame Changez for his life's trajectory suggests a desire to hold someone else accountable for how his life turned out, even though he has been on his own for a long time. However, Changez's dismissal of this blame forces Saladin to confront the reality that he is now disconnected from the heritage and familial ties that once defined him. The severing of this connection also means that Saladin will never get his hands on the object he desires: the magic lamp.



Zeeny's declaration that Changez is the winner of their argument further alienates Saladin and exacerbates his feelings of betrayal. This moment is crucial: Zeeny's siding with Changez represents a broader societal judgment against Saladin's choices and identity. He wants to return to England so desperately because, in England, he can hide behind the mask of his acting. To some extent, he enjoys the superficial way the English perceive him as to the more complex, messy way Zeeny and Changez see him.



The image of a woman with a child is typically something one would associate with love and life. However, for Saladin, this woman seems more like a harbinger of death and destruction. Saladin's flight becomes increasingly surreal when Gibreel—who everyone thinks has gone missing—also appears on the plane. At this point, Saladin and Gibreel do not know each other, but Saladin is aware of Gibreel because of his fame as an actor.



Dumsday is an American with no understanding of how a non-Western audience would receive his message. Saladin laughs at Eugene because he knows the reception Eugene received without needing Eugene to tell him. Although Eugene is a caricature rather than a nuanced character and the novel does not take him seriously, the novel is interested in the power of religion and how religious dogma captures the minds of those who fall victim to it.



When Saladin wakes up, Sikh terrorists are in the process of hijacking the plane. There are four terrorists in total, three men and one woman. The woman, Tavleen, is the same woman Saladin noticed before. Additionally, she has a Canadian accent, just like she did in his dream. Tavleen has explosives strapped to her entire body and threatens to explode them if her directions are not followed. Saladin can tell that Tavleen is more serious about her mission than the other terrorists and reminds himself not to take her lightly. Tavleen and her comrades order the pilot to land the plane, which the pilot does.

Then, slowly, the terrorists begin releasing hostages until they get down to a reasonable number. Women, children, and Sikhs are released first. For the most part, all of the men are forced to stay on the plane with the exception of Dumsday, who accidentally bites off his own tongue after one of the terrorists hits him in the head with the butt of a gun. The terrorists decide it would be best for Dumsday to go free as well because they do not want to have to deal with a wounded man.

As the hostage negotiations transpire, Saladin and Gibreel form a sort of friendship, which Gibreel initiates. Gibreel tells Saladin about his life, and Saladin listens to him reluctantly. In particular, Gibreel is eager to tell Saladin about the strange dreams he has been having since eating pork. In his dreams, he is an archangel. These dreams have given Gibreel a positive outlook, and, even while everyone else is terrified for their lives, Gibreel assures them that everything will be fine. He knows that—one way or another—they will be left off the plane, at which time they will be “born again.” Gibreel also tells Saladin that he boarded Flight 420 because he is chasing after Alleluia Cone, with whom he is still desperately in love.

After 111 days of being held hostage on a tarmac, Tavleen decides to kill a hostage—whom she chooses because he is a religious apostate—since her demands have not been met. After killing the hostage, the terrorists order the pilot to take off again, which he does. In the air, the terrorists begin fighting with each other. As a result, Jalandri detonates her explosive vest, and the plane explodes.

Here, it appears that Saladin's dreams are coming true, making him a prophet of sorts, though he never shares his insights with anyone else. The incident the narration describes here is based on the hijacking of Indian Airlines Flight 423, which occurred in 1981. In this real life incident, Sikh militants took control of a plane en route from Delhi to Amritsar, demanding the release of political prisoners. The situation was resolved after negotiations, with the hostages being freed and the hijackers surrendering without any casualties.



The loss of Dumsday's tongue is ironic given that he thinks of it as his mission to spread the word of God. Despite being one of the more insufferable people onboard the flight, he gets to go free, suggesting that there is no divine intervention afoot. However, from Eugene's perspective, his God has saved his life, even if he's lost his tongue.



Dreams play an important role in both Saladin's and Gibreel's lives. Although both men recognize their dreams as products of their imaginations, they cannot help but feel that their dreams are spilling over into the real world. Here, the dynamic that is apparent at the beginning of the novel between Gibreel and Saladin begins to get fleshed out. Gibreel's relentless optimism annoys Saladin, as does Gibreel's success. Gibreel is an Indian icon, beloved by all, whereas Saladin feels entirely alienated from India. This dynamic makes Saladin dislike Gibreel, though Gibreel does not seem to notice.



Again, time passes rapidly. Although Gibreel and Saladin spend a great deal of time together under extraordinary circumstances, the reader does not get extensive insight into this development. As this chapter comes to a close, the novel finally gets back to where it began: with Flight 420 exploding the sky.



PART 2

As Gibreel falls from the sky, vivid, prophetic visions flood his mind. He first witnesses Shaitan (the Arabic word for Satan) cast out from the sky. Shaitan desperately tries to grasp the highest tree, the lote-tree, as he falls, but he misses and plummets downward. Despite the fall, Shaitan survives and begins singing soft, seductive verses. His daughters—Lat, Manat, and Uzza—accompany him, giggling behind their hands at Gibreel. They hint at a trick planned for him and the “businessman” on the hill.

The vision shifts to another story where Gibreel, as the archangel, reveals the spring of Zamzam to Hagar, the Egyptian servant. Abandoned by the prophet Ibrahim with their child Ismail in the desert, Hagar desperately searches for **water**. Gibreel shows her the cool spring waters of Zamzam, which save her and her son. Later, Gibreel again reveals its location to Muttalib, the grandfather of the “businessman.”

The vision focuses on this “businessman,” who becomes the central figure in Gibreel’s dream. Known as Mahound, the businessman climbs Cone Mountain, which rises near the sand-built city of Jahilia. As Mahound climbs the mountain, Gibreel watches him and becomes aware of himself sleeping and dreaming. Panic grows within Gibreel as he realizes that he might be losing his sanity.

Meanwhile, Karim Abu Simbel, a wealthy and powerful man, walks through the streets of Jahilia during the feast of Ibrahim, a religious festival. The city buzzes with activity, its sand structures appearing almost miraculous in their transformation from shifting dunes to solid, permanent buildings. Abu Simbel, a key figure in Jahilia, controls much of the city’s wealth through his ownership of the temples and his influence over the council of merchants.

Every other part of the novel is entirely dedicated to Gibreel’s visions, which are retellings of religious and historical events. It is Rushdie’s retelling of these events that made the novel so controversial for reasons that will become clear. Like the first chapter of the novel, this chapter begins with a fall, in this case, the fall of Shaitan, who has been cast out of Paradise. Like Gibreel and Saladin, Shaitan sings as he falls.



These allusions refer to significant events in Islamic tradition. The spring of Zamzam is a holy well in Mecca, which, according to Islamic belief, was revealed by the archangel Gabriel (Gibreel) to Hagar, the mother of Ismail, when she was desperately searching for water to save her son. This event is part of the story of Prophet Ibrahim (Abraham) leaving Hagar and Ismail in the desert. Later, the spring was rediscovered by Abd al-Muttalib, the grandfather of the Prophet Muhammad. In this novel, Gibreel seems to be both the archangel Gabriel and the character that the reader already knows.



Here, Rushdie changes a few naming conventions, but readers with knowledge of the Islamic faith will recognize the figures the narrative represents here. Mahound is a clear stand-in for Muhammad, while Jahilia is Rushdie’s version of Mecca. Notably, for many Muslims, the depiction of the Prophet in visual art, literature, or other forms is a sensitive subject, especially if it is perceived as disrespectful or derogatory.



Unlike many other characters in Gibreel’s visions, Karim Abu Simbel comes from Rushdie’s imagination—he is not a reworking of an Islamic figure. Here, Simbel is depicted as a powerful figurehead who controls Jahilia, which, at the moment, is a polytheistic city. This would make him the enemy of Mahound, who is seeking to spread the word of Allah.



As he moves through the festival, Abu Simbel encounters a young, arrogant poet named Baal. Baal, notorious in Jahilia for his sharp tongue and satirical verses, faces accusations of having an affair with Abu Simbel's wife, Hind. Abu Simbel drags Baal to the temple of the goddess Lat, located at the city's southern gate. Inside the temple, Abu Simbel beats Baal and commands him to write a satirical poem mocking Mahound and his followers—Salman, Khalid, and Bilal. Abu Simbel reveres Lat as a powerful goddess, equal and opposite to Allah, the god that Mahound preaches about.

Afterward, Abu Simbel relaxes in his palace with his many concubines, contemplating Mahound's growing influence. Although he cares little about Hind's affair with Baal, he recognizes the significant threat that Mahound's teachings pose to the established order in Jahilia. Abu Simbel devises a plan to turn Jahilia into a city of vice, dominated by gambling, prostitution, and other forms of revelry. He intends to profit from these vices, maintaining his control over the city's wealth and power. Meanwhile, Baal begins crafting his satirical poem, using his sharp wit to ridicule Mahound and his followers. His verses aim to undermine Mahound's credibility and make his message seem foolish to the people of Jahilia.

While Baal writes his poem, Mahound grapples with a critical decision. Abu Simbel approaches him with an offer: if Mahound agrees to incorporate the three local goddesses—Lat, Uzza, and Manat—into his monotheistic faith, he will gain official recognition in Jahilia and a seat on the city's governing council. This offer presents Mahound with a dilemma, as accepting the offer would mean compromising the core belief of his faith, which asserts that there is only one God, Allah. However, it would also provide protection for his followers in a city that is growing increasingly hostile toward them.

Mahound consults his closest followers, who unanimously urge him to reject the offer. They view it as a trap designed to weaken their movement and betray the purity of their message. Hamza, Mahound's uncle, advises him to seek guidance from the archangel Gibreel. He suggests that Mahound climb Cone Mountain once more to receive the answers he seeks.

As Hamza suggests, Mahound ascends Cone Mountain to seek Gibreel's guidance. Upon reaching the summit, he enters a state of deep prayer and meditation, calling upon Gibreel for help. Gibreel, however, struggles with the dual roles he plays in the vision—as both the divine messenger and a participant in Mahound's inner conflict. Mahound, desperate for clarity, asks Gibreel whether he should accept Abu Simbel's offer. He voices his concerns about the impact this decision will have on his followers and the integrity of his message.

Baal is another one of Rushdie's fictional creations who, in part, stands in for Rushdie himself. Baal is ordered to write poems that mock the teachings of Mahound, just as Rushdie is writing a novel that is critical of Islam. Notably, unlike Baal, Rushdie, who was born into a Muslim family, is not necessarily condemning Islam, but he is certainly critiquing it. The nature of this critique becomes increasingly clear (and harsh) as the novel progresses.

Abu Simbel's plan to turn Jahilia into a city of vice reflects his attempt to maintain control through moral corruption and diversion. His indifference to his wife's affair with Baal indicates his priority: maintaining power. Baal's satirical poem demonstrates the power of art and satire to subvert and challenge authority, even (and perhaps especially) religious authority. By mocking Mahound, Baal aims to undermine his credibility, while maintaining the status quo.



Simbel's offer to incorporate the three local goddesses into Mahound's monotheistic faith tests his devotion to his core beliefs. The tension here lies in the choice between pragmatism (gaining safety for his followers) and ideological purity, which raises questions about the nature of religious belief.



This moment emphasizes the communal aspect of Mahound's decision-making process. The group's unanimous rejection of Abu Simbel's offer reinforces the idea that faith must remain uncompromised.



Here, Rushdie delves into the spiritual and psychological tension within Mahound and Gibreel. Gibreel's dual role as both a divine messenger and a participant in Mahound's inner conflict complicates the idea of clear divine communication. The ambiguity in Gibreel's silence suggests a larger commentary on the uncertainty of divine will and prophetic authenticity, as there is a difficulty in distinguishing divine truth from personal experience.



Gibreel, feeling the weight of Mahound's dilemma and his own uncertainty, stays silent. He listens to Mahound's pleas but cannot provide the clear guidance that Mahound seeks. Eventually, Mahound experiences a vision where Gibreel speaks, but the voice does not seem entirely to be Gibreel's. The message conveyed in the vision appears to offer a compromise, allowing the goddesses to be incorporated into the faith. Mahound, feeling uncertain, decides to share these new verses with his followers.

After returning to Jahilia, Mahound shares the verses that seemed to come from Gibreel, which endorse the inclusion of the goddesses Lat, Uzza, and Manat. His followers, who did not expect such a result, are shocked. That night, Mahound's followers face an ambush. With Hamza's help, they fend off their attackers, killing two of Hind's brothers in the process. Unable to sleep, Mahound wanders through the city, troubled by the recent events. He eventually collapses and awakens in Hind's house. There, Mahound and Hind have a tense conversation about religion and the future of Jahilia. Hind insists that the conflict between Allah and the other gods will not end in a truce but will lead to inevitable conflict. Mahound, thinking he has made a mistake, decides he must consult Gibreel again. Shortly after he leaves, Hind learns of her brothers' deaths, and she vows revenge upon Mahound and his followers.

Mahound climbs Cone Mountain again, desperate for clarity. Mahound struggles to understand whether the verses he received came from Allah or from Shaitan. He confronts Gibreel, who still is unsure of his own role in these unfolding events. Their encounter becomes a physical and spiritual wrestling match. Mahound, desperate for answers, grapples with Gibreel, demanding to know the truth. Gibreel, unable to provide a clear answer, fights against Mahound's intense need for clarity. Eventually, Mahound realizes that the verses did not come from Allah but from Shaitan. Horrified by the deception, Mahound decides to strike the "Satanic verses" from his teachings and reject Abu Simbel's offer.

That night, Hind's men murder Mahound's wife as an act of revenge. This brutal act forces Mahound and his followers to flee Jahilia. The group gathers their few belongings and departs the city, heading toward the desert. Gibreel, left alone on the mountain, faces his own torment. The goddesses Lat, Uzza, and Manat transform into winged creatures and descend upon him. They claw at his eyes, bite him, and whip him with their hair.

This paragraph introduces the controversial "Satanic verses," which suggest that divine revelation may carry ambiguity and error. Mahound's decision to share these verses with his followers reveals his desperation for guidance but also his susceptibility to doubt. The verses challenge the foundation of his monotheistic message, but Mahound decides to share them anyway.



The deaths of Hind's brothers show how ideological battles can turn into personal wars. The stakes shift from theological purity to raw, human revenge. This isn't just about belief anymore—it's about blood and power, with both sides digging in deeper. Meanwhile, Mahound's restless wandering reflects his own internal conflict. He grapples with doubt, not just about the verses, but also about his entire path. Although Mahound wants to find a better way forward for himself and his people, Hind's vow of revenge all but ensures that Mahound and his followers will have to seek shelter elsewhere, regardless of whether they choose to compromise their beliefs.



Gibreel's wrestling match with Mahound recalls his encounter with Saladin when both men were falling through the sky. Like that prior scene, this moment represents an instance where both prophet and divine messenger are not sure what is going on. Both Gibreel and Mahound seek clarity, but neither has the power to give the other what he seeks. Ultimately, Mahound receives his answer, only to discover that he almost betrayed his God. However, notably, both answers he received came from Gibreel—neither came from Satan. The fact that Mahound cannot tell the difference between Gibreel, Shaitan, and Allah suggests that he is fallible and perhaps not to be trusted.



Mahound has to flee Jahilia not because of religious persecution, but because of a personal act of revenge—one that deeply wounds him. As Gibreel's vision ends, Mahound and his people are in a bad spot. Gibreel, too, has is not doing well: he supposed to be their protector. The success of Hind and the goddesses suggests the forces of evil have prevailed over the forces of good, even though Mahound recanted the Satanic verses.



PART 3, CHAPTER 1

Rosa Diamond, an 88-year-old English woman living by the sea, looks out at the **water** and thinks about ghosts. She believes ghosts are manifestations of unfinished business rather than simple apparitions. Rosa, who has always had a keen sense of the supernatural, thinks about a time in her childhood when she believes she saw the Battle of Hastings. This memory, true or not, has become a cornerstone of her identity. As she looks out her window, she suddenly sees something moving near the water's edge, so she goes outside to investigate.

Down by the shore, Gibreel awakens, covered in snow, and immediately begins celebrating his survival. He makes snowballs and sings carols. Meanwhile, Saladin lies nearby encased in a thin layer of ice. Saladin cannot comprehend what has happened to him, and he thinks about the recent past with a sense of fear. As Saladin struggles with his thoughts, he feels his body freezing and worries that he might shatter like glass. Suddenly, Rosa appears. She scolds the two men for trespassing on her property. However, her sternness quickly gives way to concern. Realizing they need help, Rosa invites them into her home to warm up.

Inside Rosa's house, Saladin reflects on his past, particularly on how his looks served him well in his younger years, especially with women. This is an aspect of himself that he felt was long gone. However, upon waking from a disturbing dream, Saladin notices that his face has reverted to its earlier cherubic form. He also notices two painful swellings at his temples, which he initially dismisses as injuries from the fall. Additionally, he has acquired Gibreel's **bad breath** (Gibreel, meanwhile, now has pleasant-smelling breath).

As Saladin contemplates his current situation, he experiences a sense of unreality, as if the world beyond Rosa's house no longer exists. He knows he should call Pamela to let her know he is alive, but he feels uncertain whether that is the right move. Eventually, Saladin decides to make the call, but when he does, a man answers the phone. Upset, Saladin hangs up immediately. Saladin then recalls a play he had once seen, about a man who returns home after being presumed dead, only to find his wife remarried. Overwhelmed, Saladin begins to weep uncontrollably, cursing his Indian heritage.

First, the name of this section of the novel is worth mentioning. Although the title may look like gibberish, when spoken aloud it sounds like one is spelling "London." It is an example of the wordplay that recurs throughout the novel. Additionally, the Battle of Hastings occurred in 1066, when William the Conqueror's Normans defeated King Harold II's forces, ending Anglo-Saxon rule. This victory led to William becoming the first Norman king of England. Given the date of the battle relative to the setting of the novel, Rosa is surely mistaken unless she, like Gibreel, has visions of the past.



Gibreel and Saladin's contrasting reactions to their respective rebirths foreshadows what is to come for both men. Gibreel eagerly plays in the snow—like a snow angel, one might say—while Saladin is trapped in ice, which is perhaps a reference to Dante Alighieri's Divine Comedy, in which Lucifer is similarly frozen in ice. Despite the strange nature of their arrival, Rosa treats Saladin and Gibreel with kindness, representing a warmth neither is man is used to receiving from an English person.



Although Saladin's outside is becoming more attractive, his inside is rotting. He has inherited Gibreel's bad breath, suggesting moral corruption. Meanwhile, the bumps appearing on his head are suspiciously placed where one might expect devil horns to grow. However, it is unclear at this point whether Saladin's transformation is physical or if it exists purely in his mind.



Because everything seems too unreal to Saladin, he calls Pamela, in part, to ground himself. However, instead of reaffirming his sense of reality, Saladin's call in Pamela ends in disaster, as he assumes the man who picks up the phone is someone with whom Pamela is having an affair. Saladin blames his Indian heritage because he does not know to what else he can attribute his bad luck.



Meanwhile, Rosa, unable to sleep, watches the sea from her window and hears Gibreel pacing in the room above her. Outside, Rosa sees strange figures moving on the beach. Determined to protect her property, she gets up to see what is going on. As she opens her door to go outside, she sees the bright beam of a police officer's flashlight. The police force has come because they received reports of a suspicious person in the area. One of the officers, Inspector Lime, shows Rosa a warrant to search her property. Rosa protests, but the policemen go through with their search anyway.

When Saladin appears in Rosa's hallway, the police, particularly three plain-clothed immigration officers, react with glee, believing they have found an illegal immigrant. They mock Saladin, who desperately tries to explain that he is a British citizen. When Saladin raises his hands to his forehead, he discovers that he has grown two sharp, goat-like horns, confirming the officers' suspicions that something is not right about him.

Before the police can take Saladin away, Gibreel appears on the staircase, dressed in a maroon smoking jacket and jodhpurs from Rosa's late husband's wardrobe. His sudden appearance, coupled with the faint golden light emanating from behind his head, causes the police to hesitate. Saladin, scared and desperate, tries to get Gibreel to stick up for him, as he senses that the police trust Gibreel for some reason. However, Gibreel, for reasons he cannot understand, cannot stop thinking about Rosa, and he ignores Saladin's pleas. The police put Saladin in handcuffs and take them to their van. As Saladin looks back, he sees Gibreel watching him from a balcony, though there is no longer a light emanating from his head.

The sudden arrival of the police seems strange given that Gibreel and Saladin were only outside briefly before Rosa brought them indoors. Furthermore, since Rosa did not call the police, it seems strange that someone else would have on her behalf. Either way, the police are a threatening force for Gibreel and Saladin, who are foreigners that have just entered the country in an unusual manner.



Here, the novel's magical realism is once again in full-effect. None of the characters are particularly offput by Saladin's bizarre appearance—in fact, the police care much more about him being an illegal immigrant than they care about the horns sprouting from his head. Their racism completely blinds them to whatever is going on with Saladin—who is, as he claims, a British citizen.



Unlike Saladin, who looks like a dangerous foreigner to the police, Gibreel is dressed like an elderly Englishman. Thus, to the police, he poses no threat. Gibreel seems to have almost taken on the very character of Rosa's husband and therefore does not care when Saladin is taken away. The light that appears—and then disappears—above Gibreel's head is meant to resemble a halo, giving him an angelic appearance. In other words, as Saladin is transforming into a devil, Gibreel seems to be becoming an angel. Notably, this coincides with Gibreel dressing as though he is English and Saladin being identified as an illegal immigrant.



PART 3, CHAPTER 2

In the days after the police take Saladin away, Rosa begins telling Gibreel stories from her past. As Rosa is talking, Gibreel thinks about how he no longer feels in control of himself. He does not know why he did not help Saladin and regrets his inaction. Additionally, Gibreel realizes that he has completely ignored his quest to find Allie (Alleluia Cone). He wonders whether there is something wrong with him.

Gibreel's regret over not helping Saladin and his neglect of his quest to find Allie reveal a deep internal conflict. This uncertainty suggests that Gibreel's identity is fracturing. He starts to question his own motives and sanity, which reflects the novel's broader theme of characters struggling with their sense of self in a world that constantly challenges their identity.



Rosa's narrative is filled with memories of her time in Argentina, where she lived with her husband, Enrique, on their vast estate. Rosa reveals that her marriage to Enrique was more of a necessity than a love match. Enrique's passion was reserved for birds, leaving Rosa longing for something more. She would often walk out into the plains at night, lying on her back to gaze at the stars and feel a deep sense of joy and wonder.

Gibreel finds himself increasingly drawn into Rosa's stories, which transport him to the past. Rosa's stories reveal her longings and regrets, particularly regarding her relationship with Martin de la Cruz, a man with whom she was in love. As Rosa talks about Martin, Gibreel experiences strange physical sensations, including a painful tugging in his navel. One night, Rosa tells Gibreel that he looks just like Martin, which causes him intense pain.

A few days later, Rosa's birthday arrives, so Gibreel takes her into a nearby village to buy her cake and champagne. Gibreel, now fully in love with Rosa for reasons he cannot explain, hardly remembers his previous life. While Rosa chats with the baker, Gibreel experiences yet another jolt of pain. Later that night, Rosa celebrates her birthday with Gibreel. They dance until dawn, but the exertion proves too much for Rosa, who collapses the next day with a fever. As Rosa lies in bed, delirious, Gibreel begins to see visions of Martin de la Cruz, as well as other figures from Rosa's past. The visions become more intense, and Gibreel realizes that Rosa's will is holding him captive. Gibreel compares the experience to when the Prophet Mahound compelled him to speak in his dreams.

Rosa's fever-induced delirium brings forth more memories, including the time when Martin de la Cruz rowed her to a mysterious white island for a picnic. Rosa's memories are fragmented, and she cannot decide whether she and Martin gave in to their desires or if she resisted him. Gibreel, now fully ensnared in Rosa's dream world, experiences the conflicting versions of the story as if they are happening to him. As Rosa's life slips away, Gibreel's experience with her memories becomes increasingly intense. Then, as Rosa's dies, Gibreel feels his own life slipping away. He worries that he might die as a result of her death.

Rosa's stories about her life in Argentina demonstrate her deep-seated longing for something beyond her reality. These memories allow her to reclaim a sense of joy and wonder, which contrasts sharply with the present situation she faces. Although the past is not perfect, she prefers it to the present and cannot help but return to it.



Rosa's recollections of Martin de la Cruz and the love she felt for him parallel Gibreel's own longing and lost sense of purpose. The strange sensations Gibreel feels—like the painful tugging in his navel—suggest that some force is psychically linking him to Rosa's past. When she mentions that he looks like Martin, the intense pain he experiences indicates that Rosa's memories are beginning to possess him, further dissolving the boundaries between his identity and hers.



As Gibreel becomes more enamored with Rosa, his previous life fades into the background, symbolizing his descent into her world. His mysterious love for her seems to have no rational basis, suggesting that he has fully absorbed her narrative and lost his grip on his own. The jolts of pain he feels while in the village mirror his earlier sensations, reinforcing the idea that Rosa's memories are physically affecting him. The birthday celebration, where they dance until dawn, completes his immersion into Rosa's reality, where time and personal history lose all meaning.



Rosa's fever-driven memories, particularly of her ambiguous encounter with Martin de la Cruz on the white island, blur the lines between reality and fantasy for Gibreel. He becomes fully trapped in her dream world, experiencing her conflicting memories as if they are his own. The comparison to Mahound compelling him in dreams suggests that Gibreel's struggle with agency spans both his divine and human experiences. This entrapment highlights how powerful memories can dominate and reshape an individual's reality.



Finally, Rosa dies and the weight on Gibreel lifts. He feels like he can leave her house and return to his life in London. However, as he heads down to the beach, he hears singing coming from an old boathouse. Inside, Gibreel finds Rosa, who appears to him as a young woman—the same version of her that Gibreel has been seeing while experiencing her memories. Rosa beckons for Gibreel to lie down next to her on the floor of the boathouse, which he does.

Rosa's death lifts the immediate weight off Gibreel, suggesting a brief return to his own reality. However, the sight of a young Rosa in the boathouse hints that her narrative still holds sway over him. This final vision blurs the line between life and death, memory and reality. Rosa's beckoning suggests that Gibreel may remain forever ensnared in her memories or, at least, that his encounter with her will haunt him for a long time to come.



PART 3, CHAPTER 3

Saladin finds himself trapped in a police van, surrounded by immigration officers and policemen who show no compassion. They ridicule him relentlessly, tearing off his pajamas and exposing the grotesque transformation his body has undergone. His legs have become muscular and hairy, ending in cloven hooves, and his penis has grown to an alarming size. The officers find his new appearance and make crude jokes, delighting in his discomfort. Notably, none of them seems to find Saladin's transformation particularly strange.

The officers' indifference to Saladin's physical changes suggests a normalization of cruelty and otherness. Saladin's experience exposes how those in power often turn difference into a spectacle, using it as an excuse for humiliation. The lack of shock at his new appearance speaks to a society that routinely devalues and dehumanizes those it considers "different."



Saladin lies on the floor of the van as the policemen hold him down and restrict his movements. His horns repeatedly bang against the hard surfaces around him, causing him further pain. He considers the possibility that he might have died in the plane explosion and that everything happening now is some form of afterlife, but he dismisses this idea, realizing that the pain feels too real.

Saladin's horns repeatedly banging against the van's hard surfaces add to his physical torment and disorientation. His thoughts about the possibility of being in some kind of purgatory reflect his psychological struggle to make sense of his suffering. Meanwhile, his realization that this is no afterlife highlights the hellish reality of his present situation, where his suffering is disturbingly tangible.



The van rumbles on, and Saladin grows increasingly desperate. The officers' taunts grow crueler as they force him to clean up his own excrement, which now resembles the pellets of a goat. The officers push Saladin's face into the mess and laugh at his disgusted reaction. Saladin attempts to assert his dignity, but their laughter and mockery drown out his words. Eventually, the officers get sick of torturing Saladin and discuss sports instead. However, after some time, they remember Saladin's presence and begin abusing him again.

This act reduces Saladin to a subhuman status, forcing him to perform animalistic functions. His attempts to speak and assert his dignity are drowned out by the officers' taunts, showing how difficult it is to claim one's humanity in the face of such relentless dehumanization. Additionally, the officers' switch from taunting Saladin to discussing sports, only to return to abusing him, illustrates the banality of their cruelty.



Saladin's mind drifts as the beatings continue. He begins to feel detached from his body, as though the pain is happening to someone else. His thoughts become jumbled, and he loses track of time. The officers and policemen, meanwhile, discuss the need for increased surveillance and more control over the population. Eventually, the van halts, and the officers realize they face a problem. A check with the Police National Computer confirms that Saladin is a British citizen, which complicates their plans. They debate what to do with him, considering ways to cover up their mistreatment. Eventually, they decide to knock him out and leave him.

Saladin wakes up in a hospital bed, coughing up green slime from his lungs. His body feels frozen, and he struggles to make sense of his surroundings. A nurse named Hyacinth Phillips introduces herself and begins a brutal treatment regimen to clear his lungs, which leaves him feeling even more battered than before. Despite his initial resistance, Saladin has no choice but to endure the painful sessions, as Hyacinth firmly tells him that he needs them to get better.

During his recovery, Saladin becomes aware of the strange noises around him—animal sounds, cries of pain, and the continuous wailing of a woman in labor. The stench of the hospital, a mixture of jungle and farmyard odors, combined with the sounds of suffering, overwhelms his senses. Determined to regain some control over his situation, Saladin attempts to stand, but his new legs betray him, and he collapses to the floor.

While Saladin is in the hospital, one of the policemen, Stein, pays him a visit. Stein warns Saladin that he shouldn't bother filing a complaint, as he and the other officers have made sure it will not be taken seriously. That night, Saladin receives a visit from a manticore, a creature with the body of a man and the head of a tiger. The manticore explains that the mutations affecting them all result from the authorities' power of description: they are being reshaped by the way they are perceived.

The manticore tells Saladin that he and several others are planning to escape the hospital immanently. The manticore invites Saladin to come along, warning him that his transformation will only grow worse if he stays. Ultimately, Saladin agrees to escape with the manticore, hoping to take back control over his life. As he runs through the night, Saladin catches glimpses of other escapees—men and women who have been transformed into bizarre, monstrous forms, part plant, part animal, or even part building. Ultimately, the escape plan is successful, though Saladin struggles to see what he should do now that he is free.

As the abuse continues, Saladin begins to feel detached from his body, his mind drifting away as a defense mechanism. The officers' conversation about increasing surveillance and controlling the population reveals the systemic nature of their cruelty. They view Saladin not as a person but as a problem to manage, highlighting how power systems reduce individuals to categories, dehumanizing them in order to maintain order and control.



Saladin's awakening in the hospital introduces another layer of dehumanization. The nurse, Hyacinth Phillips, administers harsh treatments that, while intended to heal, further his sense of violation and helplessness. Her rigid insistence on these brutal methods suggests that care, in this context, is just another form of control.



Stein's visit to the hospital reinforces the futility of seeking justice in a system designed to protect its own. His warning to Saladin not to bother filing a complaint reveals the corruption within the police force. Saladin's sense of isolation deepens as he realizes he cannot fight back against the forces reshaping him, both physically and socially.



The manticore's speech introduces a broader critique of how society and authority impose identities on individuals, effectively reshaping their realities. The manticore's invitation to escape provides Saladin with a choice: stay and be further molded by the oppressive system, or flee and risk an uncertain future. This moment is a turning point for Saladin: he can choose to reclaim some agency over his fate, however fraught it may be.



As Saladin escapes with the manticore and glimpses the other transformed beings, he witnesses the diversity of altered identities who have similarly been abused. The sight of these grotesque forms reinforces the idea that breaking free from physical confinement does not mean escaping the psychological scars or societal perceptions that shaped them. Still, this is an important moment for Saladin, who finally breaks free after a night of excessive abuse.



PART 3, CHAPTER 4

Jumpy Joshi becomes Pamela Chamcha's lover on the same night she hears about Saladin's supposed death in the plane explosion. Jumpy finds himself in a difficult position when Saladin, thought to be dead, calls in the middle of the night and hangs up after Jumpy answers the phone. Pamela, half-asleep with a blackout mask over her eyes, asks who it was, and Jumpy, flustered, dismisses it as a wrong number. Left alone to wrestle with the implications of Saladin's call, Jumpy sits up in bed, naked and anxious, sucking his thumb for comfort—a habit he has had since childhood and has never outgrown.

Jumpy struggles with guilt and fear over Saladin's sudden reappearance. He resents Saladin for returning from the dead in such a dramatic fashion, seeing it as an indecent and operatic act. As he lies in Pamela's bed, he reflects on how he rushed to Pamela's side the moment he heard of Saladin's death. When he arrived, Pamela appeared surprisingly composed, even detached. She told Jumpy that Saladin's death would only leave a small hole in her life, which shocks Jumpy, who has been friends with Saladin since childhood and was deeply upset when he heard about Saladin's demise.

Pamela, who had started drinking hours before Jumpy arrived, poured herself yet another drink. Jumpy, who doesn't usually drink, joined her. As the night wore on, Pamela began to express her frustrations with her marriage to Saladin. In particular, she complained about Saladin's obsession with his idealized version of England—a place that in his mind remains a picture-postcard fantasy of the Royal Family, cricket, and the Houses of Parliament. Pamela confessed that Saladin's inability to see the reality of their life together created a growing distance between them.

The night of drinking led to an unexpected intimacy between Pamela and Jumpy. Jumpy, who has never felt secure with women, finds himself feeling surprisingly comfortable with Pamela. Everything is going well until Jumpy receives Saladin's aborted phone call. Although Jumpy keeps the call to himself at first, he increasingly feels as though Saladin is still alive. When he expresses this belief to Pamela, she begins crying uncontrollably, refusing to believe her husband is alive.

Jumpy Joshi immediately spirals into anxiety when he realizes Saladin may not be dead after all. His response—sucking his thumb like a child—reveals how deeply unprepared he feels for the moral mess he's stepped into. His affair with Pamela happens too soon after Saladin's supposed death, and the sudden call brings back all his guilt and fear. Jumpy's inner turmoil shows how shaky his sense of morality is and how his long-standing friendship with Saladin complicates his desires.



Jumpy's annoyance at Saladin's dramatic return from the dead suggests more than just fear—it also shows a sense of rivalry. He resents how Saladin, even in death (or near death), steals the spotlight. Meanwhile, Pamela's reaction to Saladin's supposed death—her coldness and detachment—reveals how far their marriage has deteriorated. Her statement that Saladin's absence would leave only a "small hole" in her life speaks to a relationship already hollowed out by unmet expectations and emotional distance.



Pamela lays bare her frustration with Saladin's fixation on an England that doesn't exist. His fantasies about a "picture-postcard" England reflect his deeper disconnection from reality and from her. She feels trapped in a marriage where Saladin's idealized dreams of England overshadow the actual complexities of their life together. This tension between illusion and reality speaks to a broader theme in the novel about identity and belonging, particularly in a multicultural landscape that doesn't fit neatly into anyone's fantasies.



The unexpected closeness between Pamela and Jumpy suggests a shared need for comfort in the wake of chaos, but Saladin's aborted call throws a shadow over their connection. When Jumpy admits his belief that Saladin might still be alive, Pamela's emotional breakdown reveals her conflicting desires—part of her wants to move on, while another part refuses to let go of the past.



This sparks a series of conversations about Pamela's marriage to Saladin. Pamela sites one instance, in particular, that she thinks summarizes their marriage, which relates to the Falklands War. She recounts how Saladin used a metaphor of intruders in a home to justify the war, only for her to counter with a more accurate metaphor about two people claiming ownership of a house. This disagreement had been emblematic of the growing divide between them, with Saladin clinging to his idealized England.

In the morning, Pamela frantically contacts the airline to determine whether Saladin could have survived the crash. Despite the airline's assurances that no survivors exist, she refuses to believe it. In a state of overwhelmed frustration, Pamela lashes out at Jumpy and orders him to leave. Desperate to escape the turmoil, Pamela decides to drive away, seeking solace in an expensive country hotel. As she speeds down the motorway, she reflects on her marriage to Saladin and the mismatched expectations that lead to its breakdown. She realizes that each was chasing something that the other could never provide. Pamela speeds through the rain until she hits a patch of **water** and loses control. The car spins out, narrowly avoiding a collision. Miraculously, she survives, though the experience frightens her.

After her near accident, Pamela arrives at the hotel, where she indulges in luxury to soothe her frayed nerves. She drinks expensive wine, eats a lavish meal, and reflects on the burdens of her past—the legacy of her conservative upbringing, her strained relationship with her parents, and her father's disapproval, which still remains in her mind at all times. As she relaxes in the opulent surroundings, she resolves to leave Saladin and start a new life, feeling a renewed sense of freedom and determination.

Meanwhile, after being thrown out by Pamela, Jumpy seeks refuge at the Shaandaar Café in Brickhall. He sits there, trying to make sense of his feelings, wondering if he has been a fool for getting involved with Pamela. The café owner, Mr. Sufyan, teases Jumpy, trying to lift his spirits. However, the light-hearted banter does not get through to Jumpy. Eventually, Pamela and Jumpy make up and then spend seven days together making love. However, on the seventh day, someone tries breaking into Pamela's house. Terrified, Pamela and Jumpy arm themselves with makeshift weapons and creep downstairs. When they reach the bottom of the stairs, they confront a horrifying sight—a creature covered in mud, ice, and blood that looks part human, part goat. Pamela runs upstairs in fear while screaming that Saladin died in the plane explosion.

Pamela's recounting of her and Saladin's argument over the Falklands War goes beyond politics—it cuts to the heart of their incompatibility. Saladin's simplistic metaphor of home invasion compared to Pamela's more nuanced one about shared ownership speaks volumes about their divide. He clings to a black-and-white view of England and identity, whereas Pamela demands a more complex, layered understanding.



When Pamela tries to reach the airline and gets stonewalled, her frustration boils over. She takes off, seeking escape, but her near-death experience on the road feels like a metaphor for her whole marriage—hurtling forward without control, narrowly avoiding disaster. Water, while typically a symbol of rebirth and renewal, is a catalyst for violence and near-death in this instance. Pamela's reflection in the hotel, surrounded by luxury, gives her a sense of clarity. She realizes she and Saladin never really understood each other, that both chased after something the other could never provide.



Jumpy's brief reconciliation with Pamela, marked by intense physicality, suggests that both are still trying to fill the void left by Saladin's presence—or absence. Yet, their brief connection crumbles when confronted with the reality of their actions and the return of the very thing they are trying to escape.



The chapter closes with Pamela and Jumpy facing what appears to be the monstrous form of Saladin. Pamela's terrified reaction—screaming that Saladin is dead—captures the unresolved tension and fear surrounding his return. It demonstrates how Saladin, who represents a deeper personal conflict, cannot simply be ignored. The figure at the door stands as a haunting reminder that unresolved issues have a way of breaking back into one's life, demanding confrontation. Even though Pamela does not want to face Saladin, she is going to have to.



PART 3, CHAPTER 5

Gibreel, seated in a first-class, non-smoking compartment on a train to London, feels an overwhelming fear that God has decided to drive him insane as punishment for his loss of faith. The fear of being unmade by what he no longer believes in—the terror of turning into the avatar of a chimerical archangel—consumes him. He struggles to rationalize the miracles, metamorphoses, and apparitions he has recently witnessed, wondering whether he is truly going insane or if someone has altered the rules of reality.

The mundane surroundings of the railway compartment comfort Gibreel. The frayed armrests, the non-working reading light, and the missing mirror all provide a reassuring sense of normalcy. A visit to the toilet, complete with a set of instructions and prohibitions, calms him even more. By the time the conductor arrives to punch his ticket, Gibreel starts to feel more at ease, inventing rational explanations for his recent experiences. He convinces himself that he survived a brush with death, experienced a delirium, and is now returning to his planned new life.

Feeling the pull of London, Gibreel moves across the compartment to sit facing forward, eager to embrace the city and his future. He speaks the name of his lover, “Alleluia,” aloud, only to be startled when the compartment’s only other occupant responds with a jovial “Alleluia, brother.” The stranger, John Maslama, takes Gibreel’s exclamation as a social and theological overture, causing him to launch into a speech about his non-denominational beliefs. He introduces himself and hands Gibreel a business card, explaining that he follows his own version of a universal faith.

Gibreel quickly realizes that Maslama intends to talk his ear off. Maslama, dressed in bespoke tailoring and exuding the confidence of someone who has done well in life, boasts about his success. He describes his rise from producing advertising jingles to owning record stores, a nightclub, and a music instrument store. Despite his affluence and his Oxford drawl, Maslama’s intense eyes betray the fanaticism of a true believer.

Maslama continues to talk, revealing that he recognizes Gibreel as the famous movie star. Gibreel, tries to downplay his status, but Maslama praises him for portraying deities of all kinds in his films. Gibreel begins to suspect that Maslama might be unhinged, especially when the man starts talking about the hidden “true name” of God. Gibreel, who fears for his sanity, feels he has somehow conjured this lunatic into existence by his own doubts.

Gibreel imagines God not as a benevolent force but as something vindictive and cruel determined to punish him for his wavering belief. This thought exposes Gibreel’s struggle with his own faith, where the boundary between belief and disbelief becomes a source of torment. The fear of becoming an avatar for an imagined archangel shows how his mind twists under the weight of his internal contradictions.



Gibreel’s focus on ordinary details suggests a yearning for a simpler reality, where everything makes sense and follows logical rules. The visit to the toilet, with its clear instructions, gives him a sense of control, which is something he desperately seeks amid the chaos of his mind. The comfort he finds in these small, mundane things highlights his desperation to ground himself in a version of reality that doesn’t involve miracles or madness.



When Gibreel speaks Alleluia’s name and John Maslama responds, the narrative takes a sharp turn into the surreal. Here, belief and reality collide in a jarring way. Maslama’s character, confident and overly familiar, embodies a kind of spiritual salesmanship that reflects the novel’s broader commentary on how people can commodify faith. His business card and non-denominational speech represent the blending of spiritual and capitalist ventures, where belief becomes just another product to market.



Gibreel, who longs for peace and quiet, finds himself confronted by someone who embodies a different kind of madness—one that is outwardly articulate yet deeply unhinged. The contrast between Maslama’s polished appearance and his fanaticism demonstrates how madness can wear the guise of reason.



Maslama’s recognition of Gibreel as a movie star who has played gods in films merges the lines between fiction and reality. Gibreel’s growing suspicion that Maslama might be unhinged mirrors his internal conflict about his own mental state.



The situation escalates when Maslama suddenly accuses Gibreel of being a charlatan and a fake. However, Maslama's rage quickly subsides after he sees what looks like a halo form over Gibreel's reflection in the window. Then, Maslama gets down on his knees and asks for forgiveness. Maslama, now humbled, reveals a sixth toe on each of his feet, declaring himself a chosen servant of God. Gibreel, overwhelmed and desperate to escape, orders Maslama to stand and tells him that he has returned to judge humanity, with a verdict to be delivered later. He warns Maslama to keep his presence a secret.

Maslama promises to keep Gibreel's secret. Seizing the opportunity, Gibreel flees the compartment, Maslama's hymns echoing behind him. He finds refuge in another first-class carriage at the rear of the train, where he tries to collect his thoughts. However, his peace is quickly interrupted when Rekha Merchant appears outside the window on a flying carpet. Her presence, unnoticed by others, only increases Gibreel's sense that he is going insane.

Elsewhere, Alleluia Cone, speaking to a classroom of teenage girls, recounts her experiences as a mountaineer. She tells them about the ghosts that accompany climbers in the high Himalayas, sharing a story of her encounter with the ghost of Maurice Wilson during her ascent of Everest. Wilson, who had died attempting to climb Everest alone, appeared to her on the mountain, dressed in old-fashioned clothing and performing surreal feats like gliding up snow-covered slopes.

The girls find Allie's tales fascinating and ask her to say more. Allie recounts the transcendent experience of reaching the summit of Everest without oxygen. She describes the overwhelming light, the visions of rainbows and angels, and the sound of a loud, mysterious gunshot that snapped her back to reality. Allie's recounting leaves the girls in awe, but when they ask about the source of the gunshot, she can only offer a shrug, suggesting that it might have been the ghost of Maurice Wilson.

The sudden shift in Maslama's demeanor—from accusing Gibreel of fraudulence to worshipping him upon seeing a supposed halo—illustrates the volatility of faith and fanaticism. Maslama's revelation of his extra toes as a mark of the divine is absurd, but still personally meaningful. Additionally, Gibreel's attempt to control the situation by assuming a divine role recalls the position he was put in during his dream about Mahound.



Gibreel's escape from Maslama and subsequent encounter with Rekha Merchant on a flying carpet blurs the boundaries between hallucination and reality. Rekha's presence represents his unresolved guilt and psychological torment, which still has not gone away even with his new divine inspiration.



Allie's recounting of her mountaineering experiences introduces a different form of spectral encounter, contrasting with Gibreel's tormented visions. Her encounter with Maurice Wilson's ghost is seemingly encouraging rather than frightening, and it ultimately drives Allie to reach her goals. Rather than a specter of regret, the spirit is an aspirational and perhaps angelic figure.



The overwhelming light, visions of rainbows, and angels that Allie describes on Everest reflect an encounter with the sublime, though the mysterious gunshot abruptly returns her to reality. There are several magical and transcendent moments in the novel but, often, they are undercut by someone or something that brings the character experiencing the moment back to reality, which is typically disappointing by comparison.



Gibreel arrives in London exhausted and scared, as Rekha follows him everywhere he goes. Gibreel runs frantically through the Underground, convinced that the stations are changing places and the city itself is warping around him. Eventually, he emerges from the Tube at an unfamiliar station and stumbles into a desolate park. As he collapses in the snow, Gibreel sees a woman approaching and assumes it is Rekha coming to deliver the final blow. However, the woman expresses disbelief and joy at finding him alive. Gibreel, overwhelmed, realizing the woman is Allie. He is overjoyed to see her but worries that Rekha is only allowing him a brief respite before returning to finish him off for good.

Gibreel's chaotic journey through London's Underground marks his psychological collapse. His perception of stations shifting and the city warping around him evokes a sense of being trapped in a nightmare, where familiar realities become unrecognizable. The encounter with Allie in the park, when he expects to meet his tormentor Rekha, signals a brief moment of respite. However, because Rekha is still around to haunt him, it seems unlikely that Gibreel's peace will last for long.



PART 4

While lying on a park bench, Gibreel experiences a surreal dream. In it, he encounters an Imam residing in London. Inside the Imam's residence, Gibreel notices a painting of Ayesha, the powerful ruler of Desh, who embodies everything the Imam opposes. Ayesha had driven the Imam from his homeland, Desh. The Imam has gathered many followers, who live in the same building and adhere to strict practices, including drinking only purified **water**.

Gibreel's surreal dream introduces the Imam, a figure steeped in religious fundamentalism, who occupies a space in London that feels both out of place and ominously powerful. The Imam's disdain for modernity and his strict adherence to purification rituals symbolize a broader rejection of progress and secularism.



The Imam and his followers use the building as a base to send radio broadcasts back to Desh, which they view as their lost homeland. An American convert named Bilal X, with his mesmerizing voice, delivers one such broadcast. The message, like all before it, is designed to incite the people of Desh to rise up against Ayesha of Desh. The Imam urges not just the rejection of Ayesha but of all modern ideas like science and progressive thought.

The novel presents the Imam as a manipulator who uses media, specifically radio broadcasts, to incite revolt against Ayesha. His choice of Bilal X as his mouthpiece reflects how charisma can be weaponized to promote ideological agendas.



In the dream, the Imam calls upon the archangel Gibreel through a ritual. Gibreel, compelled by the role he plays in this vision, is forced to appear before the Imam, dressed in borrowed clothes. The Imam commands Gibreel to transport them both to Jerusalem. Gibreel, with no other option, carries the Imam to Ayesha of Desh's palace. Upon their arrival, they find the streets filled with people in revolt.

In this vision, Gibreel appears as the archangel, compelled to serve the Imam despite his own resistance. Gibreel's unwilling participation underscores his inner turmoil about being caught in a divine role he does not want, raising questions about free will, especially in the context of faith and divine intervention.



Gibreel warns the Imam that the uprising is driven by hatred, not love. Suddenly, a beam of light shoots from the palace, and the goddess Al-Lat emerges. The Imam orders Gibreel to kill her. Gibreel complies and defeats Al-Lat, but when he returns, the Imam has transformed into a monstrous figure with a gaping mouth. The people, entranced, walk into the Imam's mouth, where they are devoured. Across the city, clocks begin to chime. At this point, Gibreel senses that his dream is about to end and another is about to begin.

The battle against Al-Lat is a conflict between pre-Islamic rule and Islamic rule (an Imam is a type of Islamic ruler). The Imam's monstrous transformation represents how extremism consumes its own people, turning faith into a devouring force rather than a guiding light. Again, Rushdie is painting Islam in a rather unflattering light, making it easy to see why the novel became controversial.



In Gibreel's new dream, a man named Mirza Saeed Akhtar has a nightmare on his 40th birthday. When Mirza awakens, he gazes at his sleeping wife, Mishal, and feels himself brimming with love for her. He steps out onto the veranda of their home in Titlipur and notices vast swarms of butterflies fluttering in the air. Local legends say these butterflies are the spirits of a saintly woman named Bibiji, who lived for two centuries and whose grave once had healing powers before it disappeared.

As Mirza Saeed looks down at the garden, he sees a young girl slowly eating the butterflies. Horrified, he shouts, waking the household as he rushes to the girl's aid. He carries her inside, where Mishal recognizes her as Ayesha of Desh, an orphan from the town who suffers from epilepsy. Ayesha stays with the family for a while, during which the people of Titlipur start believing that she can communicate with the archangel Gibreel.

This strange encounter with Ayesha of Desh stirs something in Mirza, intensifying his attraction to Mishal. He persuades her to fulfill his fantasies, which involve her dressing in modest religious attire and staying home all day. Mishal, who desires children, agrees, thinking that being close to someone who has a connection to an archangel might increase her chances of conceiving. She befriends Ayesha, hoping that the archangel might bless her with a child.

However, Ayesha of Desh delivers a devastating message from the archangel: Mishal has breast cancer. A doctor confirms the diagnosis, revealing that the cancer is advanced and inoperable. Ayesha disappears, only to return a week later, adorned in golden butterflies. She tells the people of Titlipur that they must undertake a pilgrimage to Mecca to save Mishal. She claims that the archangel has promised that the sea will part for them at the Arabian coast. The villagers agree to embark on this journey, but Mirza, enraged by what he sees as a suicidal mission, forbids Mishal from going. Despite his protests, Mishal prepares to leave with the other pilgrims anyway.

PART 5, CHAPTER 1

Saladin, now a grotesque creature with horns, hooves, and a tail, finds himself living in the Shaandaar Café as Sufyan agrees to take him in. His monstrous appearance creates a mix of fear and revulsion among those who frequent the café. Despite this, Sufyan's daughters, Mishal and Anahita, feel drawn to him. Mishal, the elder daughter, views Saladin as a symbol of rebellion and defiance. Anahita, though also interested, does not like how much of an interest Mishal takes in him.

The butterflies, symbolizing Bibiji's spirit, create an atmosphere where faith and reality blur. This sets the stage for the mystical encounters that follow, as the boundary between the sacred and the profane becomes increasingly porous.



Ayesha's introduction into the household marks a shift in the narrative from the familiar to the uncanny. Her act of eating butterflies shocks Mirza, disrupting his sense of order. Ayesha's perceived connection with the divine further complicates the household dynamics and sets her up as both a spiritual authority and a potential disruptor of Mirza's world, challenging his beliefs and sense of what is right and wrong.



Mirza's demand for Mishal to adopt religious attire speaks to his need to control his surroundings in ways that satisfy his conflicted relationship with faith and desire. Meanwhile, Mishal's desperation to conceive leads her to place her trust in Ayesha, demonstrating how faith can be both a source of hope and manipulation.



Ayesha's prophecy about Mishal's cancer blurs the line between divine intervention and fatalistic acceptance. The call for a pilgrimage, with the promise of the sea parting, evokes powerful biblical imagery but also suggests fanaticism and blind faith. Mirza's vehement opposition reflects a rational perspective, positioning him as a counterpoint to the growing religious fervor around Ayesha. Nevertheless, Mishal decides to ignore Mirza's warning and take a leap of faith that he does not understand.



Saladin's grotesque new form sets him apart as both an object of fascination and repulsion in the Shaandaar Café. Mishal's attraction to him as a symbol of rebellion highlights how the grotesque can serve as a form of resistance against social norms. Saladin's physical transformation also mirrors his psychological alienation, where his monstrous exterior reflects his inner turmoil.



Within the Sufyan household, tensions rise as Hind Sufyan, Sufyan's wife, wants Saladin out. Hind, who once embraced her role as a loving and supportive wife, now battles with deep-seated resentment. Years of feeling trapped in an immigrant life in England, coupled with her husband's passive nature, have left her bitter. To make matters worse, the sight of the monstrous Saladin in her home triggers memories of everything she believes she has lost. Her anger festers, particularly when she discovers that her daughter Mishal has become romantically involved with Hanif Johnson, a local lawyer who also boards in the upstairs of the Shaandaar Café.

Hind Sufyan's anger toward Mishal and Hanif escalates into a full-blown crisis when she confronts her daughter about the relationship. Tensions rise and Hind slashes at Mishal with a kitchen knife, but Mishal kicks the knife away and avoids any serious injuries. Angry at how her daughter has been behaving, Hind accuses Saladin of bringing misfortune upon her family. She sees him as the root of all her problems, the devil incarnate who has cursed her life.

As Saladin's physical transformation progresses, he unwittingly becomes a symbol of fear and fascination in the local community. Rumors of the horned devil in the attic spread through the neighborhood. People begin to dream of Saladin as a powerful, demonic figure, rising up to challenge the world. In these dreams, Saladin grows to gigantic proportions, his horns twisting into elaborate designs, his voice echoing with guttural, unintelligible chants.

The youth of the neighborhood, drawn to Saladin's rebellious image, start to idolize him. They see in him a reflection of their own struggles. They begin wearing rubber devil horns, imitating the figure that haunts their dreams. Saladin's image starts to appear on banners and posters, his monstrous form transformed into a symbol of resistance against the status quo. The unintended attention thrust upon him only deepens Saladin's despair. He feels trapped in a nightmare, unable to escape the grotesque parody of his former life.

One night, Hanif Johnson bursts into the Shaandaar Café with alarming news. The police have arrested Dr. Uhuru Simba, a local Black activist, and plan to frame him for the "Granny Ripper" murders, a series of killings targeting old women that has been plaguing London. The authorities, desperate to quell the growing unrest, accuse Simba of using black magic, casting him as a voodoo-priest responsible for the killings. Hanif warns the Sufyans to lock their doors, as he expects there to be violence in the streets over the case.

Hind's intense anger towards Saladin stems from her own frustrations and sense of entrapment in her immigrant life. She projects her feelings of loss and bitterness onto Saladin, who symbolizes the disruption and decay she perceives in her family and home. Her reaction to Saladin also reflects deeper cultural and generational conflicts—her struggles as an immigrant woman dealing with her husband's passive nature and the perceived erosion of traditional values in her household.



Hind's violent confrontation with Mishal, escalating to the point of wielding a knife, illustrates how deeply her resentment has festered. She blames Saladin for corrupting her household, casting him as a literal and metaphorical devil figure who brings chaos and misfortune. Saladin's monstrous form becomes a convenient scapegoat for the family's deeper issues.



As rumors about Saladin's presence spread, he becomes a figure of myth within the local community. The neighborhood's fascination with Saladin as a demonic figure demonstrates how easily society turns outsiders into someone or something other than what they are.



Although Saladin's grotesque form unintentionally inspires local youth, he feels trapped by this new role. He becomes a symbol of resistance against his will, a parody of his former life. This tension between his internal desire for normalcy and the external projection of his image as a rebel demonstrates the difference between how he sees himself and how others see him. Even if others are not knowingly misappropriating his image, they are doing so nevertheless.



The authorities' attempt to frame Simba for the "Granny Ripper" murders ties into the theme of xenophobia that runs throughout the novel. This moment reflects on the broader societal tendency to demonize the "other," even when the other may not have done anything wrong. Because Simba is an activist, it's implied that the police are trying to pin the crime on him not only because he is Black, but also because he is an obstacle to their political goals.



Hind Sufyan, already at her wit's end, snaps. In a fit of uncontrollable rage, she attacks Hanif, striking him across the face with all her strength. The blow catches Hanif off guard, and he collapses, more from shock than from pain. As Hanif lies unconscious on the floor, Hind rushes upstairs and begins hurling his office equipment out the window, her anger and frustration spilling out in a destructive frenzy. Meanwhile, Mishal and Anahita look on in horror.

The café descends into chaos. Mishal, fed up with Hind Sufyan, decides to leave home. She packs her bags and announces her departure, daring anyone to stop her. Hind, seeing her daughter on the verge of walking out of her life forever, begs Sufyan to see reason. She wants him to recognize that Saladin's presence has brought nothing but misery to their family. Her pleas go unheard as the building begins to tremble, and the ominous sound of something growling and singing echoes through the walls.

Mishal, unafraid and with Hanif by her side, goes upstairs to see what is happening to Saladin. When they reach the attic, they find Saladin in a terrifying state. He has grown to over eight feet tall, his nostrils emit smoke in two colors—yellow from the left, black from the right—and his once-human form now resembles a demonic beast. Saladin stands before them, naked except for the thick hair covering his body. His tail swishes angrily, and his eyes glow red.

Despite the monstrous sight before her, Mishal does not flinch. She questions Saladin, asking where he plans to go, knowing full well that he wouldn't survive long looking as he does. Saladin, in a voice that rumbles like thunder, responds that he is considering taking action, that there is someone he needs to find. Mishal urges him to wait, promising that they will work something out. In the dead of night, Mishal and Hanif make arrangements to move Saladin to a safer place. They contact their friend Pinkwalla, a local DJ, and convince him to use his van to transport Saladin. Pinkwalla arrives at the Shaandaar Café and watches in awe as Saladin climbs into the back of the van. Then, Pinkwalla drives Saladin to Club Hot Wax, a nightclub filled with wax figures of historical and cultural icons.

Hind's breakdown is a manifestation of her psychological turmoil and the growing tension within the family, exacerbated by Saladin's presence. Her violent outburst and the subsequent chaos mark the fracturing of familial relationships in a scene that recalls Saladin's break from his parents.



Mishal's decision to leave shows her growing sense of independence and rejection of her mother's control. Meanwhile, Hind's inability to understand the root cause of the chaos emphasizes her disconnect from the deeper, underlying issues affecting her family and their environment. This break between mother and daughter corresponds with Saladin's final transformation, which can be heard coming through the walls.



Saladin's monstrous transformation is a physical manifestation of his inner rage, alienation, and the trauma he has experienced. The grotesque imagery of his demon-like appearance reflects his psychological state, as he struggles with his identity and his need for vengeance against Gibreel.



Mishal's pragmatic response to Saladin's predicament illustrates that she understands him far more than she fears him. Saladin, his transformation now complete, wants to find Gibreel as soon as possible to get revenge. However, instead, Mishal arranges for him to go to Club Hot Wax, where he will be surrounded by wax figures that represent British culture. Notably, Saladin is not important enough to be made into a wax figure and, more importantly, he is not "English" enough to make it into the museum.



At the club, Mishal and Hanif lay Saladin down on a couple of sleeping bags. As Saladin drifts into a fitful sleep, his mind fixates on Gibreel. In his dreams, Saladin sees Gibreel's face on every wax figure in the club, mocking him, taunting him. Unable to control his fury, Saladin lashes out, destroying every wax figure in the room. As Saladin succumbs to exhaustion, the intensity of his emotions triggers another transformation. This time, his body shrinks back to its human form. When Mishal, Hanif, and Pinkwalla return to the club in the morning, they find Saladin lying among the wreckage, naked but human once more. His body, though restored, still bears the marks of his ordeal—his eyes still glow a faint red, and his face reflects the bitterness that consumes him.

Saladin's dream of Gibreel taunting him from every wax figure reveals the depth of his anger and obsession. His violent destruction of the wax figures represents his struggle to assert control over his own identity and reject the influence of those who have wronged him. The return to his human form shows that, at least temporarily he has managed to get himself under control. However, the lingering signs of his transformation—the glowing eyes and his expression of bitterness—suggest that his journey of healing and reconciliation is far from complete.



PART 5, CHAPTER 2

Alleluia Cone, while descending from Everest, sees a city of ice. Her sherpa, Pemba, tells her to stay focused, and when she looks back, the city is gone. This moment takes her back to her father's study in Bayswater. Otto Cone, an art historian and survivor of a wartime prison camp. Otto was a heterodox thinker who often warned Allie never to trust anyone who thought they had figured out the world. Otto, who rejected his Polish and Jewish heritage to become English, was both beloved and difficult. He held extreme views, such as his hatred of communism, which sometimes led to embarrassing outbursts, much to the dismay of his wife, Alicja.

Allie's fleeting vision of an ice city acts as a momentary bridge between the surreal and her lived reality. The sudden disappearance of this city upon her sherpa's reminder to focus suggests that Allie is caught between worlds—the tangible and the imagined. Meanwhile, Otto's rejection of his own Polish and Jewish roots to become English parallels Allie's struggle with her own identity.



Alicja, after Otto's death by suicide, abandoned the elegance she had maintained for him and made a simpler life for herself and Allie. Allie, distancing herself from the academic path Otto had envisioned for her, turned to mountaineering. For much of her life, Allie always felt like her mother supported her. However, this changes when Allie starts seeing Gibreel, who her mother immediately dislikes. After finding Gibreel in the show, Allie takes him home and the two rekindle their relationship.

Alicja's shift to a simpler existence signals her release from Otto's dominating intellectual presence. Allie's turn to mountaineering, rather than the academic career Otto envisioned, also sees her going against her father's rigid expectations. This choice shows her desire to carve her own path, away from the intellectual confines that defined her father. However, try as she might to leave her father behind, she cannot do so altogether, just as Saladin and Gibreel cannot leave their pasts in the past.



As Gibreel and Allie grow closer, they spend most of their time in bed. However, the two do spend some quality time talking, as well. Allie tells Gibreel that after she reached the summit of Mount Everest, she felt empty inside. Although the view was sublime, it also parked the pinnacle of her existence. She also tells him about the visions she experienced, not just on Everest but also in London, where she saw icebergs resembling the world's highest mountains sailing up the Thames. Gibreel listens without questioning her, knowing how dreams and reality can get mixed up with each other.

Allie and Gibreel's relationship intensifies not only physically but also emotionally as they open up to each other about their deepest fears and disappointments. Allie's confession about feeling empty after summiting Everest, despite its breathtaking beauty, mirrors Gibreel's experience of feeling empty after his rebirth. Still, this bond, grounded in their mutual existential struggles, remains tenuous—held together by a thin thread of empathy rather than a stable foundation.



Despite her success as a mountaineer, Allie fears her fate is tied to Everest. She hides from Gibreel her growing obsession with the idea of a solo ascent, inspired by Maurice Wilson, a figure she begins to see as a ghostly presence. Gibreel, struggling with his own demons, becomes possessive over Allie, who has become a media darling. Allie swings between embracing the media spotlight and longing for solitude. Gibreel, on the other hand, begins to believe he might truly be an archangel, a realization that strains their already troubled relationship.

Gibreel and Allie spent their days isolated from the world. Gibreel's jealousy first appears when Gibreel notices three cartoons that Allie had hung by her front door. Each one had the same inscription: "To A., in hopes, from Brunel." Gibreel angrily demands an explanation. Allie, amused, teases him—she thinks he cannot really be jealous. However, when Gibreel responds with what seems like over-the-top anger, Allie explains that Jack Brunel is an animator in his late 50s who knew her father. She assures Gibreel that she has no romantic interest in Brunel, though she knows Brunel is interested in her. Gibreel, still angry, asks why she kept the cartoons. Allie says it is simply because she likes them.

The third cartoon is from a Japanese animator. It depicts a man falling from a skyscraper onto a steel spike. Gibreel finds it despicable. After these gifts fail to win Allie over, Brunel drunkenly shows up at her apartment one night, strips naked, and presents himself to her. Allie makes Brunel get dressed and, afterwards, he never returns. However, when Allie tells Gibreel what happened, Gibreel is furious. He suspects that she secretly still wants to be with Brunel, even though she has shown no indication that this is the case. This begins an argument that ends with Allie telling Gibreel to go away, as she is fed up with his jealousy.

As he leaves, Gibreel hears a loud noise, after which he sees God sitting on Allie's bed. The God he sees is not what he expected—a balding man with a partially grey beard and glasses. Gibreel asks, "Who are you?" and the figure answered, "Ooparvala," the Fellow Upstairs. Gibreel, doubting, asked how he could be sure it wasn't "Neechayvala," the Guy from Underneath. The figure, now angry, scolds Gibreel for doubting and says it is time for him to fulfill his purpose. Although Allie, now calm, tries to get Gibreel to stay, Gibreel tells her that he needs to go.

Allie's hidden obsession with a solo ascent of Everest reveals her unspoken desire to push her limits once more. Her connection to Wilson, whom she envisions as a ghostly presence, suggests her fascination with those who confront death and the unknown. She is literally chasing a ghost—which, although aspirational, is also rather ominous. As Allie wrestles with her personal goals, Gibreel seemingly starts to become delusional, which begins the downfall of their relationship.



Gibreel's jealousy becomes a key point of tension in his relationship with Allie. His overreaction to the cartoons reveals his insecurities and deep-seated fears of abandonment. Allie's initial amusement at his jealousy soon gives way to frustration, highlighting how Gibreel's paranoia and inability to trust are starting to fracture their relationship. This scene captures the further signs of their unraveling connection, as Gibreel grows increasingly unstable.



Gibreel's reaction to Brunel's stunt—more anger and suspicion—escalates his jealousy to a new level. Even though Allie clearly dismisses Brunel, Gibreel's distrust blinds him to the facts. This is a turning point where Allie's patience with Gibreel's possessiveness wears thin, showing how his jealousy is not just an issue of insecurity but a fundamental flaw in his personality that drives people away.



The casual depiction of God as an ordinary man with glasses adds a layer of absurdity and challenges Gibreel's perception of faith. His doubt over whether this is God or the Devil reveals his deep internal conflict and inability to trust even his spiritual encounters. It's a moment that pushes him further into the spiral of his own paranoia and need for validation. Notably, the description given here resembles the real Salman Rushdie, who is Gibreel's creator.



Outside, Gibreel wanders through London, seeing the city as a place lost in its past, confused about the present, and hopeless about the future. He sees the city's decay and feels the presence of his enemy, Shaitan. Remembering ancient stories, he realizes how close he had come to danger by being with Allie. Now, he sees that his choice is clear; he must reject the dangerous love of human desires and embrace the love of God. In retrospect, he views Allie as a temptress who had almost led him to ruin, but he is now grateful for being saved just in time.

As Gibreel walks around London, Rekha continues to haunt him. She appears beside him, throwing insults and accusing Allie of being with him only because she wants to become a mother. After a long stream of mocking, Gibreel finally escapes Rekha for a moment. Then, desperate to prove his divine powers, Gibreel attempts to perform a miracle for Orphia Phillips, Hyacinth Phillips' sister, but fails miserably. Rekha returns, mocking his failure, and offers to stop haunting him if he just tells her he loves her. Gibreel argues with her until he falls into a daze. When he finally wakes up, Rekha is gone.

Determined to prove himself as an agent of God, Gibreel steps in front of a moving car, which strikes him. The driver, famous film producer S. S. Sisodia, instantly recognizes Gibreel from his films. Sisodia takes Gibreel back to Allie, calling the accident a sort of "miracle," as Gibreel did not suffer any injuries. After the accident, doctors treat Gibreel, diagnose him with schizophrenia, and prescribe him a strong medication.

This ordeal deepens Allie's love for the troubled Gibreel. Sisodia, frequently present during Gibreel's recovery, pushes him to return to the movie industry. When the negotiations do not seem to be going Sisodia's way, he threatens legal action over old contracts. Despite Allie's concerns, Gibreel agrees to star in a film as the archangel Gibreel. He thinks it will be good for him to get back to the big screen, as it will help him to regain aspects of his former self, which he desperately needs at the moment. However, as Gibreel becomes more like his old self, his relationship with Allie starts to unravel.

At a promotional event for his new film, Gibreel struggles to distinguish between his film role and the role he plays in his dreams. He slips into a trance, feeling as though he is floating high above London. From this perspective, he believes he can see Saladin, who still looks like a goat. Eventually, Gibreel collapses on Allie's doorstep. Allie finds him and helps him inside, before putting him to bed.

Gibreel's walk through London turns into an internal monologue about his perceived battle between divine purpose and human desire. Viewing Allie as a temptress aligns with his black-and-white view of the world, where everything is a test or a threat. This moment reflects his descent into a kind of religious fanaticism, where he believes he must choose between purity and corruption, further illustrating his detachment from reality.



Rekha's haunting symbolizes Gibreel's guilt and unresolved conflicts, as well as his fears about his waning powers. His failed attempt to perform a miracle shows his desperation to reclaim his sense of divine authority. Rekha's taunts keep him trapped in a cycle of self-doubt and anger, representing the internal struggle between his inflated sense of self-importance and his crippling insecurities.



Sisodia's declaration of a "miracle" speaks to the ongoing tension in the novel between the supernatural and the mundane. Gibreel's schizophrenia diagnosis grounds his visions and paranoia in a psychological framework, which complicates the reader's perception of his divine encounters and further isolates him from those around him.



Gibreel's return to acting represents an attempt to reclaim his past glory and sense of self, but it comes at a cost. His renewed association with the archangel role in the film blurs the boundary between his delusions and reality even further. As he clings to this former identity, the cracks in his relationship with Allie widen, showing how his inability to separate his inner turmoil from his outer life continues to damage his closest bonds.



Gibreel's trance during the film promotion reveals his deteriorating mental state. His inability to separate his film character from his dream persona shows the extent of his psychological disintegration. His collapse at Allie's doorstep shows his physical and emotional exhaustion, demonstrating that the life he is leading is unsustainable.



PART 6

Baal, now an aging poet in Jahilia, witnesses the return of the Prophet Mahound after 25 years in exile. Baal, now a decrepit figure, is mocked by strangers in the street as he heads home through the hardened, decaying city. Jahilia, once vibrant, has become a stagnant, impoverished place under Mahound's growing power. The city, now cut off from its lifeblood of pilgrims and caravans, struggles to survive. The Grandee of Jahilia (Abu Simbel), once powerful, has grown old and feeble, while his wife Hind, rumored to be a witch, remains unnaturally youthful and fierce.

Hind dominates the city, ruling it through her terrifying reputation and a series of public proclamations. The people of Jahilia, despite the city's decay, continue to see Hind as a symbol of their greatness, forgiving her excesses and believing in her delusions of immortality. Meanwhile, Baal, detached from public life, writes poems of unrequited love, feeling increasingly isolated in the decaying city.

One day, Baal returns home to find Salman the Persian, a former close associate of Mahound. Salman, now disillusioned and fearful of Mahound's return, shares his story with Baal. He recounts how Mahound's obsession with control and the endless rules revealed by the Archangel Gibreel led him to question the authenticity of the revelations. Salman admits to secretly altering the verses as he transcribed them, only to find that Mahound never noticed the changes. At first, Salman made minor changes to test if Mahound was paying attention. However, Mahound did not notice the alterations. Thinking it strange, Salman started making far more significant alterations. To his shock, Mahound did not catch these either. Feeling betrayed, Salman abandons Mahound, who he feels has been corrupted by power.

Baal, now in hiding, takes refuge in The Curtain, Jahilia's most popular brothel, where the Madam disguises him as a eunuch. Inside the brothel, Baal learns from the gossip of the customers that the people of Jahilia are secretly defying Mahound's rules and continuing to indulge in forbidden pleasures.

Baal, once a prominent poet, now embodies the decay of Jahilia under Mahound's expanding influence. His physical decline parallels the city's deterioration from a vibrant hub to a lifeless place. As Baal navigates the decaying streets, he becomes a relic in a society that no longer values his once-celebrated dissent. He is a fallen artist who has failed to suppress Mahound's religious fervor.



Hind's youthful appearance, contrasted with the city's physical decay, embodies the desperation to maintain an illusion of vitality. The people's continued loyalty to Hind, despite the evident deterioration of their world, indicates the allure of authoritarian figures who offer stability in times of crisis—even if that stability is based on delusion.



Salman the Persian's story reveals the cracks in Mahound's claim to divine authority. By altering the sacred verses and discovering that Mahound does not notice, Salman exposes the potential human fallibility and manipulation behind what is presented as divine revelation. This subversion not only undermines the prophet's credibility but also demonstrates the vulnerability of any leader who relies on unquestioning obedience. Salman's disillusionment reflects a broader critique of the dangers inherent in absolute power and the ease with which the desire for control can corrupt faith.



Baal's retreat to The Curtain, is a small act of defiance against Mahound's religious restrictions. Disguised as a eunuch, he immerses himself in the last bastion of resistance within the city, where people secretly indulge in forbidden pleasures.



Baal comes up with a plan to mock Mahound directly. He convinces the Madam to have the 12 sex workers in the brothel take on the identities of Mahound's 12 wives. The masquerade becomes wildly popular among the men of Jahilia, who flock to the brothel to indulge in this blasphemous fantasy. Baal, now more emboldened, even marries the 12 sex workers, assuming the role of their husband, much like Mahound with his real wives.

The success of this scheme attracts attention, and eventually, which leads someone to recognize Baal as an infamous satirist. Baal is arrested and brought to trial alongside the prostitutes. In court, he confesses openly to orchestrating the masquerade. Mahound's followers, hearing his story, cannot contain their laughter at Baal's audacity. Mahound, seeing Baal as a dangerous reflection of his own flaws, sentences the poet to death, knowing that Baal's irreverence is a threat to his authority.

The 12 sex workers are sentenced to death by stoning, and Baal is beheaded shortly afterward. Mahound, despite his absolute power, still fears the spirit of Baal, as he dared to mock the very foundations of his rule. Many years later, Hind emerges to celebrate Mahound's impending death, believing that her witchcraft has finally brought about his end. As Mahound dies in Ayesha's arms, a vision of Al-Lat visits him and claims responsibility for Baal's illness, describing it as revenge for her destruction. Mahound accepts his fate, knowing that his time has come. He chooses to enter the kingdom of God, leaving his followers to carry on his legacy.

The decision to have the 12 sex workers impersonate Mahound's wives is Baal's boldest act of satire and rebellion. This masquerade not only mocks the sacred institution of Mahound's polygamy but also serves as a commentary on the absurdity of religious and patriarchal authority. By marrying the 12 sex workers, Baal ridicules the prophet's divine authority, turning it into a spectacle for public consumption.



Baal's arrest and trial mark the climax of his defiance. His open confession of orchestrating the masquerade sees him refusing to be silenced or intimidated. The laughter of Mahound's followers in court highlights the subversive power of humor and irreverence in undermining authoritarian regimes. Baal's ability to expose the contradictions in Mahound's rule makes him a dangerous figure. His execution, though meant to quell dissent, exposes the regime's fear of mockery and its need to suppress any challenge to its legitimacy.



The execution of Baal and the 12 sex workers does not extinguish the spirit of rebellion. Even in death, Baal's irreverence haunts Mahound, reflecting the limits of authoritarian power. Hind's celebration of Mahound's impending death serves as a reminder that power is never absolute and that resistance, whether through satire or witchcraft, persists. The vision of Al-Lat as Mahound dies further complicates the narrative, suggesting that the divine and the demonic are intertwined and that every act of destruction carries within it the seeds of its own undoing. This suggestion—and the depiction of Mahound in general as a tyrant—is Rushdie's most controversial statement in the novel. Like the poet Baal, he is speaking against an entire religion, a decision which lead to dire consequences in Rushdie's real life.



PART 7, CHAPTER 1

Saladin, reflecting on his life up to this point, concludes that everything boils down to love. He thinks about his past loves, particularly his deep affection for English culture and London, a city he once adored above all else. Saladin had always believed London's blend of old and new mirrored his own identity, and he cherished its hospitality despite his recent experiences with discrimination. Additionally, he recalls his love for Pamela and the joy he once found in their shared life. However, now he finds himself disillusioned with both his love for her and the city.

Saladin's former love for London, a city he once saw as a reflection of his own mixed identity, represents his idealized vision of what his life could have been. However, recent experiences of discrimination and alienation have shattered this ideal, mirroring his disillusionment with the city and his love for Pamela. Really, Pamela and London represent the same thing to Saladin: the promise of Englishness, which now appears far more complicated than it once seemed.



Saladin also held a deep, private love for a recurring dream in which he taught a young boy to ride a bicycle in a sun-dappled park. The dream, which once brought him happiness, now only makes him feel lonely, as he was never able to have children. Even though Saladin has regained his human form, he still feels lost in the world. In an attempt to get himself back on his feet, he visits Pamela to reclaim his place in their shared home.

Saladin's recurring dream of teaching a boy to ride a bicycle in a sunlit park reveals his yearning for fatherhood. This dream, which once brought him solace, now serves as a painful reminder of what he cannot have. It highlights his profound sense of loss—not just of a potential child, but of a life that feels whole.



Though Saladin's return visibly shocks Pamela, she allows him to live in the house, knowing it is his legal right. For the moment, Saladin intends to live with Pamela and Jumpy, though he eventually plans to divorce Pamela and sell the house. The encounter between Saladin and Pamela is awkward, as both realize they have fallen out of love with each other. Still, Saladin feels guilty for not wanting her back. He moves back into his den, feeling emotionally disconnected from Pamela and overwhelmed as he realizes his marriage is truly over.

Saladin's return to his marital home, now shared with Pamela and Jumpy, is filled with awkwardness. Both he and Pamela are aware that their marriage has run its course, yet Saladin feels guilt for not wanting to rekindle their relationship. This sense of detachment, compounded by his realization that his marriage is truly over suggests that the life he once knew is officially over.



As he attempts to rebuild his life, Saladin's lingering traumas from recent events prevent him from returning to normal. He becomes obsessed with television, noticing that it is filled with images of mutants and freaks that reflect his own fractured sense of reality. He tries to convince himself that he no longer harbors hatred toward Gibreel, but deep down the pain of betrayal is still there.

Saladin's fixation on television and its grotesque imagery of mutants and freaks reflects his internal struggle to come to terms with his transformation. The TV becomes a mirror to his fractured psyche, displaying images that resonate with his feelings of alienation.



Saladin's sense of dread intensifies when he starts dreaming of two women: Mishal Sufyan and Zeeny Vakil. His dreams become a battleground where his past and present collide, and he struggles to maintain his grasp on reality. Meanwhile, Jumpy becomes increasingly anxious about Saladin's presence in the house, seeing him as a threat. Despite this, Jumpy tries to accommodate Saladin, even bringing him meals and engaging him in conversation. For her part, Pamela quickly grows frustrated with Jumpy's over-politeness, which she feels is spineless.

Saladin's dreams of Mishal Sufyan and Zeeny Vakil reflect his unresolved emotional and psychological conflicts. These visions are a battleground where his past and present intertwine, leaving him unable to distinguish reality from fantasy. Meanwhile, Jumpy's anxieties are also a form of guilt; he is annoyed with Saladin's presence, but he also cannot help but feel bad. The same cannot be said for Pamela.



Saladin's growing discomfort with his life culminates when he attends a public meeting about Dr. Uhuru Simba, the political activist arrested for murder. At the meeting, Saladin feels out of place and disconnected from the cause, noting that the crowd seems more focused on political activism than on the truth of Simba's violent history. During the meeting, Saladin experiences a vision of Mishal Sufyan with a **blazing fire** on her forehead, which he interprets as a sign that she is dangerous to him. The vision triggers a premonition of his own death, causing him to leave the meeting in a state of panic.

Interestingly, Saladin does not feel as fervently about Simba as the other participants, despite his own recent experiences with xenophobia. He cannot bring himself to carry about political causes over the deeds of individuals and, as such, he does not feel strongly about what happens to Simba. Additionally, Saladin's vision of fire is a rather ominous sign, as fire is a destructive force in the novel.



After the protest, Saladin decides to go with Joshi to a karate school. Joshi, who teaches karate, mentions that Alleluia Cone is one of his best students. Though she isn't at the class, everyone talks about her relationship with the famous actor Gibreel. This news makes Saladin feel as if all the scattered pieces of his life are starting to converge. He hails a taxi and, while riding, overhears Eugene Dumsday, an American, recounting his miraculous escape from the hijacking on the radio.

As Saladin leaves the class, he realizes that he is being pulled back into a world he thought he left behind—a world filled with darkness and uncertainty. He experiences a growing sense of inevitability, as though his life is being guided by forces beyond his control. His attempts to return to a normal life seem increasingly futile, and he begins to accept that the changes within him are irreversible. Saladin's journey has brought him to a crossroads where he must choose between confronting the darkness within him or continuing to live in denial. In the end, he chooses to accept that his old life is gone and that he must face whatever lies ahead.

Saladin's trip to Joshi's karate class offers him a chance to finally gain insight into what has occurred since he split with Gabriel. Further synchronicities occur on his ride home as another member of Flight 420, Eugene, also comes back into his life. However, a possible reunion between Gabriel and Saladin remains a troubling prospect.



Saladin's realization, that his attempts to find normalcy are in vain, marks a turning point where he begins to accept that his transformation—both physical and psychological—is irreversible. Confronted with the darkness within him, Saladin chooses to face it rather than continue living in denial. This acceptance is a significant step in his character's journey, indicating a move toward self-awareness and possibly a new beginning.



PART 7, CHAPTER 2

London is in the midst of a dangerous heatwave. During this time, Mr. Billy Battuta—a famous actor noted for his mistreatment of women—and his companion, Mimi Mamouloulian—Saladin's former co-star—announce their “grand coming-out” party. They recently returned to the city after dealing with legal troubles in New York. Billy's business connections helped him get a lenient judge, and his charm convinced several wealthy women to sign a clemency petition. They believe Billy has genuinely repented and deserves a lighter punishment than prison. The judge agrees and gives Billy a lenient sentence of deportation and a fine. Mimi, seen as merely an accomplice, receives a suspended sentence.

Billy and Mimi return to London and immediately start celebrating at Crockford's, a private club. They send out invitations to their big party, which is planned to take place on a giant sound stage at Shepperton film studios. This location has been transformed into a recreation of Dickensian London, for a movie adaptation of Charles Dickens's last completed novel. The party is expected to be filled with celebrities, socialites, and important figures.

Billy's manipulation of the legal system and society's readiness to forgive him due to his charisma and influence showcases how fame corrupts justice. Despite Billy's reputation, he is still one of London's most popular figures and everyone wants to attend his party. Billy's experience can be telling contrasted with the of Dr. Uhuru Simba, who is being framed with crimes he did not commit. The way the legal system treats these two characters exposes its racist and xenophobic tendencies.



The choice of a Dickensian London set for the party is a clever metaphor for the blend of hypocrisy, wealth, and spectacle. It's a nod to the dualities in Dickens' works—poverty versus wealth, morality versus corruption—mirroring the social dynamics at play in this story. The recreated city setting serves as a stage where the characters' conflicts as the stage is finally set for a reunion between Saladin and Gibreel.



On the night of the party, the heat is unbearable. Pamela and Jumpy arrive together in Pamela's car, while Saladin, who prefers to travel alone, takes a coach that the hosts provide. The party setting is impressive, with various famous locations from Dickens's London condensed into the studio space. The guests, including society grandees, fashion models, film stars, and minor royalty, mingle with hired extras dressed in period costumes. Saladin spots Gibreel in the crowd, surrounded by admirers with Allie by his side.

Saladin makes his way through the dense crowd, determined to reach Gibreel. However, the crowd suddenly parts as loud music starts, and Saladin is pushed back into a fake building, the "Curiosity Shop." Inside the fake building, a woman approaches him, flirtatiously talking about the cast's romantic escapades during the show's run. She exposes her breast, revealing a map of London drawn on it. Saladin, overwhelmed, escapes back into the chaotic street.

Gibreel, standing on a replica of London Bridge, looks directly at Saladin and raises his arm in greeting. Saladin, filled with resentment, recalls how Gibreel stood by silently while the policemen humiliated and captured Saladin. Saladin realizes that he blames Gibreel for everything that has gone wrong in his life since boarding Flight 420. Still, Saladin approaches Gibreel and exchanges pleasantries with him. Despite Gibreel's friendly demeanor, Saladin's anger quickly grows because Allie's presence reminds him of the English wife he lost. Gibreel talks extensively about his sex life with Allie, which is quite active. Saladin quickly gets the sense that Gibreel does not actually love Allie. Rather, he simply enjoys having sex with her. As he listens, Saladin drinks heavily, trying to numb his pain.

Gibreel, trying to be nice, begins asking Saladin about Pamela. Saladin tells Gibreel that Pamela is pregnant. Not realizing that Saladin is not the father, Gibreel congratulates him and is confused when Saladin grows irate. Eventually, Saladin tells the whole truth: Pamela is pregnant with Jumpy's child. Jumpy gave Pamela the child that she always wanted, which Saladin could never produce.

Gibreel, disturbed after hearing Saladin's revelation, suddenly disappears. Saladin tells Allie that Gibreel is gone, which causes her to grow frantic. The party descends into chaos when an actor rows down the studio's fake Thames, carrying the unconscious body of Jumpy, whom Gibreel knocked out. A week later, Saladin finds himself on a journey to Scotland with Allie, who has asked for his help in dealing with Gibreel's deteriorating mental state. Gibreel's condition has worsened, and Allie has taken him to a secluded area away from the public eye.

The stifling heat parallels the hidden animosities simmering under the surface at the party. Meanwhile, the grandeur and artificiality of the setting, filled with important guests and actors dressed in period costumes, emphasize the fabricated reality in which many actors live. When Saladin spots Gibreel and Allie with Gibreel's admirers it sparks his jealousy and makes him think that Gibreel has been living an angelic life while his own life has quite literally gone to hell.



The "Curiosity Shop" is a surreal space that reflects Saladin's inner chaos. The woman's flirtatious behavior and the bizarre tattoo on her body show how reality and fantasy blend in Saladin's mind. The map of London on her breast may represent a kind of distorted navigation, echoing Saladin's lost sense of direction—both literally and figuratively—amidst his desire for revenge against Gibreel.



Saladin's interaction with Gibreel on the replica bridge is loaded with unresolved anger. Gibreel's casual bragging about his sex life reveals his insensitivity and reinforces Saladin's perception of him as shallow and self-centered. Saladin's drinking is coping mechanism and an indication of his spiraling state of mind, as he decides what to do next. The more Gibreel talks, the more Saladin feels like Gibreel has managed to get everything that Saladin has always wanted for himself, even if this is not true in reality.



This moment is a deep cut for Saladin, further highlighting his feelings of inadequacy. Gibreel's ignorance about the situation, and his blundering attempt to be polite, only aggravates Saladin more, pushing him deeper into his resentment.



The escalating chaos at the party mirrors the breakdown of relationships and sanity among the characters. Gibreel's violent outburst toward Jumpy reflects his growing instability, while Allie's decision to take him away to a remote area shows her desperate attempt to manage the situation. Despite what Saladin assumed, it seems that all is not well with Gibreel—in fact, he seems to be worse than ever.



Saladin, still harboring his own vengeful feelings, pretends to be sympathetic. At the remote getaway, Gibreel confesses to Saladin his fears and frustrations about his mental health, revealing that he has even attacked Allie in a fit of madness. Allie, trying to cope with Gibreel's worsening condition, feels guilty and responsible for his decline. Saladin listens to their woes and alternates between feeling bad and plotting his revenge.

The next day, Gibreel insists on climbing a nearby hill with Saladin despite the rainy weather. On the hike, Gibreel becomes paranoid and rants about protecting Allie from the lustful gazes of other men. Saladin realizes that Allie cannot continue living this way for long and considers how he might exploit the situation. As they drive back to the train station, Allie talks about her struggles, and Saladin encourages her to stay connected to her own life and not let Gibreel isolate her. He subtly plants the seeds of doubt and fear in her mind, hoping he drive a wedge between her and Gibreel.

Back in London, Gibreel becomes increasingly obsessed with Allie while Saladin continues to manipulate them. Saladin, using his skills as a voice actor, begins making anonymous phone calls to Gibreel and Allie, using different voices to drive them apart. Over time, Gibreel becomes convinced that Allie is unfaithful. All this culminates in a final, violent outburst. Gibreel destroys Allie's prized possessions in a fit of rage before leaving her for good. Allie, heartbroken and furious, vows never to take him back.

Saladin, satisfied with the success of his plan, feels a twisted sense of triumph. Meanwhile, Gibreel, now completely unhinged, walks into a store and buys a **trumpet**, declaring himself the right hand of God. The shop attendants are stunned as they witness what seems to be a supernatural event. Although they initially think Gibreel is crazy, they then see what looks like a halo around his head. After purchasing the trumpet, Gibreel names it "Azrael."

Saladin's duality is on full display here—he acts like a confidant but is fueled by a desire for vengeance. Gibreel's admissions reveal how deep his paranoia runs, while Allie's guilt shows the emotional toll of dealing with his mental decline. Saladin's manipulation of the situation shows his capacity for cruelty, as he uses their vulnerabilities to his advantage.



Gibreel's paranoia about Allie highlights his deteriorating grasp on reality. Saladin's calculated manipulation during this vulnerable moment shows his strategic mind at work, sowing doubt in Allie to further isolate Gibreel. This is another step in his quiet but effective campaign to turn them against each other. Although Saladin was previously a rather sympathetic character in the novel, here, he becomes a sort of villain, which matches his demonic transformation.



Saladin's manipulation reaches its peak as he uses his voice-acting talents to play on Gibreel's insecurities. The anonymous calls are a psychological attack that preys on Gibreel's paranoia, gradually pushing him over the edge. Gibreel's violent reaction and the destruction of Allie's possessions signal his complete breakdown.



Saladin's feeling of triumph reveals the dark side of his character, showing that his obsession with revenge has completely consumed him. Meanwhile, Gibreel now seems to have fully accepted that he is a divine agent. The vision of a halo reinforces the ambiguity of his condition—is it a genuine miracle, or just another hallucination? Naming the trumpet "Azrael," after the angel of death, suggests that Gibreel sees himself as an instrument of divine judgment.



PART 7, CHAPTER 3

Dr. Uhuru Simba dies under suspicious circumstances while in police custody awaiting trial. The official account claims that Simba died due to a freak accident during a nightmare. The massive man reportedly screamed in his sleep, causing him to lift off his bunk and fall to the ground, breaking his neck instantly. The explanation is met with skepticism, especially from Simba's mother, Antoinette Roberts, who speaks out vehemently against the police. Addressing an angry crowd outside the Brickhall police station, Antoinette accuses the authorities of playing with the lives of Black people. Hanif, Simba's solicitor, adds fuel to the fire by highlighting the improbabilities in the police's account. Both he and Antoinette suspect that racism played a significant role in Simba's death.

Simba's death ignites a deep-seated anger in the black community of London. The media portrays Simba as a dangerous radical with ties to controversial figures like Qaddafi, Khomeini, and Louis Farrakhan, reinforcing the perception of him as a monster who deserved his fate. However, within the black community, Simba is seen as a martyr, and his death only intensifies the simmering anger that has been building over time. The streets of Brickhall become a battleground, with the police increasing their presence in response to the rising tensions.

The already volatile situation is further inflamed when the "Granny Ripper" strikes again, twice within two nights. The police push the theory of a copycat killer, but the community remains unconvinced. The police presence in the area quadruples, leading to more clashes between the authorities and the residents, particularly young black and Asian men who are determined to resist what they see as oppressive policing.

As tensions continue to rise, violent incidents become more frequent. Black families on council estates are targeted, schoolchildren are harassed, and fights break out in pubs. Stories of police brutality circulate, fueling the anger and leading to the formation of self-defense patrols by young Sikh, Bengali, and Afro-Caribbean men. Hanif predicts that another Ripper killing could be the final straw that leads to an explosion of violence. He suggests that the killer is not only flaunting his freedom but also mocking Simba's death, which is something the community cannot tolerate.

Simba's suspicious death and the implausible official explanation ignite outrage, revealing deep-seated issues of systemic racism and police brutality. Antoinette Roberts' vocal criticism reflects the anger and distrust brewing within the Black community, who see Simba not just as a victim, but as another casualty in a long history of racially motivated violence. Hanif's skepticism adds legitimacy to the community's claims, pushing the narrative beyond just a grieving mother's anger to a broader social indictment.



The polarized portrayals of Simba—either as a dangerous radical or a martyr—demonstrate how media narratives can manipulate public perception. This dual narrative exacerbates the divide between the Black community and the authorities, with Simba's death acting as a catalyst for the existing tensions. The battleground of Brickhall becomes a microcosm for larger societal conflicts, where police overreach and racial profiling collide with demands for justice.



The police's attempts to explain the situation away as a copycat crime only deepen the mistrust. The heightened police presence and aggressive tactics provoke more resistance from the community, creating a cycle of escalating tensions and violence. This dynamic highlights the breakdown of trust in a system that is supposed to represent justice and safety.



The escalation of violence and the targeting of Black families and schoolchildren underscore the pervasive racism in the community. The formation of self-defense patrols is a direct response to the perceived failure of the police to protect minority communities. Hanif's prediction of an imminent explosion of violence suggests that the community has reached its breaking point.



Into this tense atmosphere steps Gibreel. He wanders the city, which now seems alien to him, in a state of delirium. Gibreel has been roaming without food or sleep for days and is increasingly unable to distinguish between waking life and dreaming. He carries the **trumpet** Azrael and contemplates whether he is an angel of life or an angel of death. The city sends him conflicting messages, as everywhere there are images of oppression and triumph.

As he wanders through the streets, Gibreel's perception becomes increasingly fragmented. He encounters memories of Allie, which are bittersweet as he now feels as though she has betrayed him. His mind, fractured by his experiences, merges different realities and narratives, making it difficult for him to grasp the truth of his situation. He hears the **trumpet** calling to him, urging him to unleash its power, but he resists, unsure of what path to take.

One night, Gibreel finds himself in the red-light district, surrounded by young, underage sex workers, most of whom are not white and are being exploited. He feels a deep, inexplicable connection to them, sensing their pain and desperation. As they approach him, their bravado fades, and they kneel before him, recognizing in him a power they do not fully understand. Gibreel takes out the **trumpet** and blows, releasing a stream of **fire** that consumes the sex workers' pimps, leaving nothing behind but ashes. This act of destruction brings Gibreel a moment of clarity; he understands that he is both a destroyer and a fulfiller of desires—a being capable of granting wishes but also an agent of destruction.

With this realization, Gibreel heads toward Brickhall, where the tension is at its peak. As he walks, he breathes in the desires of the city's inhabitants. He decides that the city must be cleansed by **fire**, a purging that will fulfill the deepest desires of its residents while also destroying them. He walks through the low-cost housing estates. Some of the buildings are named after battles, while others have been renamed after freedom fighters like Mandela. As he walks, Gibreel blows his **trumpet** again, and flames sprout from the ground, forming a multicolored inferno that engulfs the buildings and the people within them. The flames create a nightmarish landscape of fire, which consumes everything in its path.

Meanwhile, Saladin, who has been trying to reestablish some semblance of normalcy in his life, finds himself drawn back into the chaos. After dining with Allie, he steps out into the night and witnesses the advance of the police and the eruption of violence in the streets. Instinctively, he runs, not realizing he is heading toward the Shaandaar Café, the epicenter of the **firestorm** that Gibreel has unleashed.

Gibreel's delirious wandering through a city on the brink mirrors his own internal chaos. The trumpet Azrael, symbolizing both life and death, reinforces Gibreel's confusion about his role, as he does not know if he is supposed to be a creator or a destroyer. Furthermore, he does not know if the city itself is in an elevated or a fallen state.



The trumpet's call represents the allure of destruction, but Gibreel's hesitation indicates his struggle between acting on his destructive impulses and seeking a more redemptive path. Again, this tension within Gibreel mirrors the chaotic and morally ambiguous environment of the city around him.



Gibreel's decision to "cleanse" the city through fire evokes apocalyptic imagery, suggesting a purging of both sin and suffering. The references to housing estates named after battles and freedom fighters highlight a historical irony: places named for liberation are now sites of destruction. The flames serve as a symbol for both societal anger and the uncontrollable nature of revolutionary fervor. Although one might argue that the flames have a cleansing power, they are ultimately a destructive force that must burn the city down before it can rise from the ashes.



Gibreel's decision to "cleanse" the city by fire is the culmination of his descent into a messianic madness. The symbolism of breathing in the city's desires before destroying it suggests a twisted form of justice—granting what people want, but at a catastrophic cost. The flames that erupt from the ground represent Gibreel's complete embrace of his role as both destroyer and purifier, turning the city into a hellish landscape. Notably, it remains unclear how much of this is actually happening versus what is occurring in Gibreel's mind.



Saladin's unintentional journey toward the heart of the firestorm reflects his inevitable confrontation with the destructive forces that Gibreel has set in motion. Previously, Saladin managed to get revenge on Gibreel and now, it seems, that Gibreel might be coming for some revenge of his own.



Television cameras capture the chaos as the police raid Club Hot Wax. The cameras, with their limited night vision, show the scene in stark, dispassionate terms: the police advancing, helicopters hovering overhead, the destruction of the club, and the arrest of several people, including Pinkwalla. The news reports focus on the supposed criminal activities linked to the club, including drug dealing and other illegal operations, while ignoring the broader social and political context of the unrest. The media portrays the rioters as mindless thugs destroying their own neighborhoods, reinforcing the narrative that the violence is senseless and self-destructive.

Amid the chaos, Gibreel carries Saladin to safety. As Gibreel walks with Saladin in his arms, the **fire** seems to part before them, creating a path through the flames. Outside, Mishal, who has been weeping for her parents, witnesses Gibreel's selfless act. She and Hanif help the two men into an ambulance, where Gibreel, still exhausted and delirious, babbles about the **trumpet** and the fire. Hanif dismisses it as the ravings of a disturbed mind, insisting to Mishal that the events of the night are part of a larger socio-political struggle: they are a process of change in British society, not the result of any mystical forces.

PART 8

Srinivas, a toy merchant, often threatens his wife and children that one day he will abandon everything to become a *sanyasi*, wandering with nothing but a begging bowl and a stick. His wife, Mrs. Srinivas, treats these threats lightly, knowing that he enjoys being seen as both devout and adventurous. However, she is surprised when one day she finds his chair empty, with his glass of lime juice left unfinished.

Srinivas himself cannot fully explain why he leaves the comfort of his porch to witness the arrival of the villagers of Titlipur in Chatnapatna. The village boys have been shouting about an unusual procession led by a girl with silver hair with butterflies flying over her head. Chatnapatna is small enough that the arrival of 150 people causes a stir. Srinivas eventually gives in to his curiosity and joins the crowd at the roadside canteen where the pilgrims gather, just as the Chatnapatna police jeep arrives. The police treat the pilgrimage as a sectarian demonstration, but Mirza Saeed steps forward to clarify that the villagers are walking to the Arabian Sea where they believe the **water** will part for them.

The media's portrayal of the raid on Club Hot Wax exemplifies how narratives can be manipulated to dehumanize communities and downplay legitimate grievances. By focusing on criminal activities and ignoring the larger socio-political issues, the media reinforces stereotypes about the rioters and justifies harsh police actions. This approach frames the unrest as irrational and self-destructive, which dismisses the deeper causes of the conflict and reflects the systemic biases in public discourse.



Gibreel's act of saving Saladin is a moment of redemption in his otherwise destructive journey. The parting of the flames symbolizes a rare moment of clarity and purpose, contrasting sharply with his previous chaos. Hanif's interpretation, rejecting mystical explanations and focusing on the socio-political reality, represents a more grounded perspective on the upheaval.



The narration introduces Srinivas as someone caught between the mundane and the spiritual. His family, who does not take his threats seriously, is surprised when he actually leaves because they do not share his pull for something more.



Srinivas's actions reflect a sense of purpose that compels him to move beyond his everyday life. The arrival of the police and Mirza Saeed's explanation of the pilgrimage highlight the tension between belief and authority: whereas the police see the gathering as potentially subversive, the pilgrims see it as a spiritual journey. These interactions with the pilgrims and the authorities recall the previous chapter where the police and a minority group were similarly at odds.



Srinivas sees Ayesha of Desh, the girl surrounded by butterflies, for the first time and finds her presence striking. When she approaches the police officer, her smile and nod cause him to apologize and withdraw his objections, ending any trouble from the authorities. Later, a group of youths attempts to disrupt the pilgrimage by throwing stones, but the officer quickly arrests them.

Srinivas, filled with a sense of destiny, decides to join the pilgrimage. Despite Mrs. Srinivas's protests, he decides to join the march, though he does not intend to go all the way to the Arabian Sea. As the pilgrimage continues, Srinivas notices that the swarm of butterflies over the heads of the marches acts as a sort of protective shield. Srinivas walks beside Muhammad Din, the village headman, and his wife Khadija, who are contentedly participating in the journey despite their age.

As the pilgrimage progresses, the land is dry and bare, making the journey difficult. Mirza Saeed spends the first weeks of the journey in a state of agitation, constantly trying to convince Mishal to abandon the pilgrimage due to her worsening health. Despite his pleas, Mishal remains resolute, and Mirza finds himself alone in his efforts to stop what he views as a dangerous and foolish mission. Even as the pilgrims face hardships, Ayesha of Desh's influence remains strong, and the group continues on as they seek to fulfill her vision.

Tragedy strikes on the 18th day when Khadija, dreams of the angel Azrael and dies the next morning. Despite Mirza's insistence that she be given a proper burial, Ayesha of Desh insists that they continue directly to the sea, so Khadija is buried by the roadside. As the pilgrimage continues, the health of the older pilgrims deteriorates, and food and **water** become scarce. Ayesha imposes stricter rules, including mandatory prayers and fasting, which leads to more deaths along the way. Despite these losses, the remaining pilgrims march on, their faith in Ayesha unwavering.

Tensions rise when the pilgrimage enters more densely populated areas, leading to harassment from locals and confrontations with the authorities. The situation escalates when a man's steer dies, and Ayesha of Desh's dismissive response causes him to lose his love for her, seeing her now as a messenger of doom rather than hope. By the ninth week, the pilgrimage has attracted national attention, drawing journalists, politicians, and onlookers. However, extremist groups also begin to denounce the "Ayesha Haj," accusing it of inciting communal tensions. Despite these threats, Ayesha remains undeterred, leading the pilgrims closer to their goal.

Ayesha's charisma and the symbolism of the butterflies around her suggest a divine influence, allowing her to defuse tension with ease. Her interaction with the police officer reflects her control over the situation and her ability to sway others, emphasizing her role as a spiritual leader.



Srinivas's decision to join the pilgrimage marks a turning point for his character, moving from passive curiosity to active participation. His perception of the butterflies as a protective shield reinforces the mystical and almost otherworldly nature of the journey. The presence of Muhammad Din and Khadija shows the inclusive nature of the pilgrimage, bringing together people of all ages, bound by a shared sense of purpose.



The harsh landscape exemplifies the physical and spiritual challenges the pilgrims must endure on their journey. Additionally, Mishal's determination despite her declining health showcases the powerful hold that Ayesha's vision has over the pilgrims. Despite Mirza Saeed's desperate attempts to get her to see reason, something about Ayesha makes her want to see the journey to its end.



Khadija's death and Ayesha's insistence on continuing the journey without a proper burial reveal the extent to which the pilgrims' devotion overrides conventional norms and humanity. The deteriorating conditions and strict rules Ayesha imposes showcase the dangerous consequences of blind faith. As the older pilgrims die and resources dwindle, the group's persistence illustrates the powerful, sometimes fatal, influence of charismatic leadership, as they seek transcendence at any cost.



As the pilgrimage moves through more populated areas, it encounters increased hostility. Ayesha's dismissive attitude when faced with the loss of the steer reveals cracks in her influence, showing how absolute faith can falter when confronted with real-world consequences. Also, the growing media and political attention reflect how the pilgrimage has become a national spectacle, with different groups projecting their agendas onto it.



As they near the city of Sarang, known for its coal mines, tensions reach a boiling point. The miners, influenced by communalist agitators, prepare to confront the pilgrims with violence. On the night before they enter Sarang, Ayesha of Desh's butterflies vanish, and the pilgrims are left feeling vulnerable. However, the next day, as they approach the barricade set up by the miners, a **torrential rainstorm** suddenly erupts, washing away the barricade and scattering the mob.

Mirza once again begs Mishal to come home with him, as her health continues to worsen. However, she refuses and continues with the others toward the Arabian Sea. When the pilgrims finally reach the sea, Ayesha stands before the waves and declares that the sea will open for them if they open their hearts. The villagers, filled with renewed faith, follow her into the **water**, ignoring Mirza's desperate pleas for them to stop. As they walk into the sea, they disappear beneath the waves, never to be seen again.

Although Mirza and a few others who did not follow Ayesha of Desh try to save the villagers, they are unsuccessful. Later, some people will insist that they saw the **water** parting, just as Ayesha had promised. Mirza is left in shock, filled with regret for not being able to save those who drowned. He returns to his village, but soon after, he dies. Right before his death, he has a vision of himself walking through the Arabian Sea, alongside the pilgrims and Ayesha.

The disappearance of Ayesha's butterflies symbolizes a loss of divine favor or protection, creating a moment of crisis for the pilgrims. However, the sudden rainstorm that washes away the barricade reinforces the idea of miraculous intervention, rekindling the pilgrims' faith. Here and elsewhere in the novel, water proves to be a cleansing force that renews and restores.



The final act of faith by the pilgrims represents the ultimate test of belief. Their decision to walk into the sea, driven by the promise of a miracle, indicates that they are placing their blind faith in Ayesha. The disappearance of the pilgrims beneath the waves is a haunting image that encapsulates the novel's exploration of the extremes of devotion and the thin line between spiritual transcendence and self-destruction.



The aftermath of the pilgrimage's tragic end shows the lasting impact of Ayesha's vision on those who survived. The insistence by some that they saw the miracle speaks to the enduring power of faith to shape reality, even in the face of death. Additionally, Mirza's final vision of joining the pilgrims suggests a reconciliation with the faith he once opposed.



PART 9

Eighteen months after the chaos in London, Saladin boards a plane to Bombay upon receiving a telegram informing him that his father, Changez, is dying of multiple myeloma, a fatal cancer of the bone marrow. Despite the long years of misunderstandings and emotional distance, Saladin feels an overwhelming need to reach his father before he passes away.

Saladin's journey back to Bombay reflects his desire for reconciliation with his father. The news of Changez's terminal illness breaks down the barriers that years of conflict and misunderstanding have built. Saladin's urgent need to be there at his father's deathbed signifies a deeper need to reconnect with his roots and to make peace with the past that he had been trying to escape.



Saladin faces a frustrating ordeal to obtain a visa at the Indian consulate. His anger flares when he's met with indifference and bureaucracy, and despite his efforts, his visa is delayed, forcing him to wait for the next available flight. When he finally boards his flight, he remembers his last nearly fatal experience aboard an airplane. Overcome with terror, he nearly chickens out but a fellow passenger, Sisodia, notices his fear and reassures him that everything is going to be fine. During the flight, Sisodia, a boisterous movie producer, engages Saladin in conversation, prattling on about the film industry and gossip about mutual acquaintances, including Gibreel, who Sisodia says is now struggling to revive his career. While Sisodia talks, Saladin tries to focus on Changez. Despite their troubled past, Saladin still feels able to forgive Changez for everything.

Upon arrival in Bombay, Saladin makes his way to his childhood home where his stepmother Nasreen and Kasturba greet him. They inform him that Changez's condition is dire: the cancer has spread throughout his bones, and he might pass away at any moment. Despite the advanced state of his illness, no one has told Changez the full extent of his condition. Saladin feels conflicted, believing his father should know the truth. However, his stepmother and Kasturba's willingness to set aside their differences to care for Changez makes him trust their judgment.

When Saladin sees Changez, his father's physical decline is shocking. The cancer has reduced Changez to a skeletal figure, stripping away the layers of harshness that once defined him. Saladin finds himself reconnecting with old, forgotten parts of himself as he reminisces with his father. In the days that follow, Saladin takes on the role of caregiver, shaving his father and helping him with his medication. Changez, aware of his impending death, speaks to Saladin with a calm acceptance, expressing that pain is the only thing he fears. Saladin reassures Changez, promising him that the worst of his pain is already over.

As Changez's condition deteriorates rapidly, Saladin decides to take him to the hospital, but there is little the doctors can do to help him. In his final moments, Changez experiences a profound terror, which deeply unsettles Saladin. Despite this, Changez dies with a smile on his face, leaving Saladin to wonder about the mystery of what his father saw in those final moments. After, Changez's body is returned home, and preparations are made for his funeral. Saladin, along with the other mourners, participate in washing and preparing the body for burial. During this process, Saladin reflects on the significance of death. He feels the weight of his father's life and legacy, as well as his own responsibility to carry on.

Saladin's ordeal at the consulate and his anxiety on the flight serve to underscore the psychological and emotional turbulence he's experiencing as he returns to a place filled with painful memories. Sisodia's chatter about Gibreel provides an ironic counterpoint to Saladin's more serious thoughts, reminding him of the interconnectedness of their lives. Largely ignoring Sisodia—who represents the entertainment business Saladin once left India to join—Saladin instead focuses on his desire to heal his old wounds with his father.



Saladin's return to his childhood home and his encounter with his father's caregivers provide a stark contrast between his memories of the past and the current reality of his father's illness. Saladin's trust in their judgment shows his growing acceptance of different perspectives, moving away from his own rigid viewpoints. Notably, it is only now, at the end of his father's life, that Saladin meets his stepmother for the first time.



Changez's physical decline strips away of the barriers that once defined his relationship with Saladin. As Changez becomes more vulnerable, Saladin begins to see him not as the harsh figure of his youth but as a man facing his mortality. The caregiving role that Saladin assumes signifies his acceptance of responsibility, a role he previously fled. The calm exchange between father and son marks a moment of healing that both men have put off for a long time.



Changez's death scene is layered with ambiguity, reflecting the mystery of what lies beyond death. The mixture of terror and peace that Changez displays as he dies leaves a profound impact on Saladin, who is left contemplating the enigma of his father's death. Meanwhile, the funeral preparations provide a moment for Saladin to connect with his heritage and the traditions he once distanced himself from, representing his full-circle journey back to his roots.



After the funeral, Saladin visits his family home. He discovers **the magic lamp** he recalls from his childhood, which Changez left to him along with a substantial inheritance. As he examines the lamp, Zeeny arrives unexpectedly. She explains that she stayed away to try to hurt Saladin, but now she wants to reconnect. They quickly rekindle their romantic relationship. As Saladin settles back into life in India, he embraces his heritage by returning to the original spelling of his name, Salahuddin.

The rediscovery of the magic lamp symbolizes Saladin's reconnection with his past and his father's legacy. Additionally, Zeeny's return—which coincidentally (or perhaps magically) coincides with Saladin getting his hands on the lamp—allows for a rekindled romance. Also, by reverting to his original name, Salahuddin, Saladin signifies his acceptance of his cultural identity, moving away from the internal conflicts that once defined him.



During this period, Gibreel also travels to India. His attempts to revive his acting career fail, and rumors begin to circulate about his strange behavior, as well as the return of his infamous **bad breath**. Gibreel plans to finance his new films with his own money, but he struggles to complete them. He becomes increasingly unhappy and unwell, especially when the police begin investigating his involvement in Rekha's death.

Gibreel's return to India becomes a futile attempt to reclaim his former glory, which seems doomed to fail. The return of his bad breath suggests that he is rotting from within, putting him on the opposite trajectory from Saladin. Additionally, the police looking into Rekha's death implies that Gibreel may have killed her, which would explain why she haunted him throughout the novel.



As Gibreel's fortune dwindles, his mental state deteriorates further. His illness intensifies when he learns that Allie is coming to India for a mountaineering trip. While in Bombay, Allie stays in the same building where Rekha had taken her own life by jumping from the roof with her child. Gibreel confronts Allie, and in a fit of rage, he throws her from the same rooftop. When the police investigate, they also find Sisodia shot dead in Gibreel's apartment.

Gibreel's murder of Allie and the subsequent death of Sisodia mark his complete unraveling. The setting of Allie's death in the same building as Rekha's draws a parallel between the two women and serves as further evidence that Gibreel may have killed Rekha. After all, he is certainly capable of murder.



Gibreel manages to avoid capture by the police and, with nowhere else to turn, visits Saladin. Once inside, Gibreel begins telling a confused story about the murders. As he talks, he handles **the magic lamp**. Saladin notices that Gibreel has hidden a gun inside the lamp. Gibreel retrieves the gun and tells Saladin that he can no longer live with his illness and that he loved Allie. Just then, a knock on the door signals the arrival of the police. Gibreel uses the gun to take his own life.

Gibreel's visit to Saladin serves as a final confrontation with both his friend and his fate. His handling of the magic lamp, an object associated with childhood wonder, presents a dark contrast to the violence that follows. Gibreel's suicide is his final escape from the torment of his mind. Despite his angelic status earlier in the novel, his life ends in tragedy, suggesting he was never a mouthpiece for God after all.



Shortly afterward, Saladin gazes out of a window, looking over the Arabian Sea. He sees how the moonlight creates a path on the waves. After a moment of quiet contemplation, Saladin decides he must leave his past behind once and for all. Hearing Zeeny behind him, he turns and joins her. Together, they walk out of the room, leaving the open window and the sea behind.

Saladin's decision to leave the past behind represents a significant moment of closure. The moonlit path on the Arabian Sea symbolizes a new beginning, suggesting hope for the future. By turning away from the sea, Saladin rejects the unresolved turmoil of his past, choosing instead to embrace a more grounded future with Zeeny. This final act of turning away from the window and walking forward represents his growth from a man haunted by his past to someone ready to live in the present. Notably, living in the present also means living in India among those whom he has spent his life running away from. Finally, it is worth noting that Saladin's fate is the inverse of Gibreel's, even though he seemed to be the devil to Gibreel's angel earlier in the novel. Once again, this suggests that the core, moral differences between angels and devils are less clearly defined than one might realize.





HOW TO CITE

To cite this LitChart:

MLA

Sawyer, Ian. "*The Satanic Verses*." *LitCharts*. LitCharts LLC, 9 Sep 2024. Web. 10 Sep 2024.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Sawyer, Ian. "*The Satanic Verses*." LitCharts LLC, September 9, 2024. Retrieved September 10, 2024. <https://www.litcharts.com/lit/the-satanic-verses>.

To cite any of the quotes from *The Satanic Verses* covered in the Quotes section of this LitChart:

MLA

Rushdie, Salman. *The Satanic Verses*. Random House. 2008.

CHICAGO MANUAL

Rushdie, Salman. *The Satanic Verses*. New York: Random House. 2008.